The Crown Demands but the Heart Desires

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37246627.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam & Adora (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam/Teela, Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Sir Tao (She-Ra), Percival (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Minster Cloudfoot (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam, Teela (He-Man), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Norwyn (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Political Alliances, Political Campaigns, War, Angst, Grief/Mourning, Alternate Universe - Historical, Lost Love, Marriage of Convenience, Marriage Proposal, POV Catra (She-Ra), Magicats (She-Ra), Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Miscommunication, King Catra, Knight Adora (She-Ra), Secret Relationship, Alternate Universe - Royalty, Presumed Dead, Reconciliation, Tags Are Hard, not beta read we die like men, POV Adora (She-Ra), Action, Alternate Universe - Medieval, Alternative Universe - Kingdom, Alliances, Alternate Universe - Politics

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of The Crown Demands But the Heart Desires Medieval AU

Stats:
Published: 2022-02-19 Completed: 2022-03-25 Words: 48,349 Chapters: 6/6

The Crown Demands but the Heart Desires
Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37246627.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam & Adora (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam/Teela, Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Sir Tao (She-Ra), Percival (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Minster Cloudfoot (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam, Teela (He-Man), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Norwyn (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Political Alliances, Political Campaigns, War, Angst, Grief/Mourning, Alternate Universe - Historical, Lost Love, Marriage of Convenience, Marriage Proposal, POV Catra (She-Ra), Magicats (She-Ra), Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Miscommunication, King Catra, Knight Adora (She-Ra), Secret Relationship, Alternate Universe - Royalty, Presumed Dead, Reconciliation, Tags Are Hard, not beta read we die like men,

POV Adora (She-Ra), Action, Alternate Universe - Medieval, Alternative Universe - Kingdom, Alliances, Alternate Universe - Politics

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of The Crown Demands But the Heart Desires Medieval AU

Stats:
Published: 2022-02-19 Completed: 2022-03-25 Words: 48,349 Chapters: 6/6

The Crown Demands but the Heart Desires

by ResFlower

Summary

"Tao, she isn't dead. I would know if she died, I would feel it in my bones. She is out there somewhere—even if- if we can’t find her." She could feel tears on her cheeks. If she were in front of anyone but Tao, she would be mortified.

"My liege, it's been well over two years. We searched all Etheria and there has not been a single sighting of Queen Adora. You need to let her go." He breached protocol and pulled Catra into a tight hug.

“Your people wish to see you happy, Catra." Tao murmured as he wrapped his tail around her waist, holding her close. Catra smiled at Tao, a sad thing that didn't reach her eyes.

"I'm not sure that is in the cards for me anymore Tao. Right now, we need to focus on defeating the Horde and bringing peace to Etheria. Happiness will have to wait."

OR

Queen Adora is long presumed dead. King Catra's only viable political option to defeat the Horde makes her stomach roll: a marriage uniting Halfmoon with Bright Moon. When King Catra's decision coincides with the appearance of the legendary warrior She-ra, the choice becomes harder than ever. Medieval/Political Warfare AU.

Notes

This is the first multi-chapter fic I am posting and the second I have written. I hope y'all enjoy it!

See the end of the work for more notes

Swords of Death

Two angry voices ping-ponged back and forth in Halfmoon's war room, the loud echoes augmenting Catra's already piercing headache.

The council meeting room was grand, it had lush curtains that kept out most outdoor light and curious eyes. Many of the rooms in the Halfmoon castle had dimmer lights than were typically used in other Etherian palaces, given that magicats were more sensitive to light.

The room had a large table for all council members to sit at as well as a dais at the end where Catra usually stood. During long meetings like this, she usually pulled up a seat at the table. Today, she leaned over the dais, almost slumped from the exhaustion.

"If we don't approve the irrigation system, we won't be able to maintain the crop generation in that sector, which could lead to a food shortage." Adam slapped the table with more force than necessary to emphasize his point, a vein in his forehead pulsing.

"That would be a compelling argument—if the cost of this irrigation system could be recouped through the food sales—" Teela leaned closer to Adam, a vicious snarl plastered on her face "—or even if we had proof that it is more effective than the system in place now." She finished archly, green eyes flashing.

They were circling back to their original points. *Again*. Catra bit back a groan.

"This is why we shouldn't have humans on the Halfmoon council. It's a disgrace all around." Percival's nasally voice was purposefully pitched too low for the two bickering humans to hear.

Catra let out a warning hiss in her cousin's direction that no magicat would challenge. She then made eye contact with Tao, who rolled his eyes at Percival's unnecessary comment. Her heart

always warmed at Tao’s reactions in the council meetings. Tao was her longest advisor, Catra remembered watching his reactions at meetings since she was a child when her mother sat on the throne.

Although Percival’s blatantly discriminatory remark was unacceptable, she didn’t want to hear Teela and Adam debate the irrigation system a second longer. Teela and Adam had a bad habit of constantly fighting over the most absurd projects and Catra was on her last nerve.

After the council’s discussions of taxes, the war effort against the Horde, and public complaints, she was done. It felt like her brain was steaming. Catra had languished in this council meeting for over three hours. She refused to let it go on for a second longer.

"Clearly, you've thought deeply on this issue councilman Adam and councilwoman Teela.” Catra delivered a blistering glare to both. Teela had the decency to look cowed. “You both are to submit reports explaining the impact of switching to this irrigation system and advocate for your respective positions. I will decide once I have been fully briefed on the issue."

She could feel her tail twitching to her side. Catra tried to keep her frustration out of her voice. From the smirk playing on the edge of Adam’s mouth, she was unsuccessful.

"If that is all, I will adjourn this meeting." Catra looked for her ceremonial bell to put her duties behind her and finally get dinner.

Tao motioned for the floor and Catra raised an eyebrow at him. "Your majesty, I believe we have one more issue that the council will find pressing," He stated, his tail thrashing as he averted his piercing stare to the ground.

Catra stared at her advisor with a frown on her face. She found it odd that Tao would have something to discuss that he did not bring up with her directly when they had afternoon tea yesterday.

Tao was arguably the second most influential politician in Halfmoon, behind only Catra herself. He was the lead councilman when Catra’s mother decided that Catra’s birth would mark the opening of Halfmoon and the magicats return to the surface after almost a century in hiding.

"Go on, then." Catra ceded the floor to Tao. She trusted him.

Tao took a deep breath, sending Catra a soft apologetic look. "I think this council and your majesty should consider the topic of your marital status." The entire council was stock still, not even a breath could be heard around the table.

Even Percival looked shocked, ears twitching as if trying to rehear Tao’s words. Adam's jaw clenched, his eyes flying to meet Catra's. This was a personal matter to him.

Catra let out a disbelieving huff. She could feel her tail lashing behind her. Catra’s tone was clipped as she said, "that is absolutely out of the question and will not be discussed in front of the council."

"Your majesty, I know you find this topic unsettling but there are many possible political alliances we could forge to improve Halfmoon's position in the war efforts." Catra saw a few council members nodding along, mainly Percival and Cloudfoot, a levelheaded advisor. "A marriage between you and Princess Glimmer or Princess Scorpia comes to mind.” Tao continued, still averting his gaze occasionally. “You know them well and uniting with one of their kingdoms would place us in a better position to defend Halfmoon and Etheria at large."

No other council member dared to speak, all eyeing Catra. She tried her best to not sink her claws into the dais in front of her.

"I have a queen, councilman you know this better than anyone. You officiated my wedding and performed my coronation." Catra curtly dismissed Tao, her back ramrod straight as she sounded the

ceremonial bell. "The meeting is adjourned. Councilman Tao accompany me to my study."

Tao and Catra walked the hallways in absolute silence, Catra fuming as they passed servants and guards, moving further into the castle until they reached the King's chambers. The moment the large wood door closed, Catra tore into Tao.

"How dare you!" She exploded. "I expected something like this from Percival— not you!" Catra walked towards one of the windows in the room, needing distance between them.

Tao looked more like a patient father than a seasoned advisor. His shock of white hair crept into his ear tufts, giving him a grandfatherly appearance. He raised an eyebrow at Catra's rage.

"That is a rather distasteful comparison, especially given your cousin's comment today." Catra rolled her eyes at that. Tao sighed, speaking plaintively. "Your majesty, what I said at the council meeting is true. A union between Halfmoon and the right kingdom is a good strategic move." He eyed Catra carefully. "And you need companionship. It's plain for everyone to see that the loneliness you bear weighs heavy on you. As a result, you do too much. When was the last time you truly rested?"

Tao's eyes are filled with concern, his tail weaving behind him in a rhythmic fashion. Catra pulled up the sleeve of her red tunic, as she thumbed the golden pin she still wore every day.

"The loneliness I bear has one cure, Tao. I will never be complete without my heart. Marrying Princess Glimmer or Princess Scorpia would not make me any less lonely." Catra ignored his comment on rest. That was a lost cause with the war afoot. She scoffed. "Besides, everyone knows that Glimmer is in love with her Master Archer and Scorpia is courting the eldest princess of Plumeria." She walked to sit behind her desk.

Tao gave her a long-suffering look. "Bright Moon's traditions ban a union between Princess Glimmer and the Master Archer and

Queen Angella would balk at making an exception—" Tao raised an eyebrow "—and Princess Scorpia always held a torch for you.” Catra’s ears lowered as she thought of her friend’s long-time infatuation. “The Queens of the Scorpioni Kingdom know a union with Halfmoon would be more beneficial than Plumeria, given our formidable army. They just don't know a union with Halfmoon could be a possibility."

Catra slammed her hand on her desk, quills and parchment landing in disarray. "Because it’s not on the table, Tao! I am married! I did not take my vows lightly and I will not sully them by discussing this farce." Catra could feel herself shaking. Tao rounded the desk and placed a gentle hand on Catra’s shoulder. She swiped it away with her tail.

"Young one, the vows are only until death." He gently reminded.

Catra’s eyes watered. "Tao, she isn't dead. I would know if she died, I would feel it in my bones. She is out there somewhere—even if—if we can’t find her." She could feel tears on her cheeks. If she were in front of anyone but Tao, she would be mortified.

“I wish I could bring Queen Adora back to you, child.” Tao gave her a look that echoed his own grief. She knew he missed Adora too. "My liege, it's been well over two years. We searched all Etheria and there has not been a single sighting of Queen Adora. You need to let her go." He breached protocol and pulled Catra into a tight hug. “Your people wish to see you happy, Catra," Tao murmured as he wrapped his tail around her waist, holding her close. Catra smiled at Tao, a sad thing that didn't reach her eyes. He was always her closest family behind closed doors.

Catra steps out of the hug. "I'm not sure that is in the cards for me anymore Tao. Right now, we need to focus on defeating the Horde and bringing peace to Etheria. Happiness will have to wait." She felt the heaviness she always did when she thought of how much ground the Horde had gained.

"If the focus is defeating the Horde, we need bonds that unite us with the other kingdoms. Halfmoon has no strong diplomatic allies given that we have only reestablished contact with the surface in the last twenty-five years." Tao's jaw was set in that stubborn way when he knew his political tactic was best. He took in Catra's weepy eyes and droopy tail, and his expression softened. "I understand the burden of lost love Catra. I saw it when your mother died of a broken heart after your father. I stand before you a man who has lost his own love." Now Tao sounded close to tears, speaking of his late husband. "I could not bear for you to follow that path of misery, young one. I know there is more for you." His voice was forceful.

"You know I love you Tao and I value your counsel above all others. I will consider your words but listen to me. Even if I took another wife, it would not be a love match." Catra averted her eyes, gaze distant. "I am not so blinded by emotions that I do not see the merits of a union with another kingdom, but I cannot stomach making vows to anyone else, even if I do not make them with my heart."

The thought alone made Catra feel like the biggest traitor on all Etheria. She knew from the moment Adora agreed to marry her that there would be no one else for her. She never expected to be without her this young.

"I advise you Catra, but you are King. Make your own decisions. Be the leader you were born to be." Tao smiled kindly at her.

Catra eyed Tao. "I'm going to rest. It has been a long, trying day." She flicked her tail in annoyance. "In large part because of the stunt you just pulled in my council meeting." She bared her fangs at him for good measure.

He was unphased. "It's been a trying day because Teela and Adam try to resolve their bedroom problems in the war room." Tao raised an eyebrow as if daring Catra to say the contrary is true.

It was well known around the castle that Teela and Adam had some weird pining relationship. Catra flicked her ear dismissively, sidestepping Tao's commentary.

"Next time you want to talk about something like that, come to me directly." Catra stated seriously.

Tao rolled his eyes and flicked one of his ears back at her. "I'll come to you directly when you stop avoiding me when you know I want to tell you something you don't want to hear."

Catra chuckled at that. "That is an astute observation councilman Tao. Very wise." She faked solemness as she delivered the line. She and Tao said their goodbyes, their fight mostly mended.

Catra made her way to her bed chamber. She had a large bed with many pillows for when she felt like nesting. The room was largely undecorated, save for a few knickknacks on a smaller desk she kept for the days she did not wish to work from her study. All and all, it was a spartan space for a regent.

Catra stripped out of her clothes and laid down. Once again, Catra desperately wished for Adora to appear to her. She missed her so much. She vividly remembered the first time she saw Adora, a knight who, at twenty, was the youngest appointed guard to Princess Glimmer. On that day, Catra, Prince of Halfmoon, felt dumbstruck and swore to herself that she would get to know the knight that always stood at Glimmer's side.

And she did. In some ways, she had known Adora better than she knew herself. Now, without her, she was adrift, resigned to think only of her kingdom. It was the only thing that could still be saved.

Some days she felt better. Like the loss of Adora was manageable, something she would learn to live with as everyone claimed. Other days, like today, she felt as if her heart was torn asunder, and nothing could ever fill the longing that seeped into her very soul.

Like many days before, Catra laid on Adora's side of the bed and cried until she fell asleep, exhausted from ruling a kingdom at war and mourning her wife.

The Halfmoon castle was tense as news from the war spread like wildfire. Lord Hordak himself laid siege to Bright Moon's capital city for three days until Bright Moon's forces rallied back.

"Is there any hope for the Alliance to respond?" Tao asked Catra.

Catra growled ears pinned back as she looked at her correspondence. "No. I wrote at least a dozen officials from different kingdoms hoping to host an emergency Princess Alliance meeting to discuss an aid package to Bright Moon." Catra's hands shook with rage. "All the responses were platitudes about how the next meeting was close enough. It's a month away Tao!" The reality is that no one wanted to shift their schedule. "The ineptitude is astounding, it's incredible to think these people could lead even one person, let alone whole communities." She ranted on, tail whipping behind her.

"Your majesty, be at ease. That's why we are having this emergency Halfmoon council meeting." Tao comforted.

"Yes, the Princess Alliance might refuse to act, but I won't allow Halfmoon to follow their lead." Catra felt a well of determination rise from within her. "If you want something done right, do it yourself," She muttered under her breath.

She and Tao walked together from the King's study to the war room. All her council members wore somber faces as she called the meeting to order. "You all know why we are meeting today. I want to coordinate a relief package for Bright Moon. I would like advice on how to most effectively do this." She announced as she looked around at her advisors. "We got word that the siege halted today. I would like for a Halfmoon presence to be in Bright Moon as soon as possible." She switched her gaze to the reports, trying to get a sense of what aid would be most needed.

“The stabilization of Bright Moon is very important to all of Etheria, but especially to Halfmoon, given that Bright Moon is our neighbor to the north.” Tao intoned. “I agree with the King that we must act to help our ally in a time of need,” He concluded.

Percival sneered. “You would think that old man.” Percival’s claws tapped on the table as he spoke. “We need to think of Halfmoon first. If we send a substantial aid package, what will we do when the Horde brings its army to Halfmoon’s door next?” He asked rhetorically.

“It won’t matter much if they come to Halfmoon next. If Bright Moon falls, all hope is lost.” Cloudfoot pointed out, brow furrowed in concern and ears pinned back.

“If we send aid to Bright Moon now, we will be seen for what we are: a competent kingdom with a formidable army and lush resources. We can assert our influence and our will there.” Catra added. “For all of those reasons and it is simply the right thing to do.” Catra tipped her tail to the side in a condescending manner. Percival slammed his hand on the table.

“You are obsessed with getting approval from every kingdom except Halfmoon!” Percival’s tail jerked behind him as he pointed an accusing finger at Catra.

“The people of Halfmoon love me, Percival. Most of them don’t even know your name. There is a reason for that.” Catra stated coldly staring down her cousin. “I have listened to your objections regarding the relief mission, but I won’t tolerate personal attacks.” She turned her gaze to the rest of the council. “We are going to Bright Moon and that is final.” Catra shifted her gaze. “Teela, I want you to oversee the creation of our aid package as swiftly as possible. Adam, you will accompany me so we can personally deliver it to Bright Moon.”

She thought it best to put the two council members who used to be Bright Mooners in charge of the efforts. Catra stared at her council, daring any of them to challenge her.

"This meeting is adjourned. I will provide a report when we return from Bright Moon."

Two days later, Catra was trekking to Bright Moon. She rode on horseback because reports indicated that the roads to Bright Moon were too damaged to travel safely over carriage.

As the Halfmoon contingent got to the outskirts of Bright Moon, the smell of rotting corpses and ash burned Catra's nose. The entire eastern side of the city had been decimated to rubble.

The destitute and hungry filled the street, watching the magicats as they rode into the city. Catra's heart broke in the face of so much suffering. Only one thought circled her mind, setting her on edge. If the Horde could do this in Bright Moon, there was nothing stopping them from doing it everywhere else.

Adam pulled up next to Catra's horse, eyes wide in despair as he took in the wreckage of the place he used to call home. "I can't believe they managed this. I know that the Horde has been gaining strength but—" Adam's voice strangled on his words and died out. He tugged on his blond hair, frustration evident.

"I know." Catra's face is set in a grim line.

The closer they traveled to the castle the less damage. Bright Moon's forces obviously tried to protect the castle most. Even still, one of the castle walls was breached. Adam was appalled, eyes like saucers. It must be even more striking for him as a former Bright Moon knight.

Magicat soldiers offloaded the large pallets in coordination with Bright Moon administrators as Catra walked to the main reception hall inside the Bright Moon castle. Catra was glad, it would be nice to see a familiar face.

She expected Queen Angella, but instead, there stood Princess Glimmer.

Catra grinned at her old friend. “Hey, Sparkles.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes fondly at Catra. “Catra, Adam. It’s so nice to see you both, even if these aren’t ideal circumstances.” The mood became somber at the mention of recent Bright Moon events. Still, she put on a brave face. “I’m sorry my mother isn’t here to greet you. She is leading the reconstruction efforts, otherwise, she would be here. Bright Moon thanks you for your swift response.” Glimmer drops some of her formality, her voice softened. “Really. Thank you for showing up for us. It means a lot.” She held Catra’s gaze.

“Of course. Adora is of Bright Moon. She loved this place and she loved you, this is the least I could do.” The *in her memory* remained unsaid between them. “And Adam wouldn’t let me do anything different either, as one of my council members.” Catra teased, trying to keep the mood at least somewhat light.

Adam gave Glimmer a warm smile. “Of course, we will always come to aid Bright Moon, your majesty.”

Catra turned to Adam, looking up at the towering man. “Adam, can you oversee the unloading of the goods while I talk with Glimmer privately?”

He nodded and gave a low bow before making a beeline for the exit.

“Let’s have tea to discuss the details.” Glimmer suggested.

She led Catra to her study. Like everything about Glimmer her study was bright and cheerful. She had an area set up with a kettle, teacups, and a few biscuits-clearly meant to receive guests. Catra took a seat in a comfortable armchair.

“Obviously, we didn’t have a lot of time to put this relief package together, but we figured that speed trumps thoroughness under these circumstances.” Glimmer nodded in understanding. “We brought food, medical supplies, blankets, tents, amongst other things. We are also prepared to leave half of our soldiers, around

one hundred of them, to shore up security for the time being. We think we can spare them for at least two weeks.” Glimmer handed Catra a plate with biscuits and a teacup. “We are also open to input on what else is needed here. I imagine construction supplies would not be remiss?” Catra ventured a guess.

“I can put together a list and Halfmoon can contribute to it as it is able.” Glimmer suggested.

Catra shifted her weight backward. “Although Halfmoon is prepared to offer more aid, it would like for the next aid package to be in conjunction with the Princess Alliance.”

Glimmer glared at her tea. “Oh yes, the Princess Alliance has been so very helpful and is racing to help Bright Moon in its time of need.” Glimmer’s words dripped with sarcasm and vitriol. Catra veered slightly off-topic.

“Have you thought about representing Bright Moon in the Alliance?” Catra was genuinely curious why Bright Moon was sending its lead general, Juliet, instead of its princess. Glimmer sighed in exasperation, putting down her teacup.

“I want to represent Bright Moon at the meetings, but my mother is hesitant to send me, she worries the council would push back.” Glimmer held her shoulders tensely. “They're already displeased with me as it is because I asked them to change the marriage laws.” Glimmer admitted. "Again."

“Are they finally allowing you to marry Bow, then?”

Glimmer groaned, putting her face in her hand. “No. The head councilman, you remember Norwyn, don't you? Well, he is so stuck in the old ways I wouldn’t be surprised if he hasn’t been informed that the wheel was invented. He refuses to let me marry anyone who is not a descendant of a royal line.”

Catra scoffed. “I remember Norwyn. Stuff fellow.” He always judged Catra’s choice to marry Adora. “I’m sorry he is keeping you from your love. We both know how rare finding love is, especially

for people like us." Catra sent Glimmer a pained smile as she thought of how lucky she felt when Halfmoon's council approved her union with Adora.

"That is not new for us, unfortunately. I'm more concerned with the attack right now. I wish there was more we could do against the Horde. They struck our home and we don't fight back? It's unacceptable." Glimmer clasped her hands together tightly, rage evident in her expression.

"I don't understand it either. If the Horde can attack Bright Moon, the crown jewel of Etheria, the largest and wealthiest Kingdom, I don't see what hope there is for the rest of us." Catra vented her frustrations.

"I agree. The Horde wants all Etheria to bend at the knee, and it is willing to do whatever is necessary to achieve it. They are an existential threat." Glimmer picked up her teacup again, steam no longer wafting off of it.

"The problem is that the Princess Alliance is a mess and it has not assessed this threat as it should," Catra said frankly, not mincing words. She continued. "I know you haven't been to a meeting but if you have seen how people haggle in the lower markets you have seen the level of organization our highest interkingdom body has." Glimmer snorted at that. Catra persisted.

"I think it would be good for you to convince your mother to let you represent Bright Moon. Your kingdom is the oldest and is the largest in terms of both land and resources. It would be the natural pick to provide the leadership the Alliance needs." Catra urged.

"Then why does it matter if I go or if our General represents us?" Glimmer raised a challenging eyebrow.

"No offense to General Juliet, but between her lower rank and her lack of charisma she is not representing Bright Moon in a forceful way." Juliet's oatmeal personality could put anyone to sleep.

“Someone needs to step up, Glimmer. We can’t let the Horde beat us out of our own kingdoms.” Catra warned.

Glimmer's lips set to a thin line as her tea grew cold.

After she returned from the relief mission, Catra revisited Tao’s plea for her to take a wife, turning the idea in her head. It all came back to the battle at Bright Moon.

She looked out the window of her private study. She could still see the plumes of smoke rising beyond the whispering woods, where Catra knew Bright Moon's capital to be, even though the battle was long done.

A union with Bright Moon would give Halfmoon the status it needed to allow Catra to lead the Princess Alliance. It would grant Catra power to make decisions that could ultimately bring the Horde to heel. It would also give Glimmer a seat in the Princess Alliance, and Catra knew that Glimmer would do well if given half the chance.

The more she thought of it the more it made sense, but her heart still rebelled against the thought. She hadn’t given up on the idea that Adora was alive, but as the third anniversary of her disappearance came and went, Catra’s hopes grew dimmer than ever.

She closed the book she was reading, pushing it towards the edge of her large dark wood desk. She heard her door open.

"You know she would never fault you for it."

Catra turned around not expecting company. She relaxed when she saw Adam. "Who are you talking about Adam?" There had never been much formality between her and her brother-in-law.

Adam's eyes were serious. "Adora. She wouldn't fault you for marrying again. She knew you were destined to be King before she fell in love with you. She would want you to put your people

first. This attack on Bright Moon changes everything." He acknowledged the elephant in the room.

"How did you know I was thinking about marriage?" Adam shot her a goofy smile, the one that reminded her of Adora. Sometimes it hurt too much to look at Adam. His eyes and smile were the same as hers.

"Remember sister dearest, I know you. You put me on your council for a reason." He chided.

Catra placed her head in her hands, running her fingers through her mane. "My stomach rolls at the thought, Adam. Even if she is gone, I can't imagine being with anyone else. But you're right, every day the Horde grows stronger, and we are no closer to adequately responding to the threat it poses." She rolled her eyes. "In large part because the so-called Princess Alliance is an alliance in name only."

"It is a terrible situation to be sure." Adam recognized as he sat in front of Catra. She turned her gaze to her advisor and brother, looking for answers.

"Do you believe she is still out there Adam? Alive and well?"

Adam looked to the floor, lower lip trembling. "No. I don't hold out any hope for my sister. There is nothing on this planet that could have kept her from us for three years." That was a heavy truth, one Catra tried not to think of often. "Part of me rejects the idea that Adora is dead because I think that somehow, as her twin brother, I would know but I can't ignore the reality anymore Catra." Adam's hulking hands formed tight fists.

Catra let out a shuddering breath. "I think I have to do this. Tao is right, we need someone to lead, and no one else is poised to do it. Etheria hangs in the balance." Adam reached out to hold Catra's hand. He understood. He lost pieces of himself when Adora disappeared, same as Catra.

"I know how hard this will be and I am with you. No matter what, I am on your side, Catra."

She gripped Adam's hand tightly. "I know. I don't know what I would have done if you had refused to join my court when Adora disappeared. I know leaving Bright Moon was difficult for you." Catra looked at Adam gratefully.

Adam corrected her. "We both need each other because we love her. The offer to join your court was a lifeline, it gave me a purpose. I am of Halfmoon now, even if I lack adorable ears and dangerous claws." He teased lightly.

Catra laughed at that. Adam always knew which of his stupid jokes Catra would find funny. She bopped his nose with her tail. “Don’t forget the tail, blondie.” Catra felt herself sober. “It feels like I’m giving up on her. Like I’m saying goodbye.” Catra softly whispered.

“I know what you mean. I feel like I’m giving up on her telling you that it’s alright to do this.” Adam took a shuddering breath and stood tall to his full height, over two heads taller than Catra. “But we know who Adora is, she always wanted what was best for Etheria. She always led through her responsibilities. She wouldn’t blame you for doing the same.” Catra looked out again to the plumes of smoke.

Catra approached Tao the next day in his office. Tao was having his afternoon tea, book opened as he read intently. Over the years, she found him this way in that very same office countless times. It was quintessentially Tao. Catra interrupted his silence.

"Let's say I were to remarry. What would we need to do?" Tao looked up at Catra steadily and closed his book.

“Good afternoon, my liege. Why yes, my book was most interesting but of course, I have a spare moment to speak to my favorite pupil. What was the question?” Tao’s sarcasm was

scathing but well deserved. He was a stickler for manners. Catra was too riled up from the topic she was broaching to appreciate it now.

“I think I might throw up if I have to ask again,” Catra whispered, ears pinned back. Tao’s face softened into empathy, as it always did when they discussed Adora. His explanation was straightforward.

"You would declare Adora deceased, given that she disappeared three years ago. The laws state this can be done within a year of someone's disappearance so it should not be a large problem. At that point, you would be a widow and free to wed."

Free to wed sounded like an oxymoron at this point, a marriage would only feel like more chains, more obligations she bore in the name of Halfmoon. She never resented her duties but she resented this act more than anything in the world.

"Would we have to have a funeral?" Catra could feel her throat closing in.

Tao gave her another pitying look. "No, a funeral would not be required. We have the remembrance event on the day of her disappearance and that would suffice." Tao hesitated. "If you would like to have a funeral for her majesty, however, it could be arranged."

Catra’s tail jerked. "No- no. Not right now. I don't know that I'll ever be ready for that. If we don't need it then we won’t have it." Catra didn't know if she could ever put herself back together again, but she knew it would be impossible if she had to go through that ordeal. She hoped Adora would forgive her if she really was gone.

"Not to be crass, but it is just paperwork, your majesty. It doesn't have to mean anything if you don't want it to.” Tao stated softly. “It doesn't mean you've given up."

Catra looked at one of the paintings that Tao had hung up behind his desk, avoiding his eyes. "Doesn't it Tao? If I declare her dead and remarry isn't that exactly what I'm telling all Etheria." She looked down, distressed.

Tao patiently found Catra's gaze. "Young one, you can move forward in your life and still honor those who have loved you best. I know her majesty would not want to see you like this." Catra remained silent because she didn't have a response. Adora wouldn't want her to be miserable, but she probably wouldn't want her marrying someone else either.

"If you were to remarry, who would you broker such an arrangement with?" Tao asked.

Catra was resolute, she knew exactly what her plan was. "Princess Glimmer. Extending this kind of offer, if received favorably, would be an olive branch in a dark time in Bright Moon's history. I know Glimmer has the political wherewithal to lead the Alliance with me." Catra listed her reasons soundly. Tao eyed her carefully.

"It would never be a love match between you." He pointed out.

Catra's face was grim. "No, it wouldn't. I don't want to give any other potential suitor false expectations. I know Glimmer will understand that." She gripped one of the extra teacups of Tao's set. "There would never be a love match for me with anyone Tao. Not again." She put the teacup back in its place.

"If that is what you think is best, your majesty." Tao offered, taking the emptied teacup from Catra.

"Quietly prepare the documents needed. I am going to the next Alliance meeting in the Scorpioni Kingdom. When I return, I'll convene the council to announce my intentions to marry Glimmer and prepare a trip to Bright Moon." Adora was about to be declared dead and Etheria needed Catra to lead. At any cost.

Catra sat through the Princess Alliance meeting with a heavy heart. She received a missive from Glimmer that, try as she might, Angella would not allow her to attend the Alliance meeting.

A part of her hoped that maybe having Glimmer representing Bright Moon could change the dynamic enough to make the meeting at least halfway functional. If that was the case, perhaps Catra could discard the idea of marriage.

"I think that if Halfmoon already took it upon itself to send aid, we should focus on a military response to the attack." Netossa proposed, pulling back one of her white hairs from her face.

"The aid to Bright Moon wasn't sufficient! We should think of sending our own package." Protested Scorpia. She glanced at her companion. "Princess Perfuma, do you want to weigh in on this?"

Perfuma stared at the group with wide eyes. "Oh no, I'm not sure which is the best course of action. I reserve my decision for later." She nodded to herself as if this isn't what she says anytime she's asked to provide a decision.

Catra suppressed the urge to groan. Princess Perfuma never decided, Duke Netossa and Princess Scorpia were always at odds, and Entrapta sat in a corner and never had an opinion unless the discussion dealt with technology.

"It doesn't have to be one or the other. We can decide to do both." Catra stated archly, tired of the bickering.

"Oh, great another option to consider." Queen Mermista snarked. The meeting dragged on for two hours and they were no closer to reaching a resolution.

"Why don't we table this discussion until next time? We can see what makes the most sense then." Spinerella suggested, her eyes flying between her wife and the other ALliance members.

"If that's what the Alliance decides, I'll send the report to Bright Moon," Juliet stated drily. The meeting ended.

Catra tried to keep her emotions off her face. The Princess Alliance was, frankly, a mess. They were all leaders of their own lands, but the coalition of princesses did not have a hierarchy when making joint decisions.

If she needed any further convincing that she had to take the reins of power somehow, this meeting was the final nail in the coffin.

Catra followed Juliet out of the room. "General Juliet. Please inform Queen Angella that I will be visiting Bright Moon as soon as possible to discuss further ways Halfmoon could be of help at this time." She was ready to put her plan into motion.

"As you all know, a few months ago Councilman Tao brought up the idea that I remarry." Catra started the council meeting with an unsteady voice. "I am announcing my intentions to ask Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon to marry me." The words felt like ash in Catra's mouth.

Most of the council members looked stunned the disbelief in the air palpable. Cloudfoot's mouth was so agape Catra feared he had broken his jaw.

Teela's jaw on the other hand was tightly wound, anger flashing in her eyes. "What of Adora?" Teela stated, words cool but her eyes betrayed her. Teela had been one of Adora's closest friends in Halfmoon.

Catra felt nauseous. "Although it is my fervent wish to be wrong about such matters, Queen Adora has been declared dead given the length of her disappearance." She could barely get the words out of her mouth. Not a sound could be heard in the war room. Adam wiped at his eyes surreptitiously. Catra stared at Teela, willing her to understand. "I will always love Adora, but we need a stronger partnership with Bright Moon. It is a sound strategic decision, and I cannot stop myself from performing my duty any longer." Catra defended her decision.

Percival’s scoff sounded out throughout the war room. “Once again, you sully our bloodline with a human. And for what? To further involve Halfmoon in a war that we wouldn’t have been a party to if we had stayed underground as our ancestors meant for us.” He was practically screeching by the end of his tantrum. “What we should be discussing is a return underground. It would provide us refuge and then we wouldn’t have to sink to the level of allowing another human Halfmoon Queen.” Percival spat, disgust clear on his face.

Catra bared her teeth. She had enough of Percival, and she wouldn't allow a word of slander against Adora. “If you want to make those decisions, dear cousin, I’m afraid you were born to the wrong mother.” Percival flinched at the reminder that he was next in line for the throne until Catra was born. “If you want to lead Halfmoon back underground, all magicats with their tails between their legs you will have to do it over my dead body.” She hissed. “So, unless you want to challenge me for the throne in a duel, kindly refer yourself to the agenda for the meeting and stop this nonsense talk of hiding underground like cowards.” Catra finished smoothly, gathering her composure again. “Who is in favor of approving the proposal?

Unsurprisingly, Percival kept his eyes averted and refused to raise his hand. One by one almost all the other council members gave their approval. Teela’s eyes widen as she saw Adam vote in favor of approving the proposal. Adam was not looking at Teela, he looked at Catra, pain in his eyes.

“Adora would have wanted what is good for Etheria,” Adam announced as he voted his conscious.

Teela’s eyes looked like flaming steel as she crossed her arms, a clear signal of her vote. “I respect your decision as my King to do as you must. I can’t vote for something I find personally intolerable. There must be other ways to accomplish what we seek.” She implored the council.

Catra nodded in understanding. Ultimately, Teela and Percival's dissent didn't stop Catra from receiving the council's approval. Although she should feel victorious, all she felt was dread.

Two weeks later, the trip to Bright Moon was made under the guise of following up Halfmoon's relief mission. Even a month after the attack, the destruction was still vaster than Catra remembered.

From her carriage, she could see the dilapidated buildings, she felt the carriage swing to avoid huge holes in the road. The outer limits of Bright Moon's capital looked like they had been ravaged by war for years, not under siege for a few days.

As they traveled closer to the core of the city where Bright Moon's castle lay, the destruction lessened, and Catra observed Bright Moon's splendor. The buildings all shone beautiful colors and the roads looked as if they refracted rainbows. It was an odd but wonderful sight. The crumbled east wing wall was still not fully repaired, a stark reminder of the Horde's attack and how far it penetrated the city.

Once again, Glimmer received Catra. As Glimmer discussed the tolls the Horde attack took on the kingdom and what Bright Moon has accomplished to address the damage, Catra decided to make her offer as soon as possible. She would only be in Bright Moon for a week and negotiating a marriage proposal between two kingdoms took time.

"Glimmer, may we speak privately." Catra requested, nerves rumbling in her gut.

Glimmer smiled brightly at Catra. "Of course, Catra! Let me have someone bring us tea." She directed a servant to fetch the hot water, leaves, and honey.

"I have a proposal for you. Something to aid the war. But I didn't want to bring it to your mother without discussing it with you

first."

Glimmer furrowed her brow and Catra understood. Although Glimmer and Catra got along, Catra and Angella discussed matters of state as the two respective regents. Catra had never addressed any official business with Glimmer directly. Catra cleared her throat, knowing her next words would make her intentions clear.

"Has your mother changed her stance on allowing Bow to court you?"Catra hedged, deciding that there would be no need to bing this up if Glimmer could marry Bow.

Glimmer eyed Catra suspiciously. "No, nothing has changed since the last time we spoke. What does that have to do with the war?" She asked.

She took a deep breath, deciding to be forthright, "It is a marriage proposal, Glimmer. A union between Bright Moon and Halfmoon. Between you and I."

Glimmer looked green in the face. "Catra. You can't be serious. Marriage?" She whispered, disbelief coloring her voice.

"Glim, you can't have Bow as your husband and keep your crown. Adora has been gone for three years now. We're losing to the Horde so badly. Look at what they have done to your capital! Bright Moon seemed untouchable, but it wasn't." Catra's voice cracked. "I feel like it will kill me to do this Glimmer. I wish to never wed again, to be loyal to Adora's memory forever. But we are friends and I think we could be partners." Catra saw Glimmer's eyes widen at that. "Don't misunderstand. I won't stand between you and Bow. I'm not asking for your love. I want your support to end this war and an understanding that a marriage between us would be a way to achieve this end."

Glimmer looked at Catra with hard eyes. "Adora was one of my closest friends, Catra. There was a time when she was my only confidant. She was my knight! My guard! How could I betray her

like this? How could you?" Glimmer spit the last words out like an accusation.

Catra laughed with no humor. “Trust me, whatever lowness you think of me now, I’ve thought it a thousand times as I considered this idea.” She tried a different approach. “It was a conversation with Adam that convinced me to bring this to your attention. He reminded me that Adora believed in protecting the innocent above all else. He said she wouldn't blame me for brokering a political marriage to bring peace to Etheria."

Glimmer snorted. "Adam said that? I didn't know we were allowing him to have thoughts now." The running joke was that Adam was the dumber but prettier twin. Catra always disagreed with half of that statement for obvious reasons. "What about Bow?" Glimmer whimpered.

Catra reached out and held Glimmer’s hand in a comforting gesture. "That's why I wanted to talk to you first. I know this is a big decision and I expect that you'll discuss it with Bow before I receive an answer. If we married, Bow would come with us wherever we are and you two would be together.” Catra reassured. “I love you both and I refuse to stand between you. If Angella would let you pursue him the way you desired, we wouldn't be having this conversation right now." Catra backed away from Glimmer slowly, her proposal delivered. Now Glimmer needed space. "I won't bring it up with Queen Angella if you refuse me. I won't force your hand. But we need the Princess Alliance to be more than a gaggle of figureheads. We need military strategists, a collective war effort. I know you believe in these things as well.” Catra insisted, passionate as she thought of how they could turn the tides of the war.

“Together Bright Moon and Halfmoon could lead the initiative. I am offering you real power Glimmer.” She gestured out in the direction of the throne room. “Power that you will never have, wasting away behind your mother’s skirt in Bright Moon." Glimmer's eyes flashed at the idea, she had always advocated that the Princess Alliance needed to be stronger and

have a centralized army to take on the Horde. "I want you to lead Glimmer. Queen Angella has sidelined you for too long, trying to protect you from the realities of the war. I know you are ready." Catra stood at the door. "I'll be in Bright Moon for a week. If you don't give me an answer within that time, I will assume that my proposal has been rejected." Catra smirked. "No hard feelings Sparkles."

Glimmer relaxed at the childhood nickname. "I have a lot to think about. I promise I'll give you an answer regardless of what my decision may be." As Glimmer shut the door behind her, Catra left to find her room. She met her main objective she just hoped the outcome was successful.

The decision came three days later at a Bright Moon council meeting that Catra was invited to partake in as a gesture of goodwill. Bow sat as an advisor, with a clenched pen in his hand and a refusal to make eye contact with anyone at the broad round table. That was Catra's first sign that something was afoot.

Glimmer locked eyes with Catra from across the table. "Mother, I have a topic for discussion for the council."

Queen Angela perked at that, looking at Glimmer with interest. "Yes darling, of course. What would you like us to consider." She asked.

"A marriage between myself and King Catra, uniting our kingdoms in the face of the Horde threat." Everyone at the table was shocked, save for Bow and Catra. Their eyes met.

Catra tried to send a look that conveyed *I'm sorry that circumstances have made it convenient to marry the love of your life, I hope we can still be friends.* She didn't think it was successful.

"Glimmer, are you sure about this?" Queen Angella's voice was colored with worry. It was an open secret in Bright Moon that

Glimmer and Bow were together, although it was generally better hidden from the other kingdoms.

"Yes, mother. Unless you want to reconsider your position on other discussions we have had regarding my options for marriage as Princess of Bright Moon?"

Catra smirked realizing what Glimmer was doing. She was leveraging this political alliance as the last chance to force her mother's hand to allow her to marry Bow. Catra had to admire her political acumen. For Glimmer and Bow's sake, she hoped it worked, even if it ruined her diplomatic agenda.

Queen Angella's shoulders slumped, a rare sight.

Norwyn cut into the exchange. "Princess Glimmer, as the council has noted many times there are certain criteria a Bright Moon royal must look for in a partner when being wed. Criteria that King Catra meets but other persons—" Norwyn's eyes cut to glare at Bow "—do not. That is the council's final decision."

Angella stared at her daughter, lower lip trembling. "You know that I cannot do what you are implying Glimmer," She affirmed Norwyn's statement, hands tied.

Glimmer straightened her back. "Then yes, I am sure. It will give our peoples hope and it will provide our kingdoms with the standing required to unite Etheria against the Horde threat. I wish more than anything for this war to be over." She declared fervently.

"Is this something you have discussed with the Halfmoon contingent?" Angella prompted.

Catra smiled sheepishly at the older regent. "I brought the idea to Princess Glimmer's attention."

A ghost of a smile passed over Queen Angella's face. "I should have known you both would conspire against me." Although the words hinted at betrayal there was only fondness there. "This is

an enormous proposition. I would like the Halfmoon contingent to give us leave to discuss this freely in private."

Catra immediately stood up. "Of course, your grace. I will be in the Bright Moon gardens if you would like to call on me." She exited the meeting without further delay.

She loved the Bright Moon gardens, and she was glad when she heard they escaped relatively unscathed from the recent battle at Bright Moon. The gardens were littered with memories of when she first met Adora as a shy warrior, recently knighted to serve the Bright Moon crown and guard Princess Glimmer.

Adora had been stiff and formal the first few times they had met, but that never stopped Catra from wanting to know her better. She had never seen a woman so beautiful and refined, yet humble and strong. It took everything in her to not court her right away.

Catra’s daydreaming was interrupted by a familiar voice. "I was surprised to hear that you thought of union through marriage, your majesty." Queen Angella had just stepped into the gardens.

Catra would never get used to hearing that title from Queen Angella’s lips. She had been the regent at Bright Moon since before Catra was born. Catra dipped into a low bow as she greeted the Queen, a sign of respect for the elder stateswoman.

"I want to do what's right for Etheria. I think that Bright Moon and Princess Glimmer would be formidable allies in that cause. This war has taken enough from all of us." It was a common theory that the Horde took Adora captive and murdered her, although few spoke of it in Catra’s presence.

Queen Angella’s face suddenly looked older than it ever had, worry lines carved into her face like marble.

"I know what it is to lose your other half, King Catra. I would not wish it on my foulest enemy."

They stopped at the monument to King Micah, a casualty of the drawn-out war with the Horde. Queen Angella lost King Micah over seven years ago. The monument was beautiful, but it did not show just how short the King was, or how kind his eyes were.

"I have a monument like this for Adora in her favorite plaza. I can see her from the balcony in our bed chamber.” If she closes her eyes, it was almost like she could see the statue in front of her. “Sometimes, when I can't sleep at night, I sit outside and stare at the stone, willing it to become flesh and blood. I'd give anything to have her back."

Queen Angella looked at Catra with understanding, one of the few who understood the battle between mourning a spouse and carrying on for her people. "I worry for my daughter. Marrying you will not make her happy. Especially when another woman lives in your heart."

Catra tempered her next words. "With all due respect your majesty, marrying anyone but Bow would likely make her unhappy. You are standing in the way of that." She tried to deliver the words as softly as possible. Queen Angella looked agonized.

"Our council works differently than yours, Catra. We need their approval, and we don't have the votes.” Angella sighed, frustrated. “I don't want to keep them apart. Bow is an excellent young man, but tradition requires she marry someone from a royal line of succession." Angella went on to explain.

"It seems we come full circle then your majesty. I want Bow to come with us, I do not pretend to keep them apart. I only seek political partnership, mutual respect, and friendship with Glimmer. Will you accept?" Catra held her breath.

“I will not stand in my daughter’s way if she thinks this is what is best for her.” Queen Angella reached her hand out and bowed her head over their joined hands, a sign of respect and ascent.

Adam’s arm came down on the bar top, shaking it with his strength. From under her hood, she saw his arms flexing, clearly trying to intimidate her. It didn’t unsettle Adora in the slightest.

"You seem to know a lot about my childhood for someone who I know nothing about.” Adam’s words were acerbic. “If this is a kidnapping attempt, I'll advise you that Halfmoon has a strict policy of not paying ransoms, even for their most handsome councilman." The hard edge of Adam's clearly showed that didn't trust her message.

That was fine with Adora, she figured he wouldn't. She was counting on his bullheadedness and curiosity to get him to the tavern. Adora reserved a room and waited at the bar, face hidden in case a passerby took interest in her. Now, her brother was here. Adam probably wouldn't go anywhere with Adora unless she revealed herself. Her whole being trembled in anticipation.

"Is that any way to treat your favorite sister?" She played off her nerves with a bad joke and allowed Adam to glimpse into her hood.

He let out a yelp in surprise. "Adora! I can't believe it is you!" He roared. And then her large oaf of a brother broke down sobbing into her arms like a child. In the middle of a tavern.

"You are making a scene Adam, let's go to my room where we can talk in private." She managed to hustle him up the stairs although it was a mite difficult given that he was still crying. Once she closed the door behind her, she hugged him fiercely and let tears of her own fall.

“I missed you so much.” Being without Adam was like being without a limb. They watched each other’s backs and when the time came, they proved their worth and were knighted to serve the Bright Moon crown.

The only time they lived more than a five-minute walk from each other was when she married Catra and moved to Halfmoon.

“Where have you been?” Adam asked pulling back slightly to look into Adora’s eyes.

Adora sighed. “It’s a long story, brother.” Adora felt tired just thinking of the last three years, everything she endured to get back.

“We have all night.” Adam challenged.

"I’ll tell you all about where I’ve been, but I need you to know this first Adam. I am on a mission, a mission that led to my disappearance. I am in dire need of help." Adora practically begged. She did not know who else to turn to.

"Of course, I’ll help you. I am terribly curious as to what you have been doing in the last three years and I'm sure I will find it in me to be angry at you when I'm no longer pleased by your reappearance." The smile on Adam’s face seemed permanent.

Adora sat in the lone chair in the room and signaled for Adam to sit on the bed. "Do you remember where I was when I disappeared?"

Adam looked down and started rubbing the frayed end of the bedsheet. "Yes, you were in a hunting party meandering through the whispering woods. I combed every inch of those woods looking for you." Adam reached out to grab Adora’s shoulder as if assuring himself that she was physically present. Adora took a deep breath, the truth slipping forward.

"I lied. I kept having visions urging me to go to the whispering woods. I used the hunting party as an excuse to make it out there without guards. When I was finally by myself in the woods, I found this." Adora showed Adam what started her long separation from everything she knew and loved.

The Sword of Protection.

Adam gaped. "Is that what I think it is?"

Adora nodded solemnly. "Yes. I was chosen as She-ra." All Etherians knew the legend of She-ra, a warrior that only appeared when the planet needed her most. She-ra was deeply connected with the magic of Etheria, one of the only people who could tap into its stores. Many thought She-ra a mythical tale, not an actual warrior.

"Adora, are you sure? You don't look like you have the spirit of a magical warrior embedded in you. No offense!" Adam backtracked quickly.

Adora smiled. Her eyes flashed a glowing blue and she stood, suddenly towering over her brother. "Is this different enough for you?" Adora challenged, her voice changing along with the rest of her. Adam stared in disbelief.

"Stars above, you *are* She-ra! Adora, you are destined to smite the Horde and help us defeat them! This is excellent news!" Adam gave Adora a goofy smile. "But I still don't understand. Why didn't you come back to Halfmoon when you found out that you were She-ra?" Adam wondered. Adora flickered back to her normal height.

"Light Hope." Adora bit out as an explanation. "When I grabbed the sword, I passed out and woke up in a place known as the Crystal Castle, a shrine to She-ra." Adora shuddered as she thought of that awful place.

"The mystical being that operates the ruin trapped me inside to harness the power of She-ra. She would not allow me to leave until I completed training." Adora sneered. It was a great irony to supposedly be the most powerful warrior on the planet but still feel so helpless. "I was released sometime after the attack on Bright Moon. Light Hope said that there was no more time to train, that the planet needed me now." She was shocked when she went from imprisoned to free with the flick of Light Hope's wrist.

“I asked around and found that you live in Halfmoon now. I sent you the missives and hoped that you would be curious enough to come back to our childhood village to meet me.” Adora explained. She wasn't sure what she would have done if he hadn't made it.

Going back to the village had been difficult for Adora. She hadn't been back to the area since before her coronation as Catra’s consort almost six years ago. Nothing was where she remembered it and it made her ache. She felt like she was always aching these days. For Catra, for the last three years of her life, for the loss of everything she thought she knew.

Adam's eyes widened as he took in the information. "Adora that was two months ago! What have you been doing?" Adam put both his arms around Adora as if to shake her.

"I wasn't sure if I would be welcomed at Bright Moon or Halfmoon." It was a difficult thing to admit.

Adam's eyes almost turned to pity as he dropped his arms. "You've heard of the engagement then?"

Adora rolled her eyes. "I was on my way to Halfmoon when the engagement was announced." Adora felt a lump rising in her throat again. "It is all anyone will talk about." Adora couldn't help the bitterness and frustration that seeped into her voice.

The news of Catra and Glimmer’s engagement reached her almost from the moment of her release. At first, she couldn't believe what she'd heard and once she did believe, the heartbreak was worse than the loneliness she'd faced for three years.

“Living in the Crystal Castle was awful, but this is the thing I feared the most. That I would find her in love, married to someone else, perhaps with a child of her own. Living the life we had dreamed of, had promised to each other.” The nauseous feeling that lived in her stomach since she learned of the engagement returned full force. Adam quickly moved to reassure her.

"Catra still loves you, Adora. She hasn't forgotten you, not for one second. She refused to stop looking for you." Adam insisted.

Adora didn't know if that was true. "Doesn't feel that way from where I'm sitting. I mean marrying Glimmer! Of all people! In my worst nightmares, I never imagined that she would fall in love with Glimmer, want to marry her." Adora put her hands on her head. "Did something happen to Bow? When did they get together? How long has it been since I lost her?" The last three years it felt like all Adora ever thought about was being reunited with her wife. It seemed those feelings were one-sided.

"No Adora you misunderstand, it's a political arrangement. Bow is in Halfmoon with Glimmer, there is nothing between her and Catra." Adam grimaced at the names.

"Then why do you look so guilty?" Adora accused.

"I might have given Catra my blessing to marry Glimmer?" Adam's voice trailed off by the end of his sentence. Adora stared at him with narrowed eyes.

"Adam. You told my wife to marry my oldest friend? My former regent?" Adora's voice pitched up as she questioned her brother. "You really are the stupid twin." She glared at him.

"Adora you were literally dead! You have likely seen what it's done for the morale of the people, and it also gives them the power to call the shots in the Alliance." Adam explained. "The first Alliance meeting since the announcement had all kingdoms tripling their resource commitments to the war!" Adam exclaimed.

Adora softened. "I know that the people are happy about the news, but I hadn't heard of the outcome of the last Alliance meeting. That is truly wonderful news." Adora felt a swell of pride for what her wife and friends had accomplished, even given the circumstances.

"Well, it doesn't matter now. Catra will obviously call off the wedding, what with you here and alive. God, this is so exciting!

I'm so, so, happy, sister." Adam bear-hugged Adora for what felt like the hundredth time and Adora let the warmth of it settle down to her toes. She missed her brother.

"You really mean it? She hasn't forgotten me? Three years is a long time, Adam. I could hardly blame her for moving on." Adora steeled herself. "Please be honest with me, I want to be prepared for whatever I might face."

Adam placed reassuring hands on both of Adora's shoulders with a force that rattled her teeth. Adam's blue eyes bored into hers. "Adora. I can promise you that no one on Etheria has mourned you like she has, myself included. She loves you still sister, it's plain as day on her face anytime she remembers you." Adam murmured softly. "Glimmer and Bow are together as always, and the betrothal is not a love match. You should have seen the way she almost took off Tao's head the first time the old coot suggested she marry someone."

Relief flooded through her at her brother's words. She felt her knees might give out. Maybe everything wasn't lost. If Catra still loved her, still wanted to be with her, Adora would move mountains to make it so.

"Adora I'm sorry." He said simply.

Adora cleared her throat. She shifted focus for the moment. "You have nothing to apologize for. I didn't know how much time had passed and although the engagement was obviously shocking to me, it made me realize that this isn't the Etheria I knew. I decided to roam and collect myself for a bit. Then I decide to find you."

Adam's grin returned. "And here I am dearest sister. What can I do to help you on your hero's journey." He had always been the more excitable of the two.

"I need you to fill me in on what has been happening the last few years. I also need an audience with a regent so I can be involved in the coordinated war efforts."

Adam snorted. "I doubt you'd have a trying time getting an audience with Catra. You don’t need me for that." Adora remained silent, hesitantly biting her lip. Adam narrowed his eyes at his sister. "What are you not saying."

Adora sighed. "I'm not sure that I want to tell Catra that I've returned yet." The vein in Adam's forehead started to pulse. Adora put a hand up. "Listen. Catra and Glimmer have been betrothed for two months and have simultaneously given all Etheria hope for a better tomorrow and centralized political leadership. If I return as Adora, Queen of Halfmoon, does it put all these advances in jeopardy?"

Adam shook his head wildly. "It doesn’t matter! You can't keep this from her Adora. She mourns you. I don't know that she will forgive you for leaving her in the dark.” Adam’s red-rimmed eyes welled with tears again. “You don't know what it has been like for us. We were convinced you were dead Adora." Adam's voice cracked on the last sentence.

Adora felt her guilt well up in her chest. "I know and I'm sorry for that. I don't want to keep Catra unaware forever. I don't wish to be cruel. But I can't waltz into Halfmoon’s castle either. That's what I need you for brother, to help me plan my next move." It was the first time she had spoken Catra’s name aloud since she was trapped in that forsaken tower in the Whispering Woods.

“So you need access to the regents without giving away your identity,” Adam smirked. "I have an idea."

With Adam's assistance, she smuggled herself through the border between Halfmoon and Bright Moon. It took her a week to stand before the castle that was once her home.

Being in the capital of Halfmoon again felt strange. Halfmoon had been her home for so long, it was jarring to not recognize so many of the buildings. Adora stopped short at one. In the middle of a square she used to frequent with Catra, was a monument of

Adora in traditional Halfmoon robes. The inscription read: *Lost but not forgotten.* It gave Adora chills. She obviously knew she wasn't dead but looking at this monument made her feel like maybe she had been.

The square was a flurry of activity. Today, Catra would present Glimmer as her betrothed to all Halfmoon. Adora was walking around with stones in her stomach all day.

Adora stood in front of the balcony she knew they would come through, an excellent view of her wife introducing her friend to Halfmoon as their future Queen. Adora really was a glutton for punishment.

She remembered the nervous excitement she felt the day Catra formally introduced her to Halfmoon standing on that same balcony. Their engagement had not been made public before the presentation and Adora was nervous about the reaction of the people. Catra had just kissed her sweetly.

"*They will love you, Adora, because they love me, and you are the absolute best part of me.*" She had been right. Halfmoon accepted Adora without question.

She waited half an hour- standing near the balcony but far enough that she would be able to escape if necessary. She was not meant to be seen until the Princess Alliance meeting in two weeks' time.

Adam would kill her if he knew where she was, but the thought of seeing Catra with her own eyes was irresistible. The crowds began to fill in, mostly magicats but a few humans and other species. She had missed being surrounded by the swishing tails and twitching ears of what she considered her people.

The door opened as Catra stepped out, decked in stylish trousers, a white blouse, and an intricate maroon vest Adora knew Catra must have hated putting on. She looked just as beautiful as Adora remembered, her eyes overlooking the crowd, her stance regal.

Adora’s breath caught as she drank in the sight of Catra. If missing Adam was like missing a limb, missing Catra was like missing her whole heart. Adora missed Catra how one might miss a portion of oneself, never forgetting that she was in pieces. Never whole if Catra was afar.

Catra provided a brilliant smile from the castle balcony, making eye contact with the commoners who came to hear the announcement. "People of Halfmoon! I present to you Princess Glimmer, soon-to-be Queen Glimmer of Halfmoon! Together we pledge that we will lead our peoples out of the darkness of war and into a new day of peace!" Catra raised her hand, joined with Glimmer’s hand in a sign of unity.

Glimmer was wearing a flouncy violet dress, the type she always loved and wore in Bright Moon. It made Adora smile. “Halfmoon! I promise to love you as my own. Catra and I will bring in a reign of peace that will be unending. It is a promise, not only to Halfmoon but to Bright Moon and to all Etheria!” Glimmer was met with raucous applause.

Adora felt grim for she knew that to reach peace there would be significant bloodshed.

Catra placed a perfunctory kiss on Glimmer’s hand as she let go. Even though there was no romance in the action it still left a sense of dread in Adora’s gut.

Catra looked over the crowd again and her eyes stopped on Adora, her head tilting to the side, one ear twitching against her golden crown.

Adora’s first reaction was instinctual- her skin was abuzz with Catra’s eyes acknowledging her. Then Adora felt panic rise in her. She had practically covered her whole body, there was no way for Catra to know it was her.

Then, she noticed the bluish light in her hood. Adora’s eyes were glowing. She shoved the hood lower and walked away at a

moderate pace not wanting to act even more suspicious.

When she glanced back Catra's attention had been diverted elsewhere, which was a blessing and a curse. She longed to be looked at by Catra. Adora comforted herself, knowing that soon Catra's eyes would be upon her again, but Catra would know exactly who she was looking at.

Swords Return

Chapter Summary

Catra loses control of an Alliance meeting.

Etheria's Champion returns.

A miracle appears before the King's eyes.

Chapter Notes

Thanks to BlueCoin00 for beta reading. She wrote gay in all caps at least four times while editing this chapter. I hope you find it as gay as she did!

I hope y'all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

This was the fifth Princess Alliance meeting since Bright Moon and Halfmoon announced Catra's engagement to Glimmer. Catra and Glimmer's joint efforts earned the Alliance had more success against the Horde in the last three months than the entire year before that. Once the tide of war turned, most of the Alliance representatives heeded their opinion.

"We have successfully reclaimed the territory that the Horde took just outside of the Bright Moon territory. The battle lines are now the same as they were before the battle of Bright Moon." Netossa reported with a surge of pride in her voice. Catra smiled warmly at Netossa. She was exceedingly pleased with the decision to appoint her as the head military strategist.

"That is amazing news. I know that I don't speak for Bright Moon in these meetings, but I am glad to know that its borders have been restored." Glimmer said, gratitude shining in her eyes.

“That *is* fantastic news." Catra echoed. "Entrapta do you have a report?” She asked.

“Yes! Although experimental, we found a way for soldiers to have handheld projectiles. We still need to find a way to mass-produce the projectiles and determine their best use, but I think it will be ready for use soon.” Entrapta rambled as she checked her notes.

“Excellent, I think that is the end of the reports for today. Does anyone else have anything to bring to the Alliance’s attention before we close the meeting?”

Perfuma motioned to speak. Catra raised an eyebrow but nodded at her, giving her the floor. “I would just like to thank the Alliance for stationing an Etherian Army battalion in Plumeria. We haven’t dealt with a Horde raid in the last two months because of it.” Perfuma practically glowed as she shared the news.

“I’m glad to hear that our decision to form the Etherian Army is already yielding results.” It was Catra’s decision, really. Most Alliance decisions were hers to make these days.

As the meeting ended, Adam popped his head through the main door looking unreasonably excited. Catra contained an eye roll— it would be inappropriate. Adam loved showing up near the end of the meetings to catch up with some of the royalty he knew from his days as a Bright Moon knight. However, this time instead of waiting for the meeting to end, Adam signaled Catra, miming that he would like to speak. Catra narrowed her gaze and awkwardly cleared her throat, confused as to why Adam would need to speak. She waved her hand, gesturing for him to come closer.

"Councilman Adam, what a pleasure to see you at a Princess Alliance meeting. Is there something you would like to say before the meeting is adjourned?" Adam beamed, an almost childish grin that looked odd on his large frame.

"Yes, I have a big announcement, something that could further our united cause. Or rather, someone. I would like to introduce

her to you.” Catra pursed her lips, gesturing for Adam to go on. He drew to his full height and spoke loudly, his voice projecting throughout the room. “This is She-ra of Etherian myth and legend. The Princess of Power has returned to us in our time of need to help defeat the Horde. She requests an audience with the Alliance."

At that, Adam opened the door he had been holding closed and what could only be described as an Amazonian warrior strode in. There were rumblings as Alliance members whispered to each other. The woman easily towered over everyone in the room, her height unnatural. It was clear that her armor-clad body had a muscular build and her long blonde hair was loose underneath her helmet. Her face was obscured but her eyes glowed a bright blue, emitting light visible from the slits in her helmet.

Catra ignored how the sight of this woman pulled low at her gut. A quick look around the room told Catra that she wasn't the only one affected by the clear strength of the supposed legendary warrior. The Alliance members all looked to Catra and Glimmer, likely assuming they knew of this allegation given that it was a member of Halfmoon’s council that was bringing it forward. Catra stiffened, discreetly gripping her tail underneath the table to keep it from visibly twitching. She had no idea— and she did not appreciate Adam springing this into an Alliance meeting with no warning.

"This is the first I've heard of a legendary warrior Adam. How did you happen upon this information? Better yet, how do we know it's accurate?” Catra leaned back into her chair at the center of the table. “We should have vetted this woman before you brought her into a room with the heads of state of half a dozen kingdoms." Her tone was cold, a dress down that Adam rightfully deserved.

Adam grinned despite the obvious censure. "I'm sorry, my liege." The armored woman's head snapped towards Adam at the words, and he gave a strange look back, as they communicated silently. Adam knew this woman and it unnerved Catra to be in the dark. She liked being prepared and in control. Adam continued to

speak. "I swear on my oath of loyalty that I verified this woman’s claim that she is She-ra. She is willing to lend her sword to the Princess Alliance to defeat the Horde." Catra wasn’t done. She gave Adam a hard stare.

"That doesn't explain how you came to meet She-ra and neglected to mention her existence until now." Catra shifted her hands to grasp the chair’s arms tightly.

"She actually found me. We have-" once again, She-ra glowered at Adam, and he changed course "-she heard I was a council member in your court and thought I would be able to request an audience with a member of the Princess Alliance. I thought this would be more streamlined and transparent." Adam stated as he shrugged one shoulder.

"So far, none of this seems streamlined or transparent, Adam. Can She-ra not speak for herself?" Glimmer inserted herself into the conversation.

Adam took a long look at She-ra who seemed to stare back, though it was hard to tell through the helmet.

The warrior sighed. "I can." Her voice was familiar to Catra, but it held an inhuman reverberation that made it impossible to place. It was as if magic echoed, overlaid onto the sound. The magic also affected the way she smelled. It was unnerving. "I have been training for years for this moment. I want to join the Alliance in their coordinated efforts against the Horde and restore Etheria.” Catra eyed the group, a collection of wide eyes and slightly agape mouths. All the other officials seemed enraptured by She-ra. “I was chosen by the Sword of Protection, and I sacrificed everything that meant anything to me to prepare for this duty." The giantess took a shuddering breath and it pulled deeply at Catra’s heartstrings. She didn't understand why. "This is my formal request to join the Alliance as the Princess of Power. As is my right. And, if the King permits it, I will also pledge my fealty to Halfmoon."

Catra’s brow raised in surprise. "If you fight for all Etheria, why pledge your fealty to Halfmoon, to me and my betrothed? Wouldn't that bias you in some way?"

A startling growl reverberated through the chambers until the fighter let out what sounded like an embarrassed cough. Adam looked tinkled pink.

"Apologies. Your majesty, my reasons are my own. Rest assured that I am sworn to fight for Etheria, but I have always belonged to Halfmoon." Catra didn't know what to think of this mysterious woman offering her loyalty so freely.

"Does that mean you are currently a citizen of Halfmoon?" Catra inquired.

She-ra paused as if evaluating her next few words. "In a sense yes. Maybe. I'm not sure of the legality of it." The warrior stumbled over her words. Adam coughed to cover a laugh.

Catra stared hard at the blonde, calculating. This was all too good to be true, for some legend to walk in prepared to lead the charge in the war efforts. "It's hard to trust a woman who won't show her face." Catra snipped. The warrior seemed to freeze looking around the room.

"If you accept my fealty and my request to join the Alliance, I will allow one of you to see my face. My preference is the regent I swear my fealty to." The woman allowed.

"So Catra or I?" Glimmer tested. The warrior nodded her assent. "But you have a preference?" Glimmer probed.

She-ra sidestepped the question entirely. "It would be an honor to reveal my face to either of you." She placated.

"Are you horribly disfigured?" Queen Mermista of Salineas asked tone bored but eyes interested. Princess Perfuma of Plumeria gasped at the accusation, but Catra could see more than one Alliance member was interested in the answer.

She-ra’s shoulders shook in what looked to be silent laughter. "I don't think I'm disfigured?" She turned to ask Adam, who rolled his eyes.

"She is not disfigured. Her face is passable."

She-ra ignored Adam's jibe. "As you can tell by my stature and the glow of my eyes the Sword of Protection imbues me with magic. I fear that revealing my identity would be unwise at this moment, making me and those I love a target.” She-ra shifted her weight from one foot to another. “I would allow all Alliance members to know my face once I can guarantee my identity is protected. Showing my face to either of my regents at this time is a show of trust."

The room feel silent for a moment as Catra’s eyes darted to Glimmer. "What do you think?" She whispered. Glimmer had made a stupendous ally in the last three months, more cunning than Catra originally gave her credit for.

"I think you should let her reveal herself to you. She clearly prefers you to me for some reason. Watch." Glimmer reached out and grabbed Catra’s hand rubbing circles with her thumb. It was uncomfortable and inappropriate for an Alliance meeting. She had no idea where Glimmer’s head was at.

The earlier growl returned louder than before until the warrior hurriedly tamped it down with a muttered, "sorry." Adam groaned.

That was strange indeed. Catra knew she needed to take control of this situation before it got out of hand. "I want to put this matter to a vote in the Alliance. I do not have the power to accept She-ra on my own.” Catra declared, hoping to appease the Alliance members. “My stance, and that of Halfmoon, is that we would be mistaken to reject the help of an eight-foot warrior goddess whose mission it is to protect Etheria," Catra announced in a no-nonsense voice that didn’t leave much room for argument.

"I'm not sure anyone said anything about a goddess, your majesty." Adam interrupted, humor obvious in his voice.

Catra glared, feeling her cheeks color. "I have eyes, councilman." She grumbled. There were murmurs of agreement amongst the Alliance members which made her feel a bit better about her slip-up. "I propose that either Glimmer or I interview She-ra, verify her identity, and claim to the Sword of Protection. We can reschedule the next Alliance meeting for next week in Salineas. That gives us time to prepare a report with the appropriate declassified information."

Catra's eyes swept over the group, trying to discern how her plan was landing. "Let me be clear. I do not want in groups and out groups in this Alliance, I will declassify all information amongst the heads of state." Catra had enjoyed almost universal support and she would make concessions to continue to do so. "When I refer to classified information it refers to information for consumption outside of the Alliance. We are all equals here."

Catra continued to gauge the mood of the Alliance members. The atmosphere remained mild, most whispering excitedly to each other and occasionally eyeing their guest. There seemed to be acceptance of the plan.

"Let's have a vote. All in favor?" Glimmer asked, raising her hand as she did so. All hands around the table shot up. It was unanimous.

Catra picked up where Glimmer left off. "Meeting adjourned. Thank you for your trust in us. We will have a report in a week's time. See you all in Salineas."

The representatives dispersed, their former whispers becoming furious chattering as they picked up their notes. The gossip would run wild with the appearance of She-ra, Catra knew. She pulled out Glimmer's chair as was customary and led her towards where Adam stood with She-ra.

Catra glared openly at Adam. "Glimmer, I need a word with my trusted advisor. Please keep our... guest company for a moment." She led Adam to a private meeting room near the main council room, jaw clenched. She turned around and let him have it. "I don't know why you thought that pulling a stunt like that would be acceptable, but I swear on the tails of my unborn children that if you ever do anything like that again, I will ban you from my kingdom." Catra snarled, the makings of a hiss hiding in her words.

Adam seemed waterlogged or maybe he lost his ability to comprehend common Etherian. He still grinned as if he hadn't been threatened by his regent. "I brought you someone to turn the tide of the war, amongst other things. I think you should talk to her before you rake me over the coals." His face turned more serious. "It needs to be you, Catra. Talk to her." Adam urged. She was taken aback by the pleading tone his voice took.

"She-ra said she would speak to Glimmer or I. Why shouldn't I send Glimmer in my stead?" Catra said, feeling contrarian.

"For many reasons. But the one I will give right now is that I don't think Bow would like it much." Adam pointed towards the pair, the deep rumble of She-ra's voice noticeable in the emptying room. Glimmer looked like she might drool herself staring at the warrior.

Catra rolled her eyes. "Really can't trust anyone to do their jobs, can I?" She turned her attention back to Adam, sending him a glare. "I'm not done with you. I *will* rake you over the coals later." She narrowed her eyes at Adam, really looking at him. He looked different. Lighter. "Something is off about you. You're too giddy. Did Teela finally give you the time of day?"

Adam sputtered looking red and horrified. "What? There is nothing between Teela and I. Only disagreements!" He blustered.

"Everyone knows you've laid together or you will. You might as well enjoy yourself instead of hosting your ridiculous fights in my

council meetings." She left Adam behind, a smirk playing on her lips as she put him in his place.

She approached Glimmer and She-ra, seeing her up close for the first time. She was incredibly tall, Catra craned her neck to try to see into her helmet. "Mighty She-ra, welcome to Halfmoon. I am sorry that councilman Adam did not show you more hospitality, we usually treat our guests better than this." Catra nodded her acknowledgment and She-ra bowed deeply in return. "Although you seem to know who we are, I will introduce myself. I am King Catra of Halfmoon and this is my betrothed, Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon, soon to be Queen of Halfmoon. How long have you been in the capital?" She asked politely. Catra usually found that she could extract much information through niceties, it made people put their guard down.

The warrior seemed happy to answer her question. "I arrived at the capital two weeks ago, on the day you introduced Princess Glimmer to the public."

This surprised Catra. She recalled looking at the crowd and seeing a strange blue glow but dismissing it as her imagination. Maybe She-ra had been in the crowd? But why? "You've been in contact with Adam since then?"

She-ra turned her head, Catra couldn't tell what she might be thinking because the helmet limited access to her expression. "I spoke with councilman Adam in a nearby village a few days before. He convinced me this would be the best course of action." Although hesitant, the answer seemed truthful.

Catra decided to cut to the chase. She was tired of these games. "You know who we are, but we know nothing about you or whether what you say holds any truth." Catra pointed out, ears twitching. "For all we know, you found a sorceress to cast an illusion spell, or you are an ogre in a suit of armor." She-ra let out a chortle at the comparison. Catra pushed on. "How do you plan to verify the claims you and Adam made at the Alliance meeting?"

She-ra seemed prepared for this question. From the waistband at her side, she pulled out a huge sword, bigger than that of any human. "This is the Sword of Protection. I am open to allowing a historian or other expert to evaluate it under my supervision." Catra nodded to herself, thinking of asking Tao or Cloudfoot to round up someone qualified for the job. "In terms of who I am… As I said, my identity is a complicated subject, but I am willing to reveal it in a private setting." She-ra's voice brokered no compromise.

"Your proposal regarding the sword is fair. What type of privacy do you require to reveal your identity?" Catra asked.

She-ra paused for a moment. "A place where you and I could be alone." Her voice dropped lower, reminding Catra of a rumbling purr, and the glowing blue of her eyes seemed to flash brighter. Catra blinked, trying to keep from gaping. She felt pulled towards this woman again. She heard Adam snort to her left and She-ra stiffened at the sound. She cleared her throat and her eyes dimmed. "Or Princess Glimmer. I defer the decision to you."

No matter how pulled Catra felt to She-ra, or maybe because of it, Catra was unsatisfied with She-ra's proposal. "You expect me to go into a room alone with a person I don't know who could likely crush me at the slightest provocation? I need security." She-ra's eyes flashed blue again, a small growl building in her chest. Could she be a magicat? She did say she was a citizen of Halfmoon. Catra shook her head slowly to attempt to clear it. None of this added up.

"I swore my fealty to you, your majesty. My fealty is all I have. You have nothing to fear from me. If it would make you feel better, the door can be unlocked, and Adam can guard the door." She-ra proposed anew.

Catra was done with all the intrigue. She was used to being the sharpest person in the room and today she felt the most ill-prepared. "Fine. Glim, I'll find you when I'm done with this. Why don't you check with the Master Archer to see if our armory has

any needs now that we delivered the latest shipment to Plumeria." It was a total lie to let Glimmer know she was free to spend time with her love.

"We can do this in my study, it's private enough." She-ra took in a sharp breath.

"Now?" The warrior stuttered.

Catra eyed the blonde. "Yes, now." Catra started to walk towards her destination, expecting She-ra to follow. "If you are amenable to that." Catra tacked on.

That seemed to make She-ra move again. "Yes of course. Lead the way." She-ra's voice pitched up, sounding nervous for the first time. Catra couldn't place the familiarity of the voice and it bothered her.

She pushed Adam in front of her. "Actually, Adam is going to lead us so he can't whisper to you like a schoolgirl." She taunted.

Adam rolled his eyes but marched onward, shooting She-ra a look before he turned around. As they walked through the halls leading to the King's chambers, a few guards looked alarmed at the warrior with glowing eyes walking around but they did not comment. Adam held open the door of Catra's study for them. After Catra passed, Adam grabbed She-ra's forearm, stopping her. Adam looked tiny next to her, no small feat. He gave her a meaningful look that She-ra seemed to understand. It reminded her of something but once again it evaded her. She-ra patted Adam's shoulder and he let go of her arm.

Finally, Shera crossed the threshold and closed the door behind her. Without turning around, she started stripping off her armor. The armor cranked as it hit the ground.

Catra yelped. "What are you doing? That is highly inappropriate." Catra's voice betrayed how shocked she was at this woman's brazen attitude.

She-ra turned around, arms now exposed, muscles moving beneath the skin as she turned. Catra noted she was still wearing a chain mail vest, her helmet, and her trousers. She felt a strange mix of relief and disappointment.

"Do not worry my King. I would never compromise your honor." She-ra's voice had a humorous edge as she spoke.

The words reverberated in her head. She heard them before, but something was different. *Do not worry my Prince, I would never compromise your honor—no matter how difficult you make the task.* Adora said those exact words to her multiple times. Adora insisted on honoring the tradition of waiting to be wed before consummating their union. She would utter them when their passionate kissing took them to inappropriate places for an unwed couple. Catra would push but Adora always held firm, telling Catra that it would be worth the wait. It had been.

It struck her then. She-ra reminded Catra of Adora. The easy way she had with Adam, the blue of her eyes, the blonde hair. Her heart panged as it always did when she thought of her love.

She-ra continued, unaware of Catra's turmoil. "The armor is heavy even when I am in this form, I would be unable to manage it in my other form," She-ra explained, her long arm reaching behind her nack to scratch. Her words caught Catra's attention.

"Your other form?" Catra prompted.

"It's easier if I show you. But first, I promised I would reveal this face to you."

She-ra raised her hand slowly—it trembled as she gripped the helmet tightly, her knuckles white from the exertion. She pulled off the helmet and a mess of blonde hair fell out. Catra looked at the face of She-ra, puzzled anew. Because it was so, so, very familiar. Her heart ached from how much this woman looked like Adora. But it was also the wrong face.

It was Adora’s nose, but the bump she received when she broke it in a fight while training was missing. The scar on her jaw that she got after surprising Catra out of a nap—missing. Her few freckles were also gone. Her teeth were straighter and an almost uncomfortable blinding white. The blue of the glowing eyes was a few shades off, the same as the blonde of her hair. It was too blonde, almost white. Add in that this woman was so much taller than Adora and it felt like an uncanny valley. The pieces could have added up to Adora in another life, but they just didn't.

Catra must have been gaping at She-ra for a long time because the warrior looked uncomfortable. Catra attempted to speak. Her voice shook. "Why—why do you bear this resemblance to my wife? You must know that you look like her." She needed to know. She-ra must have had an explanation. If she knew Adam, he would have pointed it out to her.

Then the nervous look She-ra gave Catra melted into a heart-stopping smile and warm eyes that she recognized without a doubt. This was Adora. "I think you know why, dearest." The pieces fell into place. Adam's incandescent happiness, She-ra insisting she would only reveal herself to Halfmoon’s regent, her conviction that she belonged to Halfmoon. Adora was home.

Suddenly, She-ra began to shrink in front of Catra’s eyes. A blinding flash forced Catra to close her eyes and when she opened them again, a miracle stood before her. Adora. Her freckles, her slightly crooked front tooth, her nose bump, her scars, her kind eyes—the right shade of blue—all Adora sitting in front of Catra. As if she never left. Adora looked down at the ground, then back up at Catra, smiling shyly. She shrugged her shoulders.

"This is what I meant by another form."

Adora rubbed her neck awkwardly again, a movement so familiar it stopped Catra’s heart. Catra didn't want to breathe for fear that Adora would somehow disappear the same way she appeared. Catra ran at full speed, tackling her to the ground. Adora fell over with a loud oof, the metal pieces of She-ra’s armor clanging

together. Catra straddled her, shoved her head into Adora's neck, and started to scent mark her, nuzzling up and down. She felt the tears seep out of her. Her body was overcome with wracking sobs, still in disbelief. Adora smelled the same.

Adora easily lifted them both so that she was sitting on the ground, with Catra cradled to her chest as she murmured sweet nothings into her hair. It was a running stream of commentary*, I missed you so much—I never wanted to be parted from you dearest*, *I can't believe I'm holding you right now*, *you looked so gorgeous scolding Adam earlier*.

The last one made Catra snort and the smile she felt Adora press into her head made her think it was intentional. Catra looked up, trying to catch Adora's gaze. "What happened? Where have you been? Why all of this intrigue?" The questions shot out of Catra in quick succession. Then, a quiet whimper. "Why did you leave me?" The question that haunted her since the day of Adora's disappearance.

Adora stared at Catra unflinchingly, rubbing soothing circles on her arms. "I never wanted to leave you, Catra. I promise I will explain everything to you but know that these last three years—I have done everything to return to your side." Adora grunted in discomfort, shifting Catra again. "Can I take off the rest of my armor? I have a tunic underneath."

Now that Catra looked down, she could see just how big She-ra's chainmail fit Adora. Catra nodded but did not move from her spot nestled against Adora's chest, her tailed wrapped around Adora's leg. Adora chuckled and moved Catra far enough so she could toss the chain mail vest to the side, then returned Catra to their previous embrace. Catra broke into a rumbling purr. Adora looked down at Catra, sharply taking in a breath.

"I need to do something before I tell you where I've been."

Adora slowly cupped Catra's cheeks, making her intentions clear. She begged with her eyes for the permission she always had.

Catra leaned up and kissed Adora. She had never felt kissed quite like this. It was so sweet and unbearably gentle. When Catra imagined finding Adora she always envisioned a passionate, heated kiss. This kiss moved her but instead of passion, it heated her insides with love and comfort. It felt like a release of all the loneliness and tension she carried since the day Adora left.

Adora broke away and placed a small smattering of kisses on Catra's freckles. It coaxed a giggle from Catra. Her purr restarted louder than ever, vibrating between them. Adora beamed down at her.

"I was going to be too distracted by the thought of kissing you," Adora admitted shyly. "Now I'll tell you what happened." Adora held Catra tightly. "Before I left, I was having visions. I could see a sword out in the whispering woods. It felt like the sword was calling my very blood. Every time I closed my eyes, it was tattooed behind my eyelids." Adora admitted in a quiet whisper. "At first, I thought I was unwell. Then I knew I was losing my mind because I could see the sword when I was awake." Adora let out a shuddering breath.

"It lived just out of my field of vision, always behind the next hallway or in a dark corner. It felt like I needed to go out and find it if only to know that I wasn't going insane." Adora retold.

"Why didn't you tell me about the visions?"

Adora looked down, refusing to meet Catra's gaze for the first time since she revealed herself. Her long blonde hair curtained around her, shielding her from Catra's scrutiny. "I was afraid of what they were, what they might mean. I kept getting jumbled flashes. Catra, I thought I was losing my mind." Adora chanced a glance up, grabbing Catra's hand. "I know I should have told you and I regret not asking for your help every day. I can't help but feel that maybe things would have been different." Adora's voice shook with guilt and regret.

It hurt Catra to know Adora would keep something like this from her. It must show on her face because Adora moved to comfort her. "I had every trust in you my King and every doubt in myself. I planned on looking for the sword, I expected to fail and then I would return and tell you. I just never had the opportunity." A self-deprecating smile graced her face.

"I can't pretend this isn't upsetting Adora. I would have never kept something like this from you." Catra stated seriously. She released a sigh. "But I have mourned you for three years and I won't extend that separation because of a decision you have come to regret. But from now on, there can only be honesty between us. Do you understand?"

Adora nodded eagerly, her eyes flashing She-ra's glowing blue for a moment. "Of course." Adora placed her head on Catra's forehead. "So, I never went on that hunt in the whispering woods. The moment the hunting party took off I went in the complete opposite direction." Her gaze was far away. "My horse galloped for maybe five minutes, and I was suddenly deep into the woods as if I were traveling for two hours. And sitting there was this." Adora held up the Sword of Protection. "When I reached out and grabbed it, I passed out. When I came to, I wasn't out in the woods at all. I was in the Crystal Castle. That's where I met Light Hope." Adora's voice sounded like a dangerous growl at the mention of whoever that was. "Light Hope is the guardian of the Crystal Castle and a guide for She-ra. She told me that She-ra chose me as her host, that I was destined to save Etheria from the Horde."

Adora looked into Catra's eyes. "Light Hope said I wasn't allowed to leave the Crystal Castle until it was time. She said I had training to complete. At first, I tried to escape multiple times a day, until I realized that the fastest way out was to comply with her demands." Adora's face was wet with tears, her voice creaking more as she explained. "I trained harder than I did when I was training to become a knight. I was usually working towards some goal Light Hope set for me unless I was asleep." She sighed. "Then one day Light Hope opened the doors. She told me there

had been an attack on Bright Moon. That the war took a turn for the worst and there was no time for me to train any longer. I ended up on the edge of the forest as if I had never found the Crystal Castle.” Adora’s voice is filled with disbelief.

Adora’s fantastical story left Catra bereft, a pit of sand lodged in her stomach. “So the reason that you were gone for so long. It was because of this?” Catra’s eyes flicker to the sword in disdain.

“In large part yes. There was no way out of the Crystal Castle and no way to get a message out. I was trapped.” Adora affirmed.

“Why do you bring the sword and present yourself as She-ra then? Why do this, if you were essentially a prisoner?” Catra demanded.

“Catra, I cannot ignore the duty that Etheria has bestowed upon me any more than you can ignore yours. If I can turn the tide of the war with the sword, then that’s what I’ll do.” She was resolute, blue eyes burning with determination. “In the end, I think I did it because I wanted to get back here but I also worried about what Light Hope said. If I was supposed to save Etheria from the Horde, then I needed to be prepared.”

Catra could feel a fight brewing if they continued with this line of questioning, so she decided to move past that point of discussion for a more pressing one. "The battle at Bright Moon was almost four months ago. Why has it taken so long for you to come to me?"

Adora stared at Catra with a raised eyebrow. "I had been trapped in an ancient temple with no contact with the outside world for three years, Catra. It was disorienting. And I discovered that you are engaged to marry another woman, my dear friend. I had a lot to think about." She could hear the beginning of an accusation in Adora’s words.

Catra froze, thinking of her betrothal to Glimmer and what conclusions Adora might have drawn from it. "Adora don’t

misunderstand. There is nothing but friendship between Glimmer and I. We are political allies. She belongs with Bow; you can't think I—" Adora pressed a callused finger to Catra's bottom lip, gently moving it. Catra's eyes narrowed on it, almost cross-eyed. "I know dearest. Adam told me it was a political arrangement, a brilliant one. An alliance between Halfmoon and Bright Moon was necessary for the war efforts, and I understand that." Adora bit her lip, hesitating. "But before I contacted Adam, I had no way to know. I spent two months trying to put together a plan to most effectively reintroduce myself to Etheria without causing an international incident."

Adora sounded exhausted. Catra looked into Adora's eyes and found an unending sadness there. "The fact that the betrothal is not legitimate doesn't make it any less painful, does it?" Catra realized.

Adora grimaced. "It's a difficult thing, Catra. What my heart and my head know are different." She explained.

"Is that why you made that strange growling noise at the Alliance meeting?"

Adora flushed red, averting her gaze again. "When I transform into She-ra, I am more in tune with my emotions and yet separated from them. She-ra's magic is wild, untamed, which favors more primal emotions." Adora's gaze flickered away. "I wasn't expecting to react so strongly because I knew my mission in my mind, I was focused on it. But my heart feels you are mine without regard for what the law might say." Adora took a deep breath and continued. "Anyone laying claim to you feels wrong as Adora, but in She-ra's body, it felt blasphemous. The magic pushed me to defend what was mine." Adora glanced at Catra sheepishly and let out an embarrassed chuckle. "Or what it perceived as mine, at any rate. I know you are your own brilliant person."

Catra rolled her eyes. She truly married an idiot. Catra gathered Adora's face in her hands, placing a few scent marks on her for

good measure. "I am yours, Adora. In all the ways that matter. We will call off the engagement. You are my wife, and you are alive. No one can make me take Glimmer under these circumstances. Bright Moon will understand."

Adora’s smile turned sad. "The reasons why you brokered this agreement with Bright Moon still exist. The Horde is still out there every day burning down villages and slaughtering civilians. You haven't thought of the consequences of calling off the betrothal." Adora warned.

She touched Adora’s cheek. "I don't need to consider the political ramifications of what's right Adora. You are the rightful Queen of Halfmoon and the only woman I have ever loved. I refuse to allow anything else. You are my other half."

Adora sighed, leaning into her touch. "Catra, we don't need to make any decisions tonight. Honestly, I just want to be with you. Tomorrow morning, we will inform Glimmer and Bow that I am She-ra and we can plan." Adora took a deep breath looking down at Catra earnestly. "I'm dying to kiss you again. To touch you. I thought of you endlessly when I was trapped with no hope of escaping. Of having you look at me just like this." Adora cupped her hand around Catra’s cheek. Her hands felt stronger and rougher than before. Her whole body felt different, bolder, somehow leaner and harder.

Catra pressed closer to Adora."I want that too. Let's go to our bed chamber." She started to kiss Adora’s neck.

"Glimmer won't be there?" Adora asked timidly, as if afraid of the answer.

Catra scoffed. "No, she has her own chambers where Bow warms her bed. I told you, there is nothing between us. We are both in love with different people." Catra punctuates her sentence by worrying Adora’s collarbones, the skin on her neck and chest flushing pleasantly. Catra leaned her head back slightly, looking up

at her love. "What would you have done if Glimmer had come to verify your identity instead?" Catra asked, curious.

Adora’s smile turned wicked. "I would have made her feel guilty about her plans to marry my wife and she would have brought you to me."

Catra laughed. "That's low, even for you Adora."

She smirked in response. "Nothing is too low for me, my liege." Adora picked up Catra and transformed. Catra went from being on the floor to being able to touch the high ceilings. Catra could feel all the straining muscles of She-ra as she carried her. A purr broke out of her and Adora smirked. "Unfortunately, I can't carry you around the castle in this form. I need to put on my armor. I'll meet you in your room?" Adora gently placed Catra on her feet.

Catra stayed close to place a kiss upon She-ra’s cheek. "Our bed Adora. I'll be counting the minutes. Don't keep me waiting any longer." Catra waited for Adora for what felt like a lifetime. She had her wife back and no one would take her again.

Chapter End Notes

I hope the identity reveal was satisfying! I know some comments were speculating about how long Adora might keep her identity to herself and the answer is not very long! If you want to read about Adora and Catra being stupid about secret identities, that is what my superhero AU is for lol.

Also fun fact! I am 90% sure this is the first thing I have written that does not contain any page breaks.

Next week: Adora's return to Halfmoon does not make for the idyllic home life Catra imagined.

I appreciate any comments and/or kudos! It is what keeps me committed to my fastidious posting schedule :)

Swords Reveal

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora start facing the consequences of her return.

Adora prepares for the Alliance meeting.

Catra steeps in her doubts.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The fuzzy edges of the morning came and Catra never wanted to wake up from her dream. She buried her head further into the warmth of the soft blankets and pillows surrounding her. She stretched, letting out a small sigh as her aching muscles protested the movement.

In her dream, Adora was there- above her, below her, wringing every drop of pleasure her body had to offer. She still felt boneless even at the cusp of waking. She tried to hold on to that sleepy haze for a moment longer, not wanting to spoil it with reality.

"Good morning love. It will surely be a busy day. Won't you open those beautiful eyes for me, my liege?" Adora's voice swept over her just as warm and soft as the rest of the morning. Catra felt the fingers that were ghosting up her rib cage replaced by large warm palms gently pressing, coaxing her awake.

Catra burrowed further into the covers, now recognizing that Adora was truly there, it hadn't been a dream at all. Adora tried to pull the covers down to expose them to the morning chill. She stopped her rumbled purring for a moment to let out a weak hiss in warning. Adora released a delighted giggle at Catra's recalcitrance.

"I missed how rumpled and grumpy you are in the morning, dearest." Adora peppered Catra's face with kisses until Catra reluctantly opened one eye, the amber one.

"I love you more than life itself-" Catra vowed as she cupped Adora's face in her hand "-but can you please ask me to rise after the sun? This is a ridiculous hour, even for you." Catra accused. Adora looked at her so softly.

"I want to watch the sunrise with you, like the morning of our wedding," Adora admitted in a quiet whisper, her face open and vulnerable. Catra let out a soft sigh already knowing she would do anything to please Adora, especially when she brought up such sweet memories.

They were kept apart the night before their wedding, as tradition required. Adora broke into her bedchamber right before dawn and took her to watch the sun peek out over the horizon.

She had held Catra's hand, stared at her with soft eyes, and said, *"once the sun has set again, we will belong to each other in every way known to Etheria. Nothing will ever keep us apart, my Prince."*

That hadn't been true then, it turned out. It might not be true now. Catra shook the thoughts out of her head. She rolled out of bed, dragging Adora with her by pulling her arm.

"Well hurry then we can't miss it! You are going to make us late Adora!" Adora scoffed fondly but raced Catra to put on clothes.

They stayed on the King's private balcony, out of sight from prying eyes. Adora held her reverently and Catra knew what Adora was hinting at with their early morning. She wanted to remind Catra of their promise to be together. In no time at all, the sun rose, lighting all the cavernous mountains that made up the outskirts of Halfmoon. Adora cradled Catra closer as they talked.

"I thought about exactly this so many times. Seeing the sunrise with you." Adora sighed contentedly.

“I’m still not convinced this isn’t a dream,” Catra replied. She put her hand over Adora’s turning her hand over to look at it more closely. “We have a lot to talk about and decide today.” Catra sighed. Adora hummed in agreement.

"One of my questions is how recognizable is She-ra’s face as mine. I actually haven't seen myself as She-ra." Adora admitted sheepishly. Catra pondered the question briefly as she eyed Adora critically.

"I think people who knew you well will recognize you, but She-ra’s face is very different. A lot of what characterizes your face is missing." Adora let out a thoughtful hum.

"I want to see if Bow and Glimmer recognize me. They know me best of all the princesses. If they don't recognize me then I can likely hide my identity in plain sight." Catra sent Adora a long side-ways look. Adora looked away.

"I'm still unsure why you think your identity has to be kept a secret." Catra ventured cautiously. Adora continued to avoid Catra’s eyes.

"I'm not sure, but it might be convenient depending on what happens with the engagement," Catra growled, turning to face Adora more fully.

"I cannot marry Glimmer knowing you are alive Adora! I thought we settled that last night." Adora's eyes flashed blue and once again she was the tall warrior. It was jarring and Catra mourned the loss of her love. She-ra’s face bore Adora’s determined look, her lips thinned out into a grim line.

"Let's eat breakfast with Glimmer and Bow, my King. We are all affected by my reappearance, for better or for worse." Adora sidestepped the conversation entirely. It wasn’t Adora’s voice, but it was filled with her stubbornness.

Catra sent a message for Glimmer and Bow to join her and She-ra for breakfast. As they arrived, they found Adam was already in the

dining room, a huge grin on his face. He directed his first words at Catra.

"Aren't you satisfied with our new warrior?" Catra flushed as she flicked Adam's ear with her tail, not wanting to admit just how satisfied she was to her brother-in-law.

"You left your post, disobeying my direct order." She reprimanded gruffly. Adam was long gone by the time that Adora and Catra left her study the night before.

"My fealty knows no limits, but my eardrums do, Catra. If I had to hear any more of that reunion, I think my ears would bleed." Adam made a show of grabbing his ears as if muffling sound.

"But more importantly," Catra hissed, her voice dropping to a whisper, "how long did you keep her from me?" Adam's eyes widened as he raised his hand in a gesture of surrender.

"Not long! I swear that the first moment she was ready I marched her into the castle." Adora, as She-ra, placed a comforting hand on Catra's arm. It overtook her whole shoulder.

"He is right. You shouldn't take your anger out on him, multiple circumstances made things work out this way." Adora reasoned.

Catra knew that her anger and sadness at being separated from Adora for so long was wasted on Adam.

"You always defend him," Catra grumbled as she sent Adora an accusatory look. Adora smiled sheepishly, which looked strange on her larger frame.

"Yeah, I've been helpless for so long without your help, under King Catra's tyrannical rule." Adam piped in. She-ra swiftly smacked Adam in the head.

"Ouch!" He had to crane his neck to glare balefully at Adora. Adora then patted his head, clearly enjoying the reversed height difference between the siblings.

They settled into their seats waiting for Glimmer and Bow. Usually, they rose before Catra, but the sunrise wake-up call placed them well ahead of Glimmer and Bow’s usual schedule.

By the time the kitchen staff brought in their meal, Glimmer and Bow arrived. The duo walked in closely, looking like they had just stopped holding hands. They still weren't used to the discretion required while living in Halfmoon.

Adora stood, her eyes glowing, leaving both Bow and Glimmer a little awestruck. She bowed.

"It is lovely to see you again Princess Glimmer. I heard we are having breakfast with the Master Archer as well?" Humor shone through Adora’s voice. Bow reacted immediately, reaching out to offer his hand.

"Yes! A pleasure to meet you, I'm Bow!" As they took their seat, they both stared at She-ra looking like they were solving a puzzle. Glimmer sat across from Catra, as was customary, and Bow sat at her side.

"I imagine, given that She-ra is showing her face to all of us that the debriefing went well yesterday?" Glimmer inquired cautiously, eyes darting between Catra and Adora.

"It went rather well I thought.” Catra sent a sidelong look to Adora. Adora stared back, mouth twitching into a smile. “Tell me Glim, does her face look familiar at all to you?" Catra prompted.

"She kind of looks like Adora." Pain flashed in her eyes as she whispered the admission. "It didn’t feel right to bring up." Glimmer finished, holding Catra’s eyes.

Catra appreciated the sentiment. If it truly wasn’t Adora the observation would have been unbearably painful as it was the night before.

Catra looked at Adora’s face, so high up compared to the rest of them. Catra gave Adora nod a of encouragement. She-ra’s body

then started to shrink and with a flash, Adora was sitting in her chair at her normal height. Adora sent her friends a beaming smile.

"She-ra looks like me because she is me. I've missed you both." Adora reached her arm over the table to squeeze both of their hands. "We have a lot to discuss." Adora said seriously.

Glimmer and Bow gaped at Adora for a few moments, not moving at all. Then Glimmer practically teleported over the table and squeezed Adora into a hug. Both the Brightmooners had tears in their eyes.

"But how?" Glimmer sputtered. "You just became a warrior princess overnight? Where have you been?" She demanded.

Adora flashed a smile, aiming for levity.

"I've been locked away in an ancient She-ra temple. Whenever I tried to escape a pack of giant spiders would chase after me. Nasty business." Adora briefed Glimmer and Bow on what happened to her in the last three years.

"I assume Queen Angella failed to convince the council to allow you both to marry?" Adora's eyes were full of sympathy. She too once feared a different council's disapproval of her union to Catra.

"Yeah. You know how Bright Moon's council is. Norwyn refuses to cede, and the council follows whatever he has to say." Glimmer's eyes flashed in anger. She put an arm around herself. "I think mom really means it when she said she wanted us to have the choice to be married but it's still frustrating."

Bow reached out a hand to comfort Glimmer. Adora used that as a segue.

"We need to discuss your engagement to Catra." Adora stated plaintively. Glimmer looked at Adora oddly.

"I mean, you're alive there isn't a betrothal anymore, I'm assuming." She carried on slowly, her eyes widened with horror as a thought occurred to her. "You know there is nothing between Catra and I! My heart has always been and will always be with Bow. Are you mad at me?" Glimmer's voice grew higher pitched as she continued. Adora smiled indulgently.

"No Glimmer. I'm not angry at anyone. I disappeared for three years I couldn't have expected everything to be exactly as it was when I left." Adora turned to look at Catra. "You know I would have understood if you had moved on, don't you?" Catra rolled her eyes, scoffing at her love.

"There is no other for me Adora. And for the record, if I do end up disappearing you have to wait at least five years, or I *will* hold it against you." Adora looked up at the ceiling as if praying for patience. She kissed Catra's nose.

"No one is disappearing, stop being so dramatic." Adora shifted her attention to the rest of the table. "Regardless there is a formal engagement still, my reappearance doesn't stop that."

"How could it not? I mean you are alive! Catra is already married. Hard to marry someone who already has a wife, unless she is from Plumeria or Salineas." Glimmer rebutted.

"Technically, I'm not married to Catra anymore. I'm legally dead. Our marriage ended with my pronounced death." Catra didn't like the sound of that. From the tense set of her shoulders, Catra would guess that Adora wasn't too pleased with the idea either. Adora directed her next words at Catra.

"There has to be a way to undo that," Catra argued.

"There isn't, I'd been researching it with Tao," Adam explained. Adam read the curiosity in Catra's stare and continued to clarify. "I told him that I was curious about the legal effects if Adora ever came back. I think he thought it was a way that I was coping with

my grief, so he helped me look through the library for answers. The marriage can’t be reinstated under Halfmoon law.”

"If we wanted to get married again, I'd have to court you anew,” Adora informed her. She tilted her head to the side. “Although I'd have a better starting position with the mantel of the Princess of Power." She mused.

Catra felt her heart flutter. Adora was such a sap. She missed her so much.

"Etheria’s champion, how could I refuse?” Catra’s tone made it almost a taunt. “You've been thinking about marrying me again, princess?" Catra teased, grabbing Adora’s hand and holding it. Adora flushed red.

"I might have thought about it," Adora said petulantly. It was one of the things Adora daydreamed about in the weeks when she had to remain anonymous in Halfmoon. Adora heard a retching noise from her left.

"You guys are even grosser than when you were married." Adam chimed in. Adora kicked the leg of his chair, almost making him fall backward, but he caught himself right before he truly lost balance. Better luck next time.

"Adam and I have discussed this at length since we reconnected. I don't think it is a good idea to break off the betrothal right now for a few reasons." Adora held up one finger.

“First, the Halfmoon and Bright Moon partnership is centering the larger Alliance. From what Adam has told me you two have worked miracles in the last few months. Destabilizing the relations between the two kingdoms could set us back years." Adora scanned the faces of her closest confidants, watching them react to her logic. "Second, Glimmer is a way better political partner than I ever would be."

Catra was going to interrupt, not wanting to hear a word of Adora being anything but an excellent partner, but Adora silenced her

with a look.

"It's true, love. Glimmer was born to be a diplomat and the betrothal gives her a chance to lead. I was born to defend my kingdom’s honor and follow orders." Adora held up another finger. "Third, if my identity is disclosed, which I assume would happen if you break off the engagement and I retake my place as Queen of Halfmoon, I worry that the other princesses would grow mistrustful of my ability to guard Etheria. It's a clear conflict. Never mind the complications of a regent being chosen as Etheria’s champion."

Adora took a deep breath before starting her final point.

"I think the engagement needs to stay. I'm not advocating for you two to actually wed. I don't know that I would be strong enough to support that, even for the good of Etheria.” Adora squeezed Catra’s hand and sent her a tender look. “But maintaining the status quo has undeniable advantages," Adora concluded.

Silence went through the breakfast table as they all looked at each other. Bow spoke up first.

"I won't lie and say this has been easy for me. I think the only one who may come close to understanding is Adora." Adora and Bow exchanged an indecipherable look. Adora knew that Bow also felt the same deep pang that she felt in her bones from just thinking of Catra tying herself to another. "But Adora makes some solid points. And to be honest it's a load off my chest to know that Glimmer won't actually marry Catra. I think we should keep this up and regroup in a few months." Bow allowed, crossing his arms and leaning back in his chair.

Catra flashed a look at Glimmer, who was worrying her lip. She then turned her attention to the table at large.

"We were planning on having the wedding in three months’ time." Catra winced. They hadn't told anyone yet. Adora stared back agog.

"How could you manage a royal wedding in three months? It took us a year and you threatened to elope every fifth day! And I wasn't even a princess then!" Adora said flabbergasted.

"I'm King now and it isn't a love match. No one is expecting an extravagant affair given the resources that are being diverted into the war effort." Catra explained.

"Well then, push it back. We will find a more permanent solution to the long-term relationship between Bright Moon and Halfmoon later." Adora proposed.

Catra felt a pit in her stomach as she thought of the potentially disastrous consequences for Halfmoon if they didn't manage to find a permanent solution. She groaned, putting her hand in her face for a moment before sitting upright in her chair. Her gaze turned to Glimmer.

"I'm sorry I asked you to do this, Glim. I thought I was being kind when I was actually being cruel to you and Bow. I was just worried about my own feelings." She had a newfound appreciation for how difficult this situation must be for Glimmer and Bow.

She can't bear the thought of Adora and her remaining unmarried even as a temporary solution to their problems. The thought of marrying someone else even worse than before. How did Glimmer and Bow stand the idea of hiding their love, of this engagement. She felt like a total cad.

Glimmer gave Catra a soft smile.

"I know you weren't trying to hurt us Catra. You wanted to unite us against the Horde. I can't imagine poor Scorpia dealing with this well." Adora's head snapped to attention. Catra saw as her eyes started glowing a sustained blue.

"Exactly how many members of the Alliance were vying for Catra's attention?" Adora gritted out. The muscles in Adora's jaw seemed to be working overtime.

“Relax princess, you look like you are about turn two feet taller.” Adora seemed to realize that her eyes were glowing as she closed them for a moment, her cheeks flushing a deep pink.

“I just- I feel caught off guard!” Adora defended. Glimmer squinted at Adora.

"There is something I don’t understand. If you are worried about bias, why did you insist on pledging your fealty to Halfmoon?" She wondered aloud.

Just like that, Adora’s flush died down and in its place was a self-satisfied smirk. Adora knew that the pledge of fealty had been a selfish desire of hers, but she couldn’t help but do it when the opportunity presented itself.

"Well, I wanted to give the Alliance an explanation for why I wanted to reveal my identity to Catra. It also gave me leeway to stay here in Halfmoon. I needed to be here with you all to decide the best move going forward. I couldn't do it alone." Adora then directed her next words at Catra, absolutely beaming. "Also, when I first moved to Halfmoon, Catra refused my oath of fealty because she wanted us to be equals. Now that she has accepted She-ra’s fealty in front of the Alliance, she will have to allow it." Adora preened.

Catra let out a long-suffering groan.

"Of course that's why you did that,” Catra muttered, leveling Adora with a glare. “You swore your love to me, Adora. That means more than any other pledge you might make to me in this life. I didn't want you to be my knight, I wanted you to be my wife."

It was an old argument that cropped up routinely in their married life, mostly in jest but sometimes it got more heated than necessary.

“Okay lovebirds, as happy as I am with all the news this morning, we have to make a plan.” Glimmer leaned back in her chair. “What

are we reporting to the Alliance?” Glimmer asked. Bow cut in.

“I think we are in agreement to keep the betrothal as is and to maintain Adora’s identity a secret for now.” Bow looked around the table for reassurance. Adora contemplated his words.

"If you both only thought She-ra looked like me, then I don't think any Alliance member is going to make the leap that I, the long disappeared and presumed dead Queen of Halfmoon, and She-ra are the same person." Adora thought aloud. Glimmer nodded along.

“I agree. I don’t think people will expect to see Adora in She-ra so they won’t.” Glimmer continued weaving Adora’s cover story. "We say she was a low-level Bright Moon Guard and keep the rest of the story true. The Whispering Woods rest between Halfmoon and Bright Moon anyway. We show her face. That'll keep the Alliance satisfied." Glimmer assured. Catra liked the plan but felt there was one problem.

“That doesn’t explain why She-ra wanted to pledge fealty to Halfmoon.” Catra pointed out. Glimmer’s smile twinkled, looking like she was waiting for Catra’s question.

“That’s what makes it better. She-ra was interested in pledging her allegiance to Bright Moon’s princess but feared it would be too telling. Pledging her fealty to the kingdom she will soon lead is just as good.” Glimmer looked a touch smug. “It fits with our cover story and throws off any questions of a connection between you and She-ra.” Glimmer explained. Catra huffed, impressed.

“You do think of everything, don’t you Glimmer.” Glimmer smiled like the cat that caught the canary.

“I do, don’t I?” Glimmer buffed out her nails on her robe. Catra groaned.

“I’m so glad we aren’t actually getting married I might murder you.” From there, with a plan mostly in place, the rest of breakfast

was a more ordinary affair with the group catching Adora up on what she had missed in the last three years.

Since their betrothal, Glimmer has joined Catra for all Halfmoon council meetings. Adora wanted to come to the council meeting today but Catra worried that Teela or perhaps Tao would recognize She-ra's face as Adora's.

"I wanted to inform you all of some unexpected but welcome news. The warrior known as She-ra has not only joined the Alliance but also pledged her fealty to Halfmoon." Catra declared.

The council members were a mix of shocked and elated, a few clapping out their approval. Adam could barely hide his smug smirk.

"Who is this warrior that pledges her fealty? What if she is just a spy planted by the Horde?" Percival questioned. "It seems a little too good to be true that a mythical warrior appears from the ether so close to one of the Horde's largest military victories." Percival, as always, made to challenge Catra. Catra smiled sweetly at him.

"We verified her identity and that she possesses the Sword of Protection. I personally guarantee that she is no traitor." The idea of Adora being in league with the Horde is laughable at best.

"We just need to take your word for it?" Percival scorned.

"Yes," Catra stated, deadpan. "It is the word of your King and it would do you well to remember that." It was like Percival was born to be a constant irritating thorn in Catra's side. Catra directed her next words to the council at large, both hands gripping the dais.

"I am pleased to announce that Halfmoon has cemented its status within the Alliance and the influence that Glimmer and I have is unprecedented. With the addition of Etheria's champion I have no doubt that the course of the war will turn swiftly in our direction." Catra's chest puffed out, proud.

“I have heard of the stories of She-ra and had even met a few magicat elders that remember She-ra from before our time underground. This news should be welcomed by all on Etheria as a sign of the beginning of the end for the Horde.” Tao stated. Glimmer spoke up. She was less active in Halfmoon council meetings than Catra but she usually had some good points to make.

“Now that we have She-ra, we have to consider where we should station her. Although it will ultimately be the Princess Alliance that decides, I think we should go to the next Alliance meeting prepared with suggestions as to where She-ra should be stationed.” Glimmer noted. Everything freezes inside of Catra at the thought of Adora out in the midst of battle. “I think for now scouting in Plumeria or the Scorpioni Kingdom, two of the most affected by the Horde would be a good place to start. I would love a report on your thoughts Tao or Cloudfoot.” Glimmer continued, not noticing Catra’s emotions.

“I would be happy to provide you a report Princess.” Cloudfoot readily agreed. Catra collected herself.

“On a final note, Glimmer and I have decided that we would prefer a longer engagement. We find that the use of resources that could be going towards the war efforts would not be appropriate at this time.” Catra tried to slip it in towards the end of the meeting, hoping for no questions.

“I disagree, your majesty,” Cloudfoot stated boldly. “Although a royal wedding would take some resources the morale boost that it would bring amongst both the civilians and the Etherian Army would more than makeup for it.” Cloudfoot dutifully pointed out. Catra sighed but nodded her understanding.

“Your point is well taken Councilman Cloudfoot. I will consider your position and we can discuss it further when setting a wedding date at a future council meeting.” Cloudfoot nodded, appeased. “If that is all, this meeting has adjourned.” Catra knew

she needed to talk to someone, and the only person she trusted with this was Tao.

A few hours later, Catra cornered Tao in his office. She longed to go find Adora but that would have to wait. Tao brightened when Catra arrived.

“Your majesty, how lovely to see you. I feel so relieved to have Etheria’s champion fighting on behalf of Halfmoon. That is really something.” He looked at Catra conspiratorially. “Can I meet her? I was surprised you didn’t bring her to the council meeting if she was nearby.” Tao looked put out, his nose and ears twitching.

“You have already met her.” Catra informed him. Tao’s tail dipped off to the side in obvious confusion.

“How could that be? I think I would remember meeting a magical Etherian warrior.” Tao said incredulously. Catra took a deep breath.

“Tao. It’s her. Adora.” Catra admitted. Tao’s eyes shined with tears, his eyebrows raised in surprise.

“What? That is amazing news! Adora has returned?” Tao’s voice is filled with awe and his tail thumped excitedly.

“I am so happy I could burst into pieces.” Catra lowered her voice to a whisper. Catra thinks of that moment when Adora was in front of her for the first time in years. She sighs, a faraway look in her eye.

“Where has she been? Why was she gone so long?” Tao questioned.

“Apparently she was trapped by one of She-ra’s supposed guides. I don’t understand how she can be so committed to something that imprisoned her for over three years.” Catra’s mood soured at the thought. “I worry about her being She-ra.” Catra admitted in a quiet whisper. She ran her hand through the tufts of hair by her cheeks.

“You heard Glimmer at the council meeting. She is going to be out in the front lines. I must be here, leading from the safety of the castle. How will I bear letting her out of my sight? I just got her back.” Catra’s claws came out against her will, as if ready to attack any threat on Adora. Tao placed a comforting hand on Catra’s shoulder.

“My child, you have always found the strength to do what is right. You are headstrong, just like your mother, but you are calculating like your father. I have no doubt that you will find a way to both end the war and be with Adora.” Tao placated. Catra hesitated, eyeing her advisor.

“It’s not just that. I know that Adora has always held strong beliefs when it comes to her duty as a knight but with She-ra it is something different. More.” Catra started to explain. “It feels like She-ra comes above all else for her. Every time she talks about it, it’s destiny this or duty to all Etheria that. She is never just Adora. My wife.” Catra’s grabbed her tail in her hand, a habit from when she was younger and uncertain.

“And how might she feel with you, King Catra? When have you ever been separate from Halfmoon? When has your duty not come first within your marriage?” Tao challenged with a wry smile on his face.

“That’s different Tao and you know it.” Catra accused.

“Why? Because you were born into it?” Tao raised an eyebrow, waiting for a response. Catra huffed.

“No, because I don’t let it take over my life.” Tao sends her an incredulous look.

“Are you trying to tell me that you haven’t been too involved in the ongoings of the world in the last three years?” Tao might as well be dressing down a kitten based on the look he gave Catra. She growled.

“Fine, you are right. I have been very involved, but I’ve been grieving. This is how I was dealing with her being away. Also, there has been a war going on.” Catra pointed out.

“You mean the same war She-ra will be fighting?” Tao smirked. Catra rolled her eyes.

“There is no winning with you Tao, I don’t know why I bother.” Catra threw her hands up in the air.

“My child. You aren’t looking for comfort, because you came to me, the only person in your council that isn’t afraid to tell you that you are wrong.” Tao explained, eyes warm. He looked thoughtful. “What will you do about the wedding?” He asked.

“That’s why we want to push the wedding back. We are looking to end the war before we will have to marry, just hold the engagement up in the short time.” Catra explained. Tao’s pressed his lips into a tight line, eyes narrowed.

“You know, that isn’t going to resolve the problem Catra. Bright Moon is an old people with old ways. Calling off the engagement should not be done lightly, war or no war.” Tao warned.

“I know, I know that, but I can’t marry Glimmer. I have limits and this is one of mine. Before when I thought Adora was gone forever, I convinced myself I could, but it was a pipe dream. I should have found another way as Teela advocated.” Catra groaned, wishing she had never given in.

“I understand young one. I would not expect you to marry another when your love is safe and home. I support you and I will try to think of a solution with our quandary with Bright Moon. I doubt it will take this engagement falling apart lightly.” Tao worried his lip with the edge of his fang. He then took both of Catra’s shoulders in his hands, eyes clear again. “I am proud of everything you have accomplished. I know that with you at the helm, we will be safe from the Horde soon enough. The rest will come with time.” Catra dearly hoped her advisor was right.

“Adora, what are you doing up still?” Glimmer stood by the door of She-ra’s makeshift study. She closed it quickly when she noticed Adora was not holding her She-ra form.

“I’m just reading more reports.” Adora yawned. She spent the week preparing for her bid to be officially accepted into the Princess Alliance. The dynamics had changed substantially since the last time she was in a position of power.

“You look like you’ve been run over by a horse.” Glimmer observed.

Adora was physically tired from having to maintain She-ra’s form anytime there was a chance someone could see her. She was only ever allowed to be Adora in the safety of her room, or in strategy meetings under lock and key. Adora was also mentally exhausted from reacquainting herself with political relations between the kingdoms.

“I might be a little tired.” Adora conceded. She looked down at the table absolutely covered in papers. “I just had some military strategy reports pending, and I thought I’d be better served looking at them.”

When she wasn’t preparing for the meeting in Salineas, she studied the new military reports coming in from the war front. That, she understood better. Glimmer just eyed her doubtfully. Adora could feel the judgment of her stare pricking at her skin.

“I need to be prepared for the warfront Glimmer.” She knew she would make a difference there, not sitting in on Alliance meetings.

“Adora, how long have you been trying to read that one report?” Glimmer asked knowingly.

Adora recalled feeling her gaze running over the report she was trying to finish but she couldn’t understand the words any longer.

“A while,” Adora grumbled. “But this is the last time I will have a chance to look over reports before the Halfmoon contingent heads off to Salineas tomorrow.” Adora pointed out.

“Maybe if you rest you won’t fall asleep in the Alliance meeting?” Glimmer suggested. Adora was about to protest when she closed her eyes for a moment to rest them and could feel just how bone-tired she was. Maybe sleep would be for the best.

“You’re right Glim. I’ll head off to bed.” Adora picked up her reports and sorted them into piles then turned into She-ra before opening the door to exit the study.

“Goodnight Adora. Don’t keep Catra up.” Glimmer teased. Adora refused to comment on that.

“Goodnight Glimmer. Sweet dreams.” She returned.

As Adora did every day, she snuck into Catra’s chambers through her window, using She-ra’s strength and larger frame to reach where others could not. Once she made it inside, she willed her body to let go of She-ra’s magic, leaving just Adora in her place.

She saw Catra laying in her bed almost curled into herself with her duvet up to her chin, back pointedly facing away from the window. Adora frowned and slowly approached the bed.

Adora crawled onto the mattress and noticed how Catra’s shoulders tensed as she felt the mattress dip.

“Catra. Are you alright? Is there anything I can do for you?” Adora reached a tentative hand out to gently touch Catra’s shoulder. Catra turned to face Adora, her eyes were brimming with tears.

"I just got you back. How am I supposed to allow you in harm’s way?" Catra hiccupped. Understanding dawned on Adora.

“Oh Catra, come here.” She wrapped her arms around Catra as she rubbed soothing circles down her back. She placed a kiss at

the base of one of her ears. “What brought this on? I thought things were fine when I last saw you.” Catra sniffled.

“At the Halfmoon council meeting, we discussed the next steps after you are formally accepted into the Alliance. Glimmer started talking about which battlefronts would be most advantageous for you to fight in and I felt so stupid.” Catra wept. “I was so busy feeling relief that you are alive and preparing for the next Alliance meeting that I didn’t think about you being on the war front,” Catra admitted.

Catra burrowed her head into Adora’s chest as if she could hide from the idea of Adora going to the war front. Catra scent marked her, claiming Adora as hers. Adora cursed herself for not thinking to discuss this with Catra before tonight. Adora kept her tone gentle.

“Catra, I know this is not an easy thing for any of us. Look at me.” She placed a finger under Catra’s chin to encourage her to look up. Catra’s big tearful eyes, one blue and one amber, bore into Adora’s. “The sword chose me for a reason. I must believe that I’ll have what it takes to protect Etheria. But most of all-” Adora placed a soft kiss on Catra’s forehead “-I know that there is nothing that could keep me from you.” Adora took a shuddering breath.

“I can’t imagine what you’ve been through Catra. I always knew you were out here alive and well, all I needed was to reach you. You never had those assurances. But know this.” Adora held Catra’s face in her hands, allowing Catra to nuzzle into her. “No matter how improbable it might seem, I will return to you always. I promise.” Catra’s grip on Adora tightened.

“I know you had this destiny foisted upon you, but why does it have to keep you apart from me?” She all but whined. Adora sighed.

“This sword will not keep us apart forever. You’ll see love. We can make it through this and soon we can have what we always

dreamed of. A peaceful Etheria where we can be together, no holds bar.” Adora kept drawing soothing circles on Catra’s back with callused fingers, feeling the tension slowly seep out of her small frame.

“I’m holding you to that, princess.” Catra’s tears subsided and she laid on her side like she normally did when she was falling asleep. Adora felt Catra wrap her tail around Adora’s thigh.

“Of course, dearest. It’ll be you and me at the end of the world.” Adora promised.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed this week's chapter! We have hit the halfway point on this fic! This chapter was a little slow going, but it provided a lot of needed context for what is about to happen. As always, I appreciate any comments or kudos, it really encourages me to write and post!

Next week: She-ra faces the Alliance and many unexpected repercussions follow.

The Price of Betrothal

Chapter Summary

She-ra becomes a member of the Princess Alliance.

Bright Moon voices their concerns.

Things fall apart.

Chapter Notes

I hope you enjoy this one!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora always disliked traveling to Salineas, it was always a long and tiresome affair. Adora remembered dragging her feet when it came to visiting that particular kingdom before her disappearance. It was also a difficult travel day in terms of conversation.

Glimmer wilted because there was no reasonable pretext for Bow to join them on this trip and Catra brooded over their impending separation.

Although they left in the early morning, the Halfmoon contingent did not arrive at the seaside castle until late at night. Queen Mermista was there to greet them.

Adora called on She-ra's form for the last leg of the trip and was unencumbered by her armor as she entered the castle. All the guards eyed her wearily, a reaction she often endured since becoming She-ra. Mermista's eyes widened as she took in Adora.

"I see you weren't exaggerating about being a warrior princess. I thought I imagined how tall and strong you are." Mermista's voice dropped as she walked closer. Adora felt her shoulders tense under her scrutiny. Catra's voice cut through the awkward silence.

“If you are done gawking at her Mermista, we had a long travel day and would appreciate being well rested before the Alliance meeting tomorrow.” Mermista rolled her eyes.

“As if you haven’t been enjoying the new views at Halfmoon.” Mermista rebuffed, rolling her eyes. Catra stared unflinchingly until Mermista turned around to walk back towards the castle.

“I’ll take you to your rooms, most of the other Alliance members are already here. We are only missing Scorpia, she should arrive tomorrow morning.” Mermista led them to a wing Adora recognized as the guest wing from the few times she previously stayed overnight as Glimmer’s guard.

“We have a room for She-ra and one for the Halfmoon regents.” Mermista glanced at Catra. “I know I typically give you and Glimmer separate rooms since you aren’t wed yet, but attendance is higher this meeting given that She-ra is expected to join the Alliance. We are at capacity with guest rooms.”

Mermista sent Adora a sly smirk.

“My room is in the next wing over if you need anything. Have a goodnight.” Mermista left them in the hallway, closing out her hosting duties for the night.

The three of them stepped into She-ra’s room. Adora transformed back to her own body, a welcome respite after being She-ra for a few hours.

“Well, if Mermista’s warm welcome is any indication, you’ll make it onto the Alliance just fine.” Glimmer teased. Catra let out a growl.

“Mermista treated Adora like a piece of meat. It was unacceptable and a breach of decorum.” Glimmer scoffed.

“Please, you were eyeing her the same before you knew it was Adora. You are just angry that you are going to deal with a bunch of Alliance members ogling Adora tomorrow.” Catra harrumphed,

neither confirming nor denying that statement. Adora smiled at Catra.

"You have nothing to worry about Catra I only have eyes for you," Adora reassured her.

"It's not *your* eyes I'm worried about," Catra grumbled. Adora let out a laugh.

"If anyone makes me uncomfortable, I'll say something. It'll be fine." She placated, reaching out to hold Catra's hand. "Now, do you think there is any chance we could switch rooms?" Adora said as she tugged Catra closer. She knew it was a long shot, but she had to try.

"As much as I would love to switch rooms and get a huge bed for myself, I don't think we can risk you and Catra being seen coming out of the same room. The scandal would be too great." Glimmer pointed out. "I'll have to deal with Catra's snoring tonight."

"I don't snore!" She objected, tail sticking straight out. Adora laughed at the look of full offense on her face.

"It's a very cute snore, love." She told her as she placed a kiss on her head. Catra held her chest as if wounded.

"I see how you band together against me. I'll see myself out." Catra tiptoed to press a soft kiss to Adora's lips. "I'll miss you. I'll see you at the meeting tomorrow morning." Catra whispered.

Adora leaned forward to capture Catra's lips again.

"I'll be counting the minutes," Adora replied. Glimmer looked a bit green around the gills.

"Okay both of you are gross, Adam wasn't kidding. Let's get to our room before someone catches us still up." Glimmer and Catra left, leaving Adora alone in the too-quiet room.

The next morning, Adora wandered the halls looking for someplace to eat. She hadn't seen Glimmer or Catra this morning and she felt antsy about it.

It didn't help that she tossed and turned all night without Catra at her side. They had only been sleeping together for a week but sleeping apart already felt strange again.

She picked up the sound of Catra's voice down the corridor. As she turned to look for the door, two guards standing in the hallway blocked her path.

"Sorry but this breakfast hall is reserved for only the Alliance representatives." One guard announced crossing his arms over his chest in an attempt to look intimidating.

The other looked nervously at Adora, his hands twitching towards his baton. She would love to see him try. Adora purposefully leaned forward, towering over both guards as her eyes glowed a bright blue. Their knees started to tremble and the second guard's face paled.

"Not a problem, sir. Have a great day." She walked away without a backward glance. She navigated two other hallways till she found another breakfast hall that seemed open. She picked up some food and sat to eat on her own.

She could see who she assumed were Salinean leaders sitting together. The moment she walked into the room there was dead silence but then whispers and glances picked up tenfold.

Adora suppressed the urge to roll her eyes as they all talked about her, failing to employ even a modicum of discretion. Her stomach twisted nervously. It reminded her of when she was a child back in her village and the other children would glance at the rags she wore and turn their nose at her and Adam.

Once she finished breakfast, she beelined to the chambers where she knew the meeting was taking place. Once again, she was

stopped by a guard. This one had the decency to look Adora in the face even if she had to crane her head up.

"The Alliance representatives have started their meeting. They will be calling on relevant persons as needed. Please feel free to sit as you wait." The guard delivered the words methodically. It was clearly a canned response.

"Alright." She knew she should be more polite to the guards, considering she had been in their position before, but she really couldn't bother with her nerves kicking in. She found a seat in the corner of the outer chamber, and looked down, clasping her hands together.

The Salinean leaders started trailing into the outer chamber as well, eyeing her as they found seats. Great. In this form she couldn't blend in, so she stuck out like a sore thumb, an exhibit for viewing. She hadn't felt this on display since she and Catra did their first tour of Halfmoon as a married couple.

She saw, one by one, the local leaders entered and exited the meeting room, usually taking less than fifteen minutes inside. She tried to still her leg which kept bouncing, shaking the chair she sat in.

Finally, once she was the only person left in the outer chamber, a guard stepped out of the Alliance meeting room and cautiously approached her.

"Ma'am, I believe the Alliance requires your presence." Adora hopped out of her seat, startling the guard.

"Lead the way then." She followed the guard closely, anxious to finally get inside.

As she entered the meeting room, she noted that it was structured very differently from the one in Halfmoon. Everything was brighter, with large windows that held a fantastic view of the ocean.

In the center of the room, there was a raised platform that had a large crescent-shaped table. All the Alliance members sat around the outer edge. Adora was surprised to see Catra and Glimmer near the center with Mermista.

Adora drank in the sight of Catra looking every bit the King she was, totally in her element. Even though it had been a few hours since she had seen Catra, she missed her.

"Welcome She-ra, Princess of Power. Our next order of business is your potential admission to the Princess Alliance." Catra looked so at ease sitting front and center, directing the Alliance meeting. All the Alliance members stared at either Catra or Adora.

Adora moved forward and bowed before the Alliance. Before Catra.

"Thank you for considering my petition," Adora murmured. She looked up, catching Catra's gaze.

Adora could feel her face heat as Catra slowly looked her up and down. Catra then looked to either side as she directed her words at the other Alliance members.

"Glimmer and I investigated the claims and found that this is in fact She-ra, as evidenced by the Sword of Protection and her ability to tap into Etheria's core magic." Catra looked around at the Alliance members as she spoke.

"As you can see, She-ra agreed to not conceal her face any longer. I will secede the floor to her so she can provide a more complete explanation." Adora thought of the cover story that she Glimmer, Bow, and Catra crafted in Halfmoon.

"Thank you, my liege. I come from humble beginnings. To honor my family and my Kingdom, Bright Moon, I trained to become a guard. I held guard duties on the farther end of the Bright Moon castle which faces the whispering woods." Adora began, she tried to make eye contact with all the Alliance members as she spoke. "The woods called to me with visions of the Sword of Protection.

It was a siren call, impossible to ignore. I am ashamed to say I abandoned my post and everything I held dear to investigate."

She stared at Catra as she said this, what she hoped was a clear apology in her eyes. Catra averted her gaze.

"I found the sword, but it came with a price. I was imprisoned for some time in a place called the Crystal Castle with Light Hope, a spirit of Etheria and guider of She-ra as my jailer. She promised to release me once my training was completed." Adora tried to keep the anger out of her voice. "I was released shortly after the battle at Bright Moon, and I knew that I wanted to be brought in front of the Alliance. I heard that Adam, who I knew when we were guards at Bright Moon, was now the councilman of Halfmoon and that Princess Glimmer, who I once swore fealty to, was also residing there." These were all technically truths.

"That empowered my decision to contact Adam to see if introductions could be made. That is when I met you all last week." Adora let out a sharp breath as she completed her retelling. "I seek to become a member of the Alliance to aid the larger efforts to stop the Horde. Although I was chosen by the Sword of Protection to fight for Etheria, I am not arrogant enough to think I could do this on my own. In me, you would find a loyal ally."

"I thought that you were concerned for your identity?" Netossa, the leader of a small Bright Moon fiefdom, questioned Adora. Adora remembered reading in one of the reports that Catra appointed her as a military strategist. Adora would be working closely with her if she were admitted into the Alliance.

"Yes, Duke Netossa. I did not know this before the last meeting but becoming She-ra seemed to have radically changed my face. I don't think anyone who knew me before my transformation would know me now." Adora swallowed thickly.

"You are always running around as an eight-foot warrior with a cool sword?" The youngest Alliance member, Frosta, Princess of

the Northern Reach, seemed excited by the prospect.

“Yes. Since I first held the sword, I permanently changed into She-ra. I hope that maybe when balance is restored to the planet, I might be returned to my previous body.” This is the largest lie they decided to sell today. If she was permanently She-ra, there would be no question of whether She-ra was Adora, in case she was ever caught untransformed.

“I for one, am all for having She-ra around,” Mermista stated. Catra shot her a glance but waited for other Alliance members to weigh in.

“I think it’s only logical that we admit her into the Alliance. In all likelihood, she will increase our odds of destroying the Horde. And maybe she will let me experiment with her sword if she is an Alliance member!” Entrapta, the Princess of Dryl, said brightly. Adora paled at the thought of letting Entrapta tinker with the Sword of Protection.

Around the table, I seemed that most were nodding in agreement, and a few started discussing with their neighbors. Catra cleared her throat and all Alliance members looked her way.

“I agree with Mermista and Entrapta. I think we would do well to have She-ra on our side, not only as a weapon,” Catra winced slightly at the characterization, “but as a symbol of hope for the common Etherian. I propose that we admit She-ra into the Alliance and make a public announcement welcoming her.”

The Alliance members unanimously voted to admit She-ra. Adora felt vast relief. She was in. One step closer to doing what she was destined to do.

Catra once again was laying on the chaise in Tao’s study. He looked at her bemusedly.

“You know, your majesty, maybe you need to speak with your wife about all of this.” Tao mused.

“What wife? You mean the one I declared dead so I could marry another?” Catra did not open her eyes from where she lay. She was in a self-pitying mood.

“You can be so dramatic, your majesty.” Tao intoned.

“That is literally what happened Tao.” Catra snapped an eye open, looking at her advisor.

“The last few months with She-ra on the battlefield have been a tremendous success. The reports show she and Duke Netossa are also working well together when implementing military strategies.” Tao pointed out. Catra sat upon the chaise.

“Yes, I know, but she is usually stationed with the battalion in most danger at all times. Whatever is most critical to the mission, she is there.” Catra grabbed a pillow and held it to her chest, ears twitching. “I just miss her. It feels like I’ve barely gotten to see her since she was admitted into the Alliance. She is always off to some war-torn village while I am here, leading and waiting for news.” Catra whimpered.

“Oh, Catra. It is normal to miss her.” Tao reasoned, walking closer to Catra. She scoffed.

“I thought it might be easy even, given how long we were apart. But three years of practice haven’t taught me how to be without Adora. If anything, I feel like every day I ache in new ways without her.” Catra put her face into the pillow, tempted to scream.

“It is different to miss someone with the hope that you will see them once more, than when you have lost all hope.” Tao’s face was all sympathy as he put his hand on Catra’s shoulder.

“That’s exactly right, Tao.” Before there were times when Catra felt cold and numb, the ache for Adora wasn’t this constant thing she grappled with. She grieved and she set it aside at times for the good of her kingdom.

Now, she was constantly vigilant of any news of where She-ra was, if she survived the latest battle, where she was off to next.

“You know how ridiculous I’ve become? I have a map where I pin her last known location from the military reports. I think about how it might be if we were there together.” Before she disappeared, there were plenty of far-flung places Catra promised to take Adora to, but there was never time.

“You know that can’t be Catra. As much as she belongs on the battlefront, you belong here. If something were to happen to you, the Alliance would likely crumble.” Tao warned.

“What are you worried I’ll slip off to a battle to see Adora?” Tao eyed her rather distrustfully.

“Maybe.” He said, eyeing his regent.

“I know what my responsibilities are Tao. I know that our duties are far apart from one another and never shall the two meet.” Catra spat out with a sneer, not directed at Tao but at herself. The situation frustrated Catra to no end.

“At least you will see her in the Alliance meetings?” Tao attempted to cheer her but that honestly just made Catra feel worse. She pinned her ears back reflexively.

“The next one is in Plumeria, not here. I’ll likely only see her inside the meeting.” It was so difficult to keep composed, to meet Adora’s eyes over a table discussing a new problem and pretend she wasn’t dying to hold her, greet her properly with a kiss.

Adora usually found some excuse to speak with her alone after the meeting, her eyes warm and loving even as She-ra. If they were lucky, they could find somewhere safe to hold on to each other for a moment before they were sent off to different corners of the world again. Catra didn’t know how much longer she could stand it.

“The one after will be in Halfmoon. Just one month. I know you both spend more time together when she comes here.” Tao comforted.

“That is true, we definitely have more leeway here in Halfmoon.” Adora usually requested leave to arrive at Halfmoon early, then she always lingered a few days after the meetings were long done.

They would spend their nights together, Adora getting a welcome rest from being She-ra, and Catra forgetting that she was King in the quiet moments between them.

During the day, they were joined at the hip, doing business together as they did before the Sword of Protection wreaked havoc on their lives. She missed having Adora with her more than anything.

“I’m sorry for being such a brat about this, I just don’t feel comfortable talking about this with anyone else. I know that I don’t have a choice, but I’m not used to feeling so helpless.” Catra admitted.

“You are not being a brat, as you put it. You are grieving in a whole different way once again. I firmly believe one day, Etheria will allow you peace. You just have to hold on until then, my child.” Catra’s tail lashed behind her in desperation. She wasn’t sure how much longer she could hold on like this.

She sat in her study with Glimmer on a pedestrian Tuesday morning, performing the ministerial tasks that many forgot belonged to royalty. Reading her mail in the morning became a difficult task for Catra now that She-ra was on the battlefield.

Each letter she received brought renewed worries that she would hear the worst about her love. The latest letter she received worried her, but for an entirely different reason.

"Glim, we have a missive from your mother. We need to read it." Catra waved the letter in her hand.

"I hate when mother writes, that can't be good news." Glimmer groaned. Catra ignored Glimmer's griping and began to read.

Dearest Glimmer and Catra,

I hope this message finds you well. All Bright Moon is abuzz with the news that She-ra, protector of Etheria, has joined the ranks of the Alliance. My representatives tell me you were both instrumental in this addition. I commend you.

I am writing to enquire about your wedding. I would ask that you please keep the council and I apprised of plans for your upcoming nuptials.

Given that you both have publicly committed to this engagement, the council believes it would be of benefit to both Halfmoon and Bright Moon if you wed expeditiously. You have heard my thoughts on the wedding, I will not expound on them here.

I am considering attending the upcoming Alliance meeting so we can discuss this matter further. I look forward to seeing you both.

Forever Yours,

Queen Angella of Bright Moon

Catra stared at the letter, a sense of dread filling her gut. She could read between the lines.

"The Bright Moon council is going to pressure us to speed up the timeline. They want us married as soon as possible." Glimmer looked pale as she listened. Catra groaned, her head thunking forward onto her desk. "Of course, they do! Those cowards ruin everything. I'm willing to bet they think we are trying to find a way for you to marry Bow. That's why they want us married fast."

Glimmer's eyes widened as she grabbed the letter, looking over the contents herself.

"I hadn't even thought about that. I didn't think anyone would want to rush the ceremony given that we are in the middle of a war." She touches her mother's cursive letters with a touch of sadness. Catra scoffed.

"They will argue that it is to raise the morale of Etheria or some other nonsense. Same as Cloudfoot, same as we did, when we pitched the betrothal." Catra stood to pace around her desk as she ran her fingers along the spines of books on the walls of her study. She suddenly stopped. Her fur fluffed straight up as a thought occurred to her. "Can the Bright Moon council renege on the betrothal and send you back to Bright Moon without Angella's approval?"

Glimmer chewed on a pen as she thought of an answer.

"I'm not sure. In theory, they could but it would have to be a supermajority of the council members. Norwyn has sway but I don't think he could get that many votes for this." Glimmer continued to think. "I also don't know that he wants to contradict my mother like that, at least not publicly. It would be a bad look to be sure. Especially since our betrothal is so popular in both kingdoms." Glimmer reasoned.

"We need to prepare a contingency plan. The next Alliance meeting is here in Halfmoon in less than a week and Angella would not send us a warning like that if we didn't need it." Catra argued.

"When is Adora arriving?" Glimmer inquired. Catra groaned again, tail twitching even more than before.

"I have no idea, she was in Plumeria for the last two weeks but the skirmishes there seemed to have lessened enough for her to get leave for the Alliance meeting. My guess would be anytime in the next three days." Catra looked out the window, wishing she

could see She-ra arrive in that very moment. Glimmer ran her fingers through her hair.

"The sooner the better. We need to prepare. I'm going to talk to Bow." Catra was then left alone to stare at her map full of pins, wondering when Adora was going to arrive so they could face things the way they were supposed to. Together.

Adora saw the Horde commander yelling out orders, sending his youngest soldiers out to slaughter. Adora sprinted towards him, bowling him over and pressing her sword to his neck.

She could feel She-ra's power surging through her as she issued a command of her own.

"Call for a retreat, and your death will be merciful." She projected her voice using her magic, it boomed across the battlefield. Every soldier, Horde or Etherian, stopped in uncertainty. AN unknown stillness permeated the battlefield. She pressed the man harder into the ground and he flailed like a chicken, paling under her grip.

"I'll be dead either way. Do what you must." The man had courage at least. Without giving him another moment, her sword cleanly hacked off his head. Blood pooled all over her as an inhuman gurgle sounded from where the man's head had been. She stood, holding the decapitated head up to the Horde soldiers.

"Go back to your encampment and tell Hordak this is the future that he can expect if he continues to delude himself into thinking he can win this war." No one moved, everyone froze in place.

"Go now!" She all but roared, her voice shaking the ground that the Horde soldiers scrambled on. Her own soldiers yipped and cheered, chanting her name. She waved them off.

"See? I told you that with She-ra on our side, there is no way to fail!" She overheard one of the Etherian soldiers say to another. She ducked out of their way as she walked towards their base.

She washed off most of the grime and dirt at a nearby river before finally making it to her tent. Adora took off her helmet. She fastened the closure on her tent before she stripped out of her armor and transformed back into herself. She ran her hands through her newly sheared blonde hair.

She looked more like Adam than ever but looked farther away from any known image of either Queen Adora or She-ra. Having the cropped hair felt right, it made her feel more like the soldier she was, not as She-ra, but Adora.

She dutifully put on her hood, as she always did when she was not in She-ra's form. She laid down, fearing she would fall asleep almost immediately from exhaustion. It was difficult sustaining the magic that made her She-ra for such long periods of time.

Adora loved being on the front lines as She-ra. She could see how all Etherians fought even more ardently when following her into battle. When they looked at her, they saw a literal goddess. Being this symbol of war and peace was equally terrifying and exhilarating.

Still, she rolled in her bed, unable to get the image of blood sputtering in her hands out of her mind. Although it should be a blessing to be She-ra, she was counting the days until she was back in Halfmoon.

Adora didn't think she had ever been so relaxed and at peace, laying in Catra's bed. She just arrived for the Alliance meeting and was overjoyed to be back in Catra's arms where she most belonged. She showed Catra exactly how much she missed her and now she let Catra spoon her, running her fingers along Adora's scalp.

"I don't think I'll ever be used to your hair being quite so short," Catra murmured, placing a sweet kiss where her fingers just brushed.

Adora turned her body, so she laid face up with Catra snuggled on her chest.

"Do you not like it?" She whispered, suddenly feeling self-conscious. Catra shook her head, one of her ears flicked dismissively.

"I like it just fine, it's just strange how you go from having practically no hair to the longest hair I have ever seen multiple times in the same day." Catra teased gently.

Adora didn't have answers for why that was. Even after three years in the Crystal Castle, there were many things about She-ra she didn't understand. Adora felt Catra tense.

"I know you just got home but we need to talk about something urgent. Queen Angella sent a letter implying that the Bright Moon council wanted to expedite the wedding. She is coming to the Alliance meeting this week, I'm sure we will know more then." Catra informed. Adora cursed under her breath.

"I couldn't stand the Bright Moon council as a knight, and I like them even less now. When are they pushing to do this?" Adora cursed. Catra moved her tail up and down Adora's side in a light soothing pattern.

"I have no idea. I don't think we will know until Angella arrives. But Adora-" Catra leaned away so she could catch Adora's gaze. Her eyes, one amber the other blue, shined as she bit her lip with worry. "-we will have to consider ending the betrothal soon and what the fall out with Bright Moon might be."

"You know the Bright Moon council has more power than the council in Halfmoon. Even if Angella is understanding, the council won't be." Catra warned. It was Adora's turn to soothe Catra.

"We won't know what our options are until you and Glimmer get more information from Angella. Who knows how that might impact our decision? And who knows if, with how successful we have been in the last few months, we defeat the Horde before the

wedding becomes an issue for the council." Adora speculated hopefully. Catra snorted.

"Adora, I love you, but the Horde is not going to be defeated tomorrow. We will likely have to make a decision." Adora tightened her hold on Catra.

"But not tonight love. I just arrived a few hours ago and I want to have the rest of the night with you. Either way, until we know more of what is happening in Bright Moon, we won't be able to plan. Let's enjoy the time between now and the Alliance meeting?" Adora proposed. Dropping a kiss between Catra's ears.

Catra stared at Adora, with a look Adora couldn't quite understand. Then her eyes softened and she once again burrowed into Adora, a purr rumbling just beneath the surface as she nuzzled Adora.

"I missed you so much, Adora." Adora smiled and held the person she cared about most on the planet.

"Me too dearest. me too."

Angella arrived at Halfmoon precisely one hour before the Alliance meeting, allowing no room for a private meeting. Catra cursed whatever game Angella and the Bright Moon council were playing.

The Alliance members talked amongst themselves before the start of the meeting, but the room was tense. It was the first time Angella herself represented Bright Moon at an Alliance meeting.

Everyone had an eye for who would be in charge today. Angella sat near the front of her room, her stature outmatched by only She-ra and Princess Scorpia. But whatever height difference there might have been made no difference. Angella was the most commanding presence in the room by far.

Catra watched Angella walk towards She-ra. Adora looked surprised to see Angella approaching her, but they talked

amicably. Catra presumed that Angella was welcoming the newest member of the Alliance, but something about the interaction made her feel uneasy.

As the meeting start time approached, everyone began to take their seats. Catra took her customary place by the dais next to Glimmer. She saw Angella take the seat Bright Moon's representative, Juliet, usually took.

Catra thought she had an understanding with Angella but staring at the woman now, she wasn't so sure. Her eyebrows pinched together and her lips thinned in an uncomfortable expression Catra couldn't decipher. She knew she had to be careful, the last thing she needed was Angella trying to take the reins from her. Catra called the meeting to order.

"This Alliance meeting is called to session. We will be hearing reports. Netossa and She-ra, would you start with the military report?"

"I'm happy to report that the Horde is losing ground and are retreating farther than they have in the last year. There have been fewer sightings of Hordak, which might have to do with how She-ra has been handling his commanders on the field." She picked up on Adora's grimace at that but she didn't know what to make of it. Adora spoke up.

"That being said, the Fright Zone remains their largest stronghold and our efforts haven't affected it much. It is heavily guarded. I think we need to start focusing our efforts there." Adora proposed. Netossa nodded.

"I agree, I think we can accomplish more if we retreat one of the battalions from Salineas and one from Bright Moon and move them to the Scorpioni kingdom," Netossa added on. Netossa and Adora continued to weave their battle plans together, almost thinking with one mind. Catra nodded, satisfied with the proposal.

“I think that sounds reasonable given how far the skirmishes are happening from the southern kingdoms. Let’s put it to a vote after the representatives from those kingdoms speak on it.” Catra gestured towards Mermista.

“Yeah, that’s fine, we have enough resources to make do without a battalion,” Mermista says.

“And Bright Moon?” Catra addressed Angella. All eyes moved to Angella, gauging whether she took offense to not speaking first. She remained impassive.

“I agree with the proposition,” Angella stated curtly. Catra relaxed as the meeting plodded along without much fanfare. Angella was mostly a quiet observer as everyone provided their reports.

It was a bit of a boring meeting if Catra was honest.

As the meeting ended, Catra caught Adora’s eyes from across the table. She was so distracted that she didn’t notice that Angella approached her until she heard her pointedly clear her throat. Catra could feel herself redden.

“I would like a private audience with you both if it’s not too much trouble.” Angella addressed them, although the request felt like an order.

“Of course, we would be delighted mother.” Glimmer answered for them. Catra led mother and daughter through a series of hallways until they reached the castle’s private garden.

Catra thought Angella would like it and hoped to recapture the trust and understanding they found in the Bright Moon gardens over six months before.

It didn’t seem to be working. Once the three of them were alone Angella looked truly irate, openly glaring at Catra. She went straight to the point.

“I find it rather odd how much She-ra looks like your Adora, Catra.” Angella’s words were an open accusation.

Catra closed her eyes cursing herself internally as she heard Glimmer do the same under her breath.

Why did she not realize that Angella, the woman who knighted Adora and appointed her as Glimmer’s personal guard, would recognize her? Catra looked at Glimmer in despair. Glimmer looked like a child ready for a scolding.

“How long did you both think you could keep this farce up? Where you even intending on getting married in the first place?” Angella’s eyes flashed with a wave of deeper anger. “Was Adora even missing at all? I can’t believe you would use my Micah’s disappearance to ingratiate yourself to me.” Angella’s voice gave way to disbelief and hurt. Catra interrupted then.

“No, that is not what happened. Angella please listen to me. I would never have lied to you about believing that Adora was dead.” Catra reached out to touch the other regent’s shoulder. “I swear to you on Halfmoon and on Adora herself that she was lost to me when I approached Glimmer about marriage.”

“I did not know she was alive, and I surely did not know that she was She-ra. You must believe that. I have too much respect for you and your grief to disrespect you this way.” Catra swore, looking Angella straight in the eyes, hoping to be believed. Angella’s expression cleared some.

“You will tell me everything. Both of you. Do not leave out a single detail.” Angella commanded. Catra and Glimmer shared a look and then launched into an explanation of the last few months since Adora’s reappearance.

“She-ra appeared at an Alliance meeting accompanied by Adam. She had her helmet on, so I had no idea it was Adora.” Catra recounted.

“I swear we didn’t know Mom. Catra found out that night and I found out at breakfast the next morning.” Glimmer affirmed.

“By that point, we already ran the Alliance meetings and we committed to getting married. But obviously, Adora being alive changed things.” Catra took a deep breath, looking Angella in the eyes. “I can’t marry Glimmer knowing Adora is alive. We decided to postpone the wedding, to see if we could come up with a solution that didn’t disrupt relations between our two kingdoms but didn’t rely on us getting married.”

Catra gave Angella a pleading look. Glimmer took her mother’s hand in hers.

“The strategy is working. With Adora on the battlefield and us leading the Alliance we can end this war. Fast. Maybe within the year. That’s how long we would need to resolve this Mom.” Glimmer urged.

“Glimmer and I fully intended to wed but now with Adora back I cannot possibly marry another. We were hoping to extend the engagement at least temporarily so that we could continue to work with the Alliance as we have.” Catra hoped their explanation would be enough for Angella to trust them and to maintain relations with Bright Moon.

Glimmer stared pleadingly up at her mother, her short hair swaying in the breeze.

“Mom I know this isn’t what we agreed on, but you can’t argue with the results we are getting right now. You sat in that meeting. you saw how well the Horde is being contained right now.” Glimmer pointed out. “We need to stay in control of the situation for a while longer and any change in the status of the partnership between Bright Moon and Halfmoon jeopardizes that.”

Angella looked understanding, but she wouldn’t quite meet their gaze upfront.

“That is quite troubling. I understand why you both do not want to go through with the wedding, but I fear you might not have a choice.” Angella averted her gaze.

“Why mom? What do you mean?” Glimmer sputtered. Angella sighed, rolling her arms back.

“The Bright Moon council grows impatient. Norwyn and the other council members are suspicious of how suddenly the wedding plans have been halted—” Angella shot them both a disappointed stare “—evidently with good reason.”

“I can try to stall them some, but ultimately the wedding needs to happen soon for the partnership to remain intact,” Angella announced, defeated. Catra felt a knot in her throat, almost blocking out her next words.

“How much time do you think we have Angella?” Angella seemed to ponder this, staring out at the yellow tulips in the far end of the garden.

“I think four months. Maybe six at most.” Angella estimated. “In either case, preparations must begin immediately to ease the council’s nerves. If I can tell Norwyn that planning is on the way, he won’t do anything rash.”

“You can’t do anything else about this mother? You are the Queen of Brightmoon! Why do you constantly bend to the spineless ninnies that make up the council.” Glimmer looked raving mad, and Catra sensed this was not the first time Angella and Glimmer argued over the council this way.

“You know how it is Glimmer, Bright Moon’s monarch does not enjoy the consolidated power found in other kingdoms. My hands are tied if I want to uphold the laws of Bright Moon. I will always put Bright Moon first.” Angella’s argument sounds rote, something she delivered to Glimmer countless times. Tears fell down Glimmer’s face.

“Yes, I know mother. You will always put Bright Moon before me.” Catra winced as she watched Angella recoil as if Glimmer physically attacked her.

“As the Queen of Bright Moon, I refuse to apologize. As your mother, it tears me in two to see you hurting. I don’t have a solution for you girls. Not one that doesn’t end in a marriage anyway.” Angella fixed them with a hard stare. “It is a commitment you both undertook and you must see it through for the stability of not only Halfmoon and Bright Moon, but for all of Etheria.”

Angella’s eyes were downturned, shame clear in them.

“I’m sorry it has to be this way.” She whispered.

Adora paced in the King’s chambers, waiting for Catra’s meeting with Angella to conclude. It took her by surprise when she looked across the room, only to find Catra, Glimmer, and Angella quickly exiting the Princess Alliance meeting together.

It was a stupid thought, that maybe she would have an opportunity to be involved in the meeting. She wondered if this is how Bow felt when these types of meetings occurred, anxious and left out of the loop.

After what felt like ages, but was only a few hours, Catra walked into the bedroom with her head hung low and ears pinned back. Adora could feel her heart beating out of her chest, palms sweating.

“How did it go? What does the Bright Moon council want?” Adora asked, desperate for the information. Catra scoffed a bitter, angry sound.

“A wedding. As soon as possible. Angella thinks the longest she can really give us is six months, but the wedding preparations have to start tomorrow.” Adora took a deep breath, releasing it slowly through her nose.

“That’s not the news we were hoping for.” Adora pointed out unhelpfully. Catra tugged at one of her ears tufts, her voice on the verge of tears.

“Oh no, Adora it gets worse. Angella instantly recognized you. She knows everything. Glimmer and I pleaded with her, but she says the council won’t be swayed.” Catra sat on the edge of the bed, head in her hands. “She will keep your identity secret but that’s the only favor she will do us,” Catra whispered.

Adora felt like the biggest fool on the planet.

“I can’t believe that I didn’t think about that.” Adora groaned, tamping her foot down in frustration. “What are we going to do?”

Catra looked up at her.

“Adora, we need to call off the engagement now and find another way to shore up Bright Moon’s support.” Adora stared at Catra carefully, thinking of how to respond.

“Didn’t Angella just say that was impossible?” Adora reminded her gently. She took in the stubborn set of Catra’s eyes.

“We will find another way. Teela was right about that; we have other tools at our disposal. Now that we have led the Alliance for close to six months, I doubt that a change in the partnership between Halfmoon and Bright Moon necessarily means that we can’t lead. We just need to convince the representatives of our results.” Catra seemed more determined than even a few moments prior.“No matter what I am not doing this. I won’t marry Glimmer, not anymore.” Catra swore.

Adora could feel her stomach twist at the words.

“Obviously that isn’t ideal Catra but we need to think this through.” She placed what was meant to be a comforting hand on Catra’s back, sitting next to her. “We all have our responsibilities Catra. You decided that marrying Glimmer was a good idea.”

Adora's words are a little bitter but she couldn't help that.

"Maybe this is what you must do for Etheria, the same way that I have to be She-ra." Even as the words came out of Adora's mouth they felt wrong. But still, she didn't see any other option—she was stuck as She-ra and Catra as King.

Catra shrugged off Adora's arm and stood, eyes wide in disbelief.

"You just want me to marry someone else and what? Keep you as a lover the few days a month you come back from the battlefield? As a bed warmer for Etheria's champion." Catra clenched her jaw. "I can lead us out of this war Adora, with or without Bright Moon."

"If you could lead without Bright Moon, you wouldn't have agreed to marry Glimmer in the first place. Face the facts Catra!" Adora could feel her frustration bubbling over. She had been imprisoned for years and was now a murderer. That was sometimes what duty did. "You need to marry Glimmer if you want to keep the power you've gained. If you want to remain in a position to do something about the war! Stop being a child."

Adora winced as she felt the last words coming out of her mouth, knowing instantly it had been a mistake. Catra felt all her emotions boiling over as she too raised her voice.

"I don't want to hear that from you! You care more about being out on the battlefield as She-ra than whatever else goes on. You could care less if I married Glimmer! I know what you really want. You want to go off and play the hero while leaving the actual leading to me!" Catra accused flailing her arms about. Adora's eyes flashed blue, and she spoke through pressed lips.

"You don't know what I do on the war front, and you don't know how it weighs on me! I have done things I will never forget! I'm not pretending to be some hero!" Adora couldn't believe Catra thought this of her.

"Were you even trapped in the Crystal Castle or is that some lie you made up? So that I wouldn't question your absence?" Catra

pushed her accusations further, turning away from Adora to the balcony.

“What? Catra, obviously I wouldn’t lie to you about that! Where is this even coming from?” Adora shook her head, trying to connect the pieces of what Catra truly thought of her.

“Tell me Adora, if you had the chance to leave the Crystal Castle, would you have even done it? Can you tell me that you would have left to find me if you had to give up the sword? Give up being She-ra?” Catra asked, tears streaming down her face now. That felt like a question with an impossible answer to Adora. She pushed back.

“Catra, It’s not fair of you to make me choose between you and all of Etheria! I have a responsibility to uphold.” Catra’s breath was heaving, one of her fangs poking out, her tail barely visible from how fast it was twitching.

“Of course, it isn’t that simple to you.” Suddenly, Catra’s tail was still as she turned away from Adora. “As you said, we aren’t married anymore. I can do what I want, and I won’t marry Glimmer.”

“I can fulfill my duty to Halfmoon, to all Etheria even, without Bright Moon. I know I can find a way.” Catra was resolute. She was breathing heavy, eyes flashing, ears still pinned back. “And I know the difference between my obligations and my desires Adora. Do you?” Catra stated forcefully.

Catra didn’t wait for an answer. She left the room, slamming the door behind her with a resounding thud. Adora watched Catra’s retreating form, her anger disappearing. Adora discovered something she thought impossible: she felt more alone at that moment than she ever did in the Crystal Castle.

“I don’t understand why you are going to this relief mission in the Northern Reach.” Glimmer said, looking at the crates that were

being loaded onto the carriages.

“Netossa sent word that it was important I go. I’m not sure why but I’ll be glad to leave the castle for a few days.” Catra admitted.

“Are you still upset about the fight with Adora last week?” Glimmer asked, quirking an eyebrow at Catra.

“Yes.” Catra didn’t even bother hiding it. She had been miserable since the day she and Adora fought. “I just hate that we couldn’t resolve things. When I got back to the room and saw she was gone, I couldn’t believe it.”

Catra found a note from Adora saying she had to leave on urgent business. It felt like a punch to the gut.

“I’m going to be on edge until we speak again.” She grabbed her personal rucksack and threw it into the carriage. Catra knew nothing would make her feel better other than apologizing for being an ass.

“I’m sure you’ll resolve it soon. You usually don’t stay mad at each other for long.” Glimmer reasoned.

“I have apologizing to do. I’m not proud of how I spoke or what I said to her.” Catra said, averting her gaze to the ground.

“It was a turbulent moment. It’ll pass.” Glimmer placed her hand on Catra’s shoulder. Catra made a noise of disagreement.

“I’ve been unhappy for a while with this arrangement between us. With all the distance and the way it feels like the Sword of Protection and Halfmoon are always between us.” Catra admitted in a whisper. “At first, I was just relieved because she was alive. I could handle anything else. But Adora has been so ready for me to just marry you and I just snapped.”

Catra hadn’t felt anger like that in years.

“She acts like we don’t have choices, like we don’t have power. She’s wrong. She isn’t a weapon and I’m not a bargaining chip. Not if we don’t let the world turn us into that. I want her to choose her future.” She fervently wished for Adora to see she was more than the Sword of Protection. “I want her to choose me.” Catra finished quietly.

“I’m sure you will always be her choice. There is no world in which Adora doesn’t love you.” Glimmer assured. “Goodbye Cat. Have a safe trip.”

Catra delivered a halfhearted wave, ready to be cramped in a carriage for the foreseeable future.

Catra’s ears were cold, and she felt like she had been in the carriage for an eternity. Her thoughts were still stuck on Adora.

Adora leaving without saying goodbye worried her. Still, she was confident that they would be able to talk through their argument. It wasn’t the first time they had a fight that led to them cooling off in separate rooms.

Her thoughts were disrupted when the carriage careened to the side, jostling her as it came to a halt.

“What is happening out there?” Catra opened the door and stepped out of the carriage. From every direction, there were dozens of Horde soldiers.

“King Catra. I have longed to put a name to the face.” The voice oozed with condescension. Standing before her was a ghoulish-looking man who was very pale with blood-red lips. His armor bore a large Horde symbol.

“Lord Hordak, to what do I owe the pleasure?” Catra sneered, ears shifting as she tried to listen for where any reinforcements might be. Hordak smirked at her.

“You know, I was contemplating why you Etherians were suddenly fighting back in a way that wasn’t abjectly pathetic.” His tone was conversational. “At first, I thought it was She-ra, but the tide started to turn before She-ra graced the battlefield.”

He fixed her with a perusing look.

“Then, I realized there was another woman in charge of the Etherian success story. You. And now that I have you, King Catra, that Alliance of yours is going to fall apart.” Hordak grinned a grotesque thing.

Before Catra knew what was happening, her world faded to black.

Chapter End Notes

Welp. That escalated quickly. :)

How many times will I have Catra kidnapped in fanfics? The world may never know. (The Catra kidnap tally is up to 3 at this point lol).

A lot happened in this chapter so I am really excited about what you all think! There are only two more chapters so strap in for that. As always, I live for the comments and kudos, I enjoy the feedback so feel free to drop me a line!

Next Week: Adora finds out that her King is missing and she tries to mount a rescue mission.

A Sharpened Sword

Chapter Summary

Adora copes with Catra's disappearance.

The Alliance barely holds on.

Time to Save the King.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora was putting on her armor in Scorpioni land when she heard it. Gossip overran the camp just minutes before their planned attack. Throughout the Etherian Army, all soldiers had King Catra's name on their lips.

"Did you hear that the Horde kidnapped King Catra? She was out on a relief mission going to the Northern Reach." One of the soldiers attempted to whisper but failed, shock and excitement colored their voice.

"I heard the Horde was targeting the relief shipment and the King happened to be there. Maybe they just took her because she was there?" Another speculated. That theory was met with scoffs and jeers.

"No, my cousin says the opposite, he was one of her guards. He says that they specifically targeted the carriage because the Horde thought an Alliance member was there." A Bright Moon soldier insisted.

"I think it was a setup from Halfmoon." A Scorpioni soldier conspired, pitching their voice low.

"Halfmoon would never allow such a thing! We love our King!" A magicat soldier hissed tail lashing and ears twitching at the

accusation. “The Horde is all scum, they are probably trying to extort the Alliance to get King Catra back.”

A few murmurs of agreement sounded in the group.

“They haven't asked for a ransom yet." One of them pointed out. The whispers were furious as soldiers speculated and exchanged tidbits here and there of things, they heard from people supposedly in the know.

Adora heard rumors like this before around the soldier’s tents and had yet to hear one based on reality. There was no way Catra was captured by the Horde. Adora would have been notified already.

Still, although she knew her mind should be focused on the battle before her, her thoughts veered to a fight of a more personal nature. Adora hadn’t slept or known peace since the night Catra stormed out of her room. Adora shook off the thoughts of Catra and approached her troops. Adora, as She-ra, augmented her voice using magic.

"We are moments from battle. I have the same concerns as you whenever we hear uncertain rumors.” Adora glared at the gossiping group and they were cowed. “We do not have control over what might be happening out there, but here, we are the Etherian Army. We can and will succeed in our mission today! That is what we have control over!”

Adora raised the Sword of Protection, beaming in the sunlight.

“For Etheria!” All the soldiers around her roared, responding to her call. Out in the field, Adora barely felt like herself as she felt She-ra’s magic flow through her. It crackled like fire or lightning, filling her until she could feel nothing but that golden shining warmth.

Adora led the charge, running full force. She was faster than most of the horses when she tapped into this much of Etheria’s magic. She saw the Horde soldiers scattering as the army surged into the encampment. They ran for their weapons, crazed looks in their eyes.

Adora kept running, scanning the melee for higher command, the people truly responsible for what happened in the Horde. She fought a few soldiers who were brave enough to face her, but they stood no chance.

She felt a surge of pride at the battalion she led as she saw them clashing with the enemy, no fear in their eyes. The Horde soldiers were clearly not trained for an offensive attack and failed to find their formation, overwhelmed by the onslaught.

Before long, the contingent recaptured the Horde encampment. With the mission a success, Adora pulled her helmet off, letting her hair free as she wiped the sweat off her brow.

She helped soldiers from both sides get to the Etherian Army's medics, wincing at some of the injuries. The last rays of sunlight dipped below the horizon when the encampment was finally fully secured.

"Most of the battalion should stay here and prepare for any counter strike. I'm going to take a smaller unit back to our original encampment and I'll be back tomorrow morning." Adora told a nameless, faceless captain.

She couldn't risk sleeping anywhere but in her secured tent, no matter how bone-tired she felt. The captain she addressed nodded, standing ramrod straight.

"Yes She-ra, as you say." Her voice was cool and collected.

"What's your name?" Adora asked, embarrassed to realize she didn't know. The captain faltered for a moment her eyes widening in surprise.

"Lonnie." She answered curtly, recomposing herself.

"Do you have anyone at home waiting for you?" She found herself asking. The captain eyed her for a moment and Adora finally realized just how private the question she asked was to some folks. "I'm sorry, you don't need to answer that."

"No, it's fine. Um, two someones actually. One is a baker and the other a florist. They keep each other company while I'm here." Lonnie cleared her throat awkwardly. Adora nodded sympathetically.

"It's important to have someone out there. Someone who makes all the ugliness we see here worth it." Adora had this crushing solemn feeling rolling in her stomach, but she had no idea why. She shook her head. "I'm sorry to pry, I'd best be on my way before it gets even later."

Captain Lonnie nodded without comment and Adora gave her a tired smile before she headed out. As Adora traveled astride her horse, she tried to calculate how many days it might be until she returned to Halfmoon. Her heart panged as she realized the soonest she could leave would be at least two more weeks.

By the time she returned to her tent, bruised, bloodied, and exhausted, she had almost forgotten the soldiers' earlier murmurings that she dismissed as false. But when she opened her tent and found a tear-stained Adam waiting for her, she knew something was wrong.

"Adam, why are you here?" She walked directly towards her brother, eyes wide as she transformed back into herself. Adam tried to speak but only a choked sound made its way past his lips. He eyed her carefully and cleared his throat.

"I have bad news. You are going to want to sit down." Adam's usually smooth voice was still deep but scratchy and hoarse.

Adora sat next to her brother. Her muscles groaned after being in constant motion for the last few hours. She felt like something was clawing at her throat. She bounced her leg.

"Is it Catra? Did they really take her?" She could barely get the words out. The distraught look on his face told her everything she needed to know. "Adam no. It can't-what happened? How could this happen?" Adora demanded.

“We aren’t sure.” He amitted, shame clear in his voice. “We think the Horde took her when they tried to capture the relief supplies, she was overseeing.”

Adam’s hands were trembling. Or maybe she trembled. She wasn’t sure.

“What was she doing anywhere near the Northern Reach? That is a dangerous area, she shouldn’t have been there.” Adora hissed. Adam sighed, looking exhausted.

“I don’t know Adora. I think she got word that her presence was required for the delivery.” Adam eyed her delicately. He bit his lip, an indecisive furrow on his strong brow. “Catra was in a rough place emotionally. She might have wanted something to do.”

The implication stung Adora like a whip. This was all her fault. Adora broke down sobbing, feeling like a child. Adam held his sister close, rubbing his arm down her back.

“We had a fight right before I left. I’ve been such a mess this whole week, the only thing I’ve wanted is to return to Halfmoon and make amends.” Adora sniffled. “I left without saying goodbye. I could have looked for her before I left but the message calling me away said it was urgent and I was so angry. I didn’t want to hurt her more by fighting again.”

Adora buried her face in her brother’s shoulder like she did when he comforted her as children.

“What if this is it, Adam? What if the last thing I said to my wife were words of anger? We just left this to fester between us.” Adora couldn’t breathe around the hole in her chest.

“Don’t think like that Adora. Look at how long you were gone, and you both still found each other. You two always had your fights—I suspect you’ll have more of them.” Adam’s voice bordered on teasing and Adora snorted. He rubbed a soothing hand down her back. “Tonight, we are going to eat and sleep. Then we are going back to Halfmoon, and we will plan to get her back. You can

apologize and fix whatever your fight was about after we have her out of harm's way." Adam said gently.

Adora barely listened to him as sobs wracked her body, falling apart anew.

It was strange being at Halfmoon again, knowing that Catra wouldn't be waiting for her. As she approached the castle, it seemed the whole country was in mourning. Everyone was quieter, more subdued than normal. No children played in the street and no music flowed from the residential balconies. Everything was a somber oppressive silence that felt too heavy to break.

Halfmoon seemed to feel as dead as Adora. Many of the magicats she saw walking on the street turned to look at She-ra as she passed, a look akin to hope shining from them. Every hopeful look stacked on her shoulders, another promise to break and burden to carry if she couldn't bring Catra back.

Once they entered the castle, Adora picked up her pace. Walking down those halls again, she felt a lump rise in her throat, and tears fill her eyes.

"Where are you going?" Adam grabbed her arm and craned his neck up to see her.

"Are we going to be doing something that will help us find Catra?" Adora asked curtly, trying to keep the water out of her voice.

"Not right this moment. We have a few hours." Adam admitted, rubbing his neck.

"Then I'm going to be alone for a while. I'll catch up with you later." Adora shrugged off Adam's arm and stalked away.

She knew she probably shouldn't, but she snuck into Catra's room. There was nothing and no one waiting for her there, just the

sinking feeling in the pit of her stomach that accompanied her since she left Catra after their fight.

The three days of travel from the Scorpioni Kingdom to Halfmoon were filled with her tears. She thought she didn't have anymore but standing in the middle of the last place she saw Catra cracked her chest wide open.

She looked around the room for any clue of what Catra might have been doing before her disappearance.

Which reports did she read? Was she lounging on the bed or the long chaise she insisted on moving in when they first married? Was she still angry at Adora for leaving without saying goodbye? For being She-ra? Did she want to reconcile as desperately as Adora did?

As Adora scanned the room, her eyes caught a note crumpled on one of the bedside tables. She had a sinking feeling she knew exactly what the note read. She opened it, fingers trembling. It was the note she left for Catra, possibly the last words Catra would ever receive from her.

Catra,

I'm sorry that I will not be here when you return. Duke Netossa sent for me. I don't have the details, but the message sounds urgent. I will be back as soon as I can. We can continue talking then.

With devotion,

She-ra

She winced as she re-read the note. She was upset when she wrote it. She was also worried about being too explicit with her words in case someone besides Catra read it.

Her message was curt, cold, and unsatisfying. She can't imagine Catra was anything but furious with Adora when she read it.

She could see that although the note was only a few weeks old, the folds on the page were deep as if the note had been opened and closed multiple times. A few of the words on the sheet were smudged.

She wondered if Catra cried when she read it or if she worried the paper with her fingers, blurring out Adora's words.

She was a terrible person for leaving that note and she would give anything on Etheria to have said more, anything that told Catra how much she loved her. Or better yet, to have Catra with her now.

The exhaustion caught up with Adora then. She fell forward, her knees buckling under the pressure of the guilt and sadness that seemed to live in Adora's skin now. She ended up laying on the floor a few feet from the bed. She didn't know how long she laid there crying.

"Adora?" A voice called gently. Adora blearily opened her eyes, confused as to where she was or how she got there.

She glanced up and recognized the high ceilings of Catra's room, but she didn't quite remember when she ended up there. Adora focused on Glimmer's concerned face and realized she was on the floor.

Oh. She must have exhausted herself crying and fell asleep right on the rug.

It was a plush rug. Probably thicker than the cot she slept on when she was out on the field. But being caught sleeping there made her feel vulnerable in a way she couldn't explain. Glimmer held her hand out for Adora to take, hoisting her up on her feet.

"I know this is difficult Adora, but she is out there. We are going to find her." Glimmer's eyes held a fierce determination.

Adora nodded mutely, transforming into She-ra. Glimmer led her to the King's consort's study. It used to be Adora's study when she was married to Catra.

Bow was sitting at the large desk looking over reports. He glanced up as he heard the door jar open and stood when Glimmer and Adora walked in.

His eyes grew soft as he perused Adora's form. The moment that the door shut behind her, Adora lost She-ra. Calling her had been more difficult than usual in the last few days.

"How are you holding up?" Before she could answer Bow's soft question, he mumbled to himself. "Yeah, that was a stupid thing to ask. Do you want to talk about how you are feeling or talk about plans to get her back?"

The answer was obvious.

"How are we getting her back. Please." Adora could have feelings on her on time, she needed to know what was necessary to rescue Catra. She needed something to work towards.

Glimmer sighed and for the first time since she woke up, Adora really took the time to look at her. She looked like she hadn't slept in the last three days either.

"The Alliance is crumbling without Catra." Glimmer stated bluntly, her hands running through her hair. "I think under normal circumstances, I would be able to rally them behind me but there is some … dissent in Halfmoon."

Adora felt her eyebrows raise of their own accord.

"What do you mean dissent? Dissent from who? About what?" Adora demanded.

"Percival," Glimmer muttered the name like it was a curse. Adora narrowed her eyes in confusion.

“Why would Percival’s opinion matter at all? He is on the council but unless something has changed recently, he barely has any sway there.” Glimmer pinched the bridge of her nose.

“He claims to be next in line for the throne.” Adora paused, looking between Bow and Glimmer.

“Because you and Catra are still unmarried? That’s ridiculous, as Catra’s betrothed you are the acting regent for as long as she is King.” Adora was well versed in Halfmoon’s line of succession.

“He insists that magicat blood must sit on the throne.” Adora scoffed, rolling her eyes at the tired line.

“Of course, he would say that. He objected to my marriage to Catra on those same grounds.” Adora muttered darkly. “His mother was a magicat separatist, she was one of the main proponents of keeping Halfmoon hidden underground.”

Glimmer shared a glance with Bow, an understanding passing between them.

“That actually makes a lot of sense. He has been incredibly rude to me since I arrived at Halfmoon.” Glimmer rolled her eyes.

“Even still, should these rumblings about who controls the Halfmoon crown affect a request to the Alliance?” Adora asked, still at a loss.

“I’m not sure, Tao and Adam are looking for an answer with the royal librarians. Hopefully, I can at least stay in control of diplomatic relations until we get Catra back.” Glimmer sat down across from Bow, taking his hand. “It’s about more than just who controls the crown of Halfmoon. Catra was a charismatic force and effective at moving her agenda forward in Alliance meetings.”

Adora knew Glimmer’s words to be true.

“The last one we had everyone was just hemming and hawing, just like before. None of the other members know how to build

consensus the way Catra did.” Glimmer explained.

Adora looked away, once again thinking about Catra. Hearing Glimmer speak so glowingly about Catra hurt her heart.

“Is something else bothering you?” Adora gave Glimmer a withering stare. Glimmer stared right back. “Besides the obvious, I mean.”

Adora sighed.

“The last time I saw Catra all we did was fight about the engagement and the situation with Bright Moon. She thinks I value being She-ra more than I love her. That I don’t believe in her ability to come up with another solution.” Adora swallowed the lump in her throat as the words burn out of her. “I didn’t say goodbye before I left Halfmoon.” Adora whimpered.

It was all Adora could think about since she knew of Catra’s disappearance. Glimmer stood and gave Adora a hug.

“Adora, you couldn’t have known,” Bow spoke up, eyeing her carefully.

“I did notice that Catra was out of sorts since you left. It was obvious it bothered her too, Adora. She told me she wanted to apologize for what she said.” Glimmer offered. She hadn’t released Adora when Bow came around the other side and provided another hug. “Besides, is that true? Do you want to be She-ra more than you want to be together with Catra?”

Adora shot Glimmer an affronted look.

“No! Of course not! We have been under a lot of pressure since I returned because of the war. I think we need to take time to reconnect after everything that has happened.” Adora groaned. “I don’t know how she did this for three years. She hasn’t been missing long and I am about to lose my mind.”

Adora was helpless, her friends' hugs the only thing keeping her standing.

"She let other people support her Adora. People like Adam, Tao, us when we visited each other. All of Halfmoon gave her strength to continue as well. You have us, we will help you get her back." Bow consoled. Bow tightened his arms around Adora, and Glimmer did the same.

"You know, we would hug her just like this when she would visit Bright Moon and was having a rough time with your disappearance. And I'll tell you what I told her then. We will get her back Adora, I know it." Glimmer sounded certain. Adora hoped she was right.

--

Adora helped Adam sort through paperwork, looking for clues as to why Catra left to the Northern Reach at all when Glimmer burst through the door stomping her way into the King's study.

"I will wring his skinny little magicat neck, I swear it!" Glimmer blustered. Adora looked up from the report she was studying with a raised eyebrow. Adam also looked at the King's consort.

"Glimmer, that doesn't seem like an effective diplomatic tactic. Who are you talking about?" Adam inquired, a hint of amusement buried under the weight of his exhaustion.

"Percival! That damn rat is pushing for his coronation now. He says that Catra is dead, and he is the rightful King of Halfmoon." Adora felt something inside her snap.

"Catra is not dead. I would know it." Glimmer looked at her with sympathy but quickly returned to her anger.

"I know she isn't. We just need to keep Percival's grubby little paws off the crown." Glimmer stated crossly. Adora groaned, eyes searching the mountain of paper on Catra's desk and failing.

"It's offensive to call them paws. You should know that. Rat is probably no good either." Adam said absentmindedly as he looked at another one of Catra's papers. He narrowed his eyes on a particular page, lost in thought.

"I know it's offensive, that's why I am using it in reference to Percival." Glimmer's frustration seemed like another person in the room.

"What are we even doing, we aren't out there finding her!" Glimmer's interruption fueled a different type of frustration in Adora. She put her hands in her head, and tears welled up in her eyes. Again. Even with all the power she wielded as She-ra, she never felt as weak as she does now. Glimmer put a comforting arm around her.

"Adora look at this!" Adam interrupted excitement booming in his voice. Lodged between the two reports that Adam scrutinized was a note.

King Catra,

It is of the utmost importance that you accompany the relief mission to the Northern Reach. I will send further instruction for what I need from you once you are there. Thank you for your cooperation.

For Etheria,

Duke Netossa

"Why would Netossa tell Catra to go to the Northern Reach?" Adam furrowed his brow as he posed the question to the room.

"Catra mentioned that Netossa told her it was important, but I'd never seen the note before." Glimmer commented, taking a turn to inspect the note closely. Adora made a noise of protest as she grabbed the note.

“That can’t be from Netossa. It isn’t in her handwriting, but it has her seal. This is a fake.” Adora exclaimed, a grim feeling washing over her as she made the next logical leap.

“Someone set Catra up to be taken by the Horde.” Glimmer thought aloud. The three friends looked at each other as the implication settled in the room. Adora’s skin itched with rage.

“This stays between us until we have evidence of who it can be. I have my suspicions, but I want to be sure before we accuse anyone.” Adora commanded a deep growl in her voice as magic reverberated against the study’s walls.

Adora had a new purpose. She knew how she was going to get Catra back. She just needed the Alliance’s cooperation.

"We need to rescue King Catra. That should be our priority." The Alliance meeting carried on for an hour and nothing got done. Adora was about to pull her hair out of her head in frustration.

Percival cut in. Again.

"We don't know that she was taken by the Horde. It's only been six weeks, if they do have her, they might be willing to negotiate with us to get her back. If we jump into something half-cocked there won't be a chance of that." Percival’s voice is smooth and unworried, no love lost between him and Catra.

"We do know that she was taken by the Horde because there are witnesses and a majority of the goods she was transporting are gone!" Glimmer tried to control her tone, but it was a close thing.

“I say we put this discussion to bed. Although I too am horrified by my dearest cousin’s disappearance, we need to focus on the actual war effort, not this potential suicide mission.” Percival’s words stung like acid and Adora barely stayed in her seat.

“With all due respect,” Adora spit out with exactly a zero amount of respect in her tone, “the Alliance agreed to allow you to attend

the meetings as an observer given the … complicated political situation at Halfmoon. You cannot control what we discuss.” Adora hissed. This was the third time Percival interrupted the meeting, advocating for the Alliance to abandon any rescue efforts.

“Well, as long as Princess Glimmer is treated the same, given that she is the other half of what you call a complicated political situation, then by all means She-ra.” Percival smirked at Glimmer and tossed her a wink. Glimmer clenched her hand and looked away, but stubbornly kept her mouth closed.

The room was held an awkward silence for a moment. Entrapta was the only person who seemed to not notice the tension in the room, shuffling through her notes. Netossa cleared her throat.

“I’m concerned about diverting resources when we don’t even know if King Catra is alive,” Netossa admitted. “The Horde has failed to communicate a ransom or verify that she is within their custody. It would be like looking for a needle in a haystack.”

Netossa furrowed her brow, clearly unpleased by the odds of a successful mission.

“Exactly, Duke Netossa, great point.” Netossa scrunched her face as if she touched something slimy when she heard Percival praise her. Adora directed her words at Percival, glaring at him.

"I find your careless attitude disgusting.” She then addressed the room at large. She thought if she looked at Percival’s smug face for one more moment, she would smack him into a wall. “The Alliance is meant to be united and if it were any of you out there, I know that Catra would be looking for you." Adora’s eyes glowed.

"The only reason we have been able to maintain the lines we had gained since Catra was kidnapped is because of me. You all need to work together if we don't want to be where we were six months ago, with capitals like Bright Moon burning." Adora spit out.

Despair caught in her throat, she didn't know if Catra was alive or dead if she would ever see her again. Hold her. She felt herself shrinking into herself and then she realized she was actually shrinking as her grip on She-ra waned.

The Alliance members gasped as Adora fell to her knees in front of them. She felt utterly spent and drained dry.

“Who are you?” Percival demanded.

"Queen Adora?" Princess Scorpia whispered, shocked at the appearance of the thought to be long-lost regent. Adora spoke again, voice full of tears.

"Rescuing King Catra of Halfmoon is for the good of Etheria, I ask this council for its help as the Princess of Power. As She-ra.” She took a deep breath, ready to admit who she really was, consequences damned. “But I also ask this council as Adora, as a woman who has already lost the love of her life once, to find it in your heart to rescue her. My Catra."

Adora felt limp, her tears streamed down her face.

"Please," Adora whispered. The Alliance room was eerily quiet for a moment.

"Adora is right.” Princess Scorpia spoke up. She pointed around the room. “Catra would save any of us. We have been digging our heads in the sand and it is not okay. We need to do something to get her back, or at least try. We need her to defeat the Horde." Scorpia declared fervently.

"I agree with my betrothed. Catra is a kind and fair ruler, and she is our leader. We need her back not only because it is the strategic thing to do but because it is the right thing to do." Perfuma straightened her spine, this was the most provocative thing she had said in any Princess Alliance meeting.

Princess Perfuma grabbed onto Princess Scorpia’s pincer. It seemed Scorpia found a love match after all.

Netossa looked torn, eyeing the two princesses that spoke out. Spinerella, her wife, reached out for her hand.

"Nettie if it were me, would you even think twice?" She asked softly.

"Of course, not my love.” She returned. Netossa let out a groan.

“You're right, we are letting the bureaucracy let us get away from what's important. I vote for us to stage a rescue mission to find King Catra." Netossa proposed she glanced at Adora. "At some later date, Queen Adora, you'll have some explaining to do. But only after we have King Catra safe within the midst of the Alliance again."

Adora felt relief course through her.

“This is a waste of resources and time she is long dead!” Percival protested again. Adora’s relief was quickly replaced by rage. Suddenly, he was pinned to the wall, not by She-ra, but Adora herself.

“Unless you have proof that my wife is dead, you will remain silent.” Adora acted as if she were pondering her command, touching her chin as she held Percival lifted in the air with one arm. “I actually have questions of my own for you Percival- you conniving snake.” Adora hissed.

She held Percival so high up that his feet could never hope to reach the ground.

“Do you sign all of your official correspondence, ‘For Halfmoon’?” Adora asked with faux innocence. Percival sputtered eyes wide, Adora’s hold on his neck making it impossible for him to speak. “Let me answer that for you- you do. I had Tao verify the records of your correspondence. It is a very old-fashioned sign-off, one that sticks out like a sore thumb- especially when one uses its even older variation, For Etheria.”

Percival tried to speak but Adora grips him a smidgen tighter. He is starting to turn blue.

“I know you are working with the Horde. I know you forged a note from Netossa so that the Horde could find Catra in a vulnerable, unguarded place.” Adora let her voice boom over the whole room, laying all her accusations for everyone to hear. “Let me make this clear to you. You will never be King of Halfmoon. We will successfully return Catra to safety and to her throne.”

Adora’s eyes flashed with determination.

“If for any reason, Catra is dead-” Adora couldn’t suppress the shudder that ran through her at the thought “- I will hang you by your entrails. I don’t care about the consequences. Your life now totally depends on Catra’s safety.”

Adora stared at the squirming magicat his legs twitching from the lack of air.

“So Percival. You have one opportunity to make this right. Where is the Horde holding Catra?” Adora held her breath and loosened her grip on his throat.

“The Fright Zone.” Percival gasped out. “She is still there, please don’t kill me.” Percival sniveled.

Adora slowly put his feet back onto the ground.

“Guards. Put Percival in the dungeon. He may live—for now.” Adora allowed.

Percival melted in relief even with Adora’s hand around his neck. As Percival was taken away, the red haze around Adora’s vision faded and she looked around, the rest of the Alliance staring at her with wide eyes.

“We should set forth our course to the Fright Zone tomorrow at dawn. Seems we have a lead.” Adora turned on her heels and

walked out of whatever was left of the meeting, slamming the door behind her.

It was so odd, seeing Adam in armor again, his already large frame looking bulkier under the extra protection. Adora had grown used to seeing him in the loose robes that were fashionable in Halfmoon. Instead of the purplish hue of the Bright Moon armor, Adam wore a plated bronze marking him as a Halfmoon warrior.

Adora stared straight ahead, focused on the mission. The tips of her fingers were tingling from the adrenaline. Adam led his horse next to Adora's.

"We will get her back, I swear it," Adam told his sister, matter of fact.

"I have no doubt." Adora refused to think of the alternative.

"Would it help to talk about it?" Adam offered. She shot him a half-hearted glare.

"We are walking into the Horde's largest stronghold, an encampment that has never been penetrated. An annexed portion of the Scorpioni Kingdom." Adora listed off the facts, remaining calm.

"One of our spies had eyes on Catra, says that she is alive still." Adam reminded her helpfully.

"That intelligence is almost a week old now, Adam." Adora's stomach plummeted every time she thought about the fact that they were unable to get any new information on Catra's whereabouts.

"Let's not focus on that," Adam suggested. The Fright Zone could now be seen in the distance, plumes of smokes and smog from the factories overwhelming the nearby buildings.

“You’re right.” Adora was barely holding it together as it is. She had not dealt with the fall out of her identity being revealed.

“Her last known location was the prison. You and I will infiltrate, the rest of the contingent will stay out of sight unless we don’t come back within two hours. In which case, we will bring down the Fright Zone if necessary.” Adora knew that if she let lose the rage in her body, she could turn the Fright Zone into a pile of rubble.

“We will get her back,” Adam repeated the mantra.

“There is no other option Adam.” Adora’s eyes glowed a fierce blue.

They knocked out a pair of Horde guards and took their armor. Adora and Adam hid in plain sight, acting as soldiers would when anyone got too close.

They finally reached the hallway that led to the cells Catra should be in. There was a guard standing to attention at the opening of the hallway. Adam and Adora his behind a crate as they watched the guard.

“Our friend says guard change is in five minutes. That’s when we will strike.” Adora thanked every star in the sky that their spy was able to get the guard change information.

Just as expected the guards switched. Adora walked casually by, as if going to another corridor, but at the last second, she veered off course and struck the guard in the temple.

The guard fell with a heavy thunk. Adam and Adora quickly hid him away.

“I’ll watch the hallway, you go get her.” Adam stood to attention, looking just like the guard who stood there moments before.

Fear welled in Adora as she looked inside each cell, hoping against hope that Catra would be in one of them. She was about to give up hope when she caught sight of some movement in one of the back cells.

Adora finally laid eyes on her. Catra looked a bit gaunt but no worse for wear. Adora could feel her body filling with relief. She felt a sob bubbling up in her chest.

Catra caught sight of Adora, but instead of coming towards her, she took a step back, stumbling onto the ground of her cell and clutching her eyes closed.

"I told you, your mind games won't work on me Hordak, I don't care how many times you conjure people I know- I-I- won't tell you anything." Catra hissed. Adora could feel her brow furrowing.

"Catra what are you talking about. It's me. She-ra. Adora. I'm here to take you home." Catra shut her eyes even tighter, turning her head away from Adora.

"No that can't be." Adora reached slowly towards Catra, making sure to create noise so she knew exactly where she was even with her eyes closed. She could see her ears twitch attentively in her direction.

"Catra I'm here to take you home. I need you to please let me take you." Adora was begging at this point, tears caught in her throat. Catra slowly opened her eyes.

"How do I know you are truly She-ra?" Adora noted that even in her frazzled state, Catra refused to confirm She-ra's identity. She got close and whispered to Catra.

"Do you remember where we went when you first asked for permission to court me?" Catra shivered and nodded, eyes clearer than just a moment before. "You took me out to the fields by the Bright Moon castle on horseback. You knew I loved fields and horses. I was so nervous I reverted to all I knew, which was guard etiquette."

Adora grabbed Catra’s hand.

“You thought I hated the outing until I started blubbering about how sorry I was that a ruined everything with my nerves." Catra stared at her closely. "Then you grinned, shoved me into the stream nearby, and we played like children in the water.”

She saw Catra’s lips twitch into a small smile. Adora’s heart warmed at the memory and at having her love in front of her. She chanced a step closer.

“That's when I knew that no matter how nervous Prince Catra made me, I never wanted to be without her," Adora whispered the end of the story, hoping it would be enough.

Catra continued to search her gaze. Adora supposed she found what she was looking for because her eyes became less guarded.

"Adora?" Adora smiled lovingly and placed a kiss on Catra’s forehead.

"Yes, love. We must hurry now if we want to get out of here. I'm going to carry you." Even without She-ra, she easily lifted Catra into her arms, walking quickly.

“Guard!” Catra whispered urgently into Adora’s ear. Adam heard and turned around, pulling off his helmet. He beamed.

“Hello your majesty, fancy seeing you here.” Adam’s cavalier attitude grated on Adora’s nerves.

“Less talking, more escaping.” Adora was as tense as a violin string. She would know no relief until Catra was safely out of the Fright Zone.

By some miracle, they were able to get out of the building without being spotted. Adora thought she even saw a few Horde cadets willfully turn a blind eye to them as they got to the outskirts of the encampment.

They finally arrived at the two horses they hid on their way into the Fright Zone. Catra rode with Adora in silence.

As they reached the extraction team, the magicats all dropped into a low bow at the sight of their King. Catra made a motion for them to rise, but it was weak.

"We are getting you home, love." Adora opened the door of the carriage and got Catra inside. She then sat Catra on her lap, occasionally dropping kisses on her ears. As the Fright Zone became smaller in the distance, Adora finally allowed herself to relax, her thoughts only centered on Catra and breathing her in.

The royal physician had been looking Catra over for the better part of an hour, and Adora watched him carefully.

"She is bruised and dehydrated, but thankfully King Catra is in good physical health. I expect her to make a full recovery." The royal physician assured Adora for probably the tenth time since he walked into Catra's room. Catra was currently sleeping, clearly tired from her imprisonment.

"Thank you for checking on her. I would appreciate it if you came back tomorrow and checked on her progress." Adora knew she was being ridiculous, but she couldn't help it.

The physician agreed and saw himself out. She closed the door behind him, alone with Catra for the first time since the rescue mission was completed. She watched Catra lay still for a few moments until she started to toss and turn, her face creasing in displeasure. Her eyes shot open.

"Adora?" Catra's voice pitched his, her eyes wide with panic. Adora rushed to her bedside, sitting on the chair she had pulled up for this eventuality. She reached out and held Catra's hand.

"Yes, Catra?" Adora answered as evenly as possible. It was difficult when Catra was upset. Catra's shoulders untensed some but she looked at Adora wearily.

“How do I know you are Adora?” Catra sounded hopeful but mistrust seeped into her voice. Catra seemed to have suffered in non-physical ways in the Fright Zone and Adora didn’t have a clue how to help.

“I rescued you from the Fright Zone. We are in your room right now, we traveled for a few days to get back to Halfmoon. Do you remember?” Catra slowly relaxed at Adora’s words. Adora found that gently reminding her of recent events seemed to bring Catra to herself faster.

“I’m sorry,” Catra whispered. Adora looked down at Catra confused by her apology. “I know we left things terribly the last time we saw each other. I’m so sorry for my part in it- I was awful to you.”

Understanding flooded Adora as she squeezed Catra’s hand.

“We don’t have to talk about that right now.” Adora consoled. Catra’s eyes cut back up to her.

“We have to talk about it, Adora.” Catra stubbornly pursed her lips. Adora knew the look well, the one that told Adora she would not be letting go and would only press the issue further.

“We do have to talk about it, and we will. Later. I want you to save your strength for now. You need rest.” Catra averted her gaze, looking around the room, likely talking in all of the get-well blooms for the first time.

“I don’t want to sleep. I get nightmares. That I’m back there.” Catra begrudgingly admitted, looking down at the sheets on the bed.

“Is there anything I can do to help?” Adora desperately wanted to fix this, but she knew she couldn’t.

“Could you lay here with me? I think I would feel more grounded if you were holding me.” Catra’s eyes stayed down, and her ears

pinned back as if afraid Adora would say no. Adora quickly crawled into the bed, holding Catra’s back to her front.

“I wish all the world’s problems could be solved by me holding you. It would make my life so much better.” Adora teased tentatively. Catra relaxed into Adora’s hold.

“You’ll stay?” Catra asked.

“Of course, dearest. However long you want me, I’m here.” Adora promised.

“Forever then?” The longing in Catra’s voice sent a pang through Adora.

“And longer than that.” She murmured. Adora’s eyes started to get heavy as she held Catra, and soon she was falling asleep to the feeling of Catra’s purr against her chest.

Chapter End Notes

Well, there you have it! We only have one more to go folks!!! I'm very excited :)

Fun fact: the first scene I ever wrote for this fic was the scene of Adora begging the Alliance to help her get Catra back as her powers fail her. It's funny to me because the fic became Catra-centric but the first few scenes I wrote were all about Adora and her POV. It didn't become Catra's story until later in the editing process. (Although maybe y'all disagree on who is the "center" of the story? Let me know!)

As always, comments and kudos are what inspire me to write and edit after working 60 hours a week lol.

Next Week: Adora and Catra face the consequences of Catra's kidnapping and have a long-overdue conversation. It's the end!

A Shuffle of Crowns

Chapter Summary

A relationship reconciled.

A traitor punished.

A marriage proposed. Again.

Chapter Notes

I can't believe this is it, folks!! Thank you to everyone who has supported me since the beginning, I really appreciate it!

Special thanks to BlueCoin00, who wanted me to let y'all know she is sad life got in the way and she was unable to beta fully on this project. That being said she did skim a rough draft and gave me invaluable criticism that helped me on my own self-editing journey. I would also like to thank PlagueVectress for being an excellent naming gremlin and naming this story and every single chapter in it because writing an over 45k story is easy peasy but naming it is hell.

I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora woke the next morning with Catra still in her arms, a blessing to be sure. Sunlight softly streamed in through the farthest window, making shadows play against Catra's curves. She gently kissed her ears and then down one of her shoulders. Adora could tell that Catra was waking up because her ear flicked, and her tail weaved softly. Catra turned to look at Adora, eyes opening slowly.

"Hey Adora. How did you sleep?" Catra asked softly, voice scratchy from disuse and gaze nervous. If Adora was to hazard a

guess, she figured Catra was nervous because of everything left unsaid between them.

"Amazing. I had a dream the most beautiful woman in the world slept in my arms." Adora returned as she pulled her closer, trying to assure her without addressing the tension outright. Catra grinned, leaning her head against Adora. "How about you?"

"No nightmares last night, for the first time." She pressed a soft kiss to Adora's brow. She squeezed her eyes shut in relief, glad that Catra received some reprieve from her own mind.

"Do you feel okay to talk about some things that have happened recently?" She asked the King cautiously. Catra nodded, her eyes guarded.

The last few days Adora's singular focus was Catra's rest and health, but even she could admit that Catra needed to know some of the events since her disappearance. She could not keep Catra locked away forever, as tempting as the idea might seem.

"First, I don't want you to hear this from anyone else. The Alliance knows that I am She-ra. Everyone knows—I'd be surprised if my return hasn't been reported to every kingdom in Etheria." Catra's eyes widened but she remained silent. Adora took this as a hint to continue. "I didn't mean to take that decision without you. It just happened."

Catra placed a comforting hand on Adora's arm. Adora tried to search her gaze for a clue as to how this was landing. Catra's expression was unreadable, her ears still except for the occasional fidget.

"I was standing in the Alliance meeting room, thinking about how much I wanted you there. How awful I felt that the last thing I ever said to you might have been words of anger." Adora's voice shook with remorse she felt down to her bones. "And it was like She-ra was gone. This well of magic I had complete access to was

just gone. So, without meaning to, I transformed into myself. And I begged them, on my knees, to let me go find you."

Adora was sobbing now, unable to keep the tears at bay. She took a deep shuddering breath as Catra continued to hold her, her tail sweeping over the side of her legs rhythmically.

"But I want to be clear—I don't regret revealing my identity. Because that's what ultimately won the council over and gave us access to the intelligence we needed to stage the rescue mission. They were moved by my plea, not as She-ra, but as Adora." Catra looked speechless, staring at Adora in a way she hadn't seen before. "Dearest, there is nothing on this planet more important to me than you. I knew it while we were fighting, and I know it now. If I had to choose, I would choose you, Catra. It killed me to think that you might not know that."

She gathered up Catra in her arms. Catra continued to hold on, reassuring her not only with her touch but with her words.

"I know that I'm important to you, Adora. I always knew, even when we were upset with each other. I love you so much. I'm so glad to be here with you." Catra rubbed her arm down Adora's back in comfort.

"I love you too. I was beside myself when you were gone. I don't think I would have been strong enough to do it for three years as you did." Adora referenced her disappearance, a newfound appreciation for just how truly resilient and strong Catra had to be.

"It wasn't pretty. I put myself dead last and focused on Halfmoon. If it weren't for Tao and Adam, I don't think I would have managed it." Catra admitted quietly. "I'm glad everyone knows you're back. You shouldn't have to hide."

Residual tension in Adora's shoulders eased at Catra's last admission.

“I’m glad that you aren’t upset by that.” She pressed her nose to Catra’s hair. “There is something else you should know. It’s about how you were captured.” Adora warned.

“What is it?” Catra furrowed her brow, confused. Adora contemplated how to deliver the bombshell she was dreading since returning to Halfmoon with Catra.

“Did you go on that relief mission because you received a note from Netossa?” She asked slowly. Catra nodded, staring at Adora expectantly. “It was a forged missive. We believe Percival conspired with the Horde to deliver you to them so he could ascend to the throne.”

Catra eyes flew open as she stared unseeingly at Adora. Her disbelief is palpable, ears pinned back and eyes wide.

“That little rat! I can’t believe him! He really had the guts to do that?” Catra blustered, tail slashing behind her. “Where is he now?”

“He is in the dungeon for whenever you feel up to seeing him,” Adora explained as she reached out to hold Catra’s hand.

“I’m surprised you or Adam didn’t kill him on the spot.” Catra stated offhandedly.

Adora froze. Given the way they are pressed against each other, Catra immediately noticed the way Adora tensed. She quirked an eyebrow, the silent question obvious.

“I might have choked him in the middle of an Alliance meeting.” She grudgingly acknowledged. “And threatened bodily harm if he refused to disclose your location.”

Catra backed up a few inches to look Adora in the eyes. Catra’s eyes are full of mirth. She relaxes slightly at the sight.

“I’m sad I missed the show.” She teased. She then sighed and put a hand on Adora’s cheek.

“Adora, I’m ready to start dealing with all of this.” Catra stated seriously. “I’ll let you hover over me like a mother hen if you let me attend to my duties.” She offered as a compromise. Adora scoffed.

“It’s a given that I’m not letting you out of my sight for at least the next three years.” Adora knew she would probably have to part from Catra soon, but she refused to think about it now. “Will you promise to take a nap? And tell me if you need a break?” Adora pled.

“Yes, love. I’ll let you know if I need anything.” Catra kissed Adora, their first kiss since their fight a month ago. Nothing could ever taste sweeter.

“You’ll take care of her, yes?” Adora reconfirmed, looking at Tao with serious eyes.

“Of course, my liege. I always have the King’s best interest at heart.” Tao looked at Adora in an exasperated fashion, lips pressed together as he rolled his eyes. Adora tripped over her own feet at Tao’s address.

“I’m not anyone’s liege.” Adora protested a blush creeping up her neck.

“Oh, I beg to differ, mighty She-ra, Princess of Power,” Tao smirked at Adora, tail swiping at her shoulder blades. Catra pushed Adora towards the door. She barely moved an inch, looking down at Catra as if the shove was a mere annoyance.

“Adora, I love you, but I need at least two hours with Tao and if you come to this room even a second early, I will challenge you to combat,” Catra swore, continuing to press her hands on Adora’s torso. Adora wore a pinched expression and remained an immovable object.

“I have all of Etheria’s magic at my disposal, I would surely win,” Adora noted as she side-eyed her love, confused as to why

combat would be a deterrent.

“Yes, but you wouldn’t want me to *strain* myself, would you?” Catra smirked as Adora’s eyes grew in horror and she left without another word, her steps too long and fast to be normal.

“Do we really need two hours to talk?” Tao mused. He settled into his seat now that it was just the two of them.

“Probably not, but Adora is driving me mad, she is like a second shadow. I can’t go anywhere without her hovering!” Catra knew she gave Adora permission to stay nearby, but it was getting absurd.

“So, before she was too far, out on the battlefield, and now she is too near?” Tao raised an eyebrow and flicked one of his ears. Catra rolled her eyes.

“She is never too close, that’s not the point. I just don’t want to be treated like an invalid. I’m perfectly capable of carrying out my duties.” Catra complained. “Regardless, that isn’t why I came to speak with you. I actually wanted your advice on a few topics, given everything that has happened recently.” She addressed him. Catra needed to process with her most trusted advisor.

“I am always here to advise your majesty.” Tao allowed, a curious expression taking over.

“The easiest first then. What do we do about Adora’s legal status in Halfmoon?” Catra asked. Tao hummed, tail weaving softly.

“If you are referring to her status as citizen and Queen, it is a complicated issue. We can undo the finding that she is deceased—obviously, she isn’t—but unfortunately, we cannot undo the annulment. It wouldn’t be difficult to establish her as a citizen of Halfmoon again, or Bright Moon, or any other kingdom willing to take She-ra as a citizen. However, if Adora is to regain her position as Queen, you two would have to remarry.” Tao stated, cutting to the quick of what Catra truly meant to ask.

“For now, let’s start the necessary paperwork for her to regain her status as a living person and citizen of Halfmoon, yes?” Catra urged. Tao nodded along, making a note on a piece of parchment.

“Very well, I shall see to it. What about marriage? Are you planning on marrying Adora again?” He asked, a small smile on his lips.

Catra’s mouth went dry. She wanted to marry Adora again more than anything, but she wasn’t sure if that is what Adora wanted. They still hadn’t even had an opportunity to really discuss their last fight, although they apologized to each other.

“I’m not sure what Adora wants, I’d have to speak to her first. Marriage is complicated by matters with Bright Moon.” Catra hedged, looking out the window of Tao’s study.

“Which I am assuming you also wanted to discuss?” Tao verified.

“You would be correct oh wise councilman.” Catra stated lightheartedly.

“Well since Adora revealed her identity as She-ra it has spread like wildfire through all of Etheria,” Tao explained. “Bright Moon sent Glimmer a missive stating their understanding of the delicate matter given your kidnaping, but the Bright Moon council, in particular, is *most displeased*.” Tao put on a Bright Moon accent for the last two words, clearly channeling Norwyn’s mannerisms.

“What a surprise.” Catra rolled her eyes derisively.

“I think there is no chance to salvage the engagement with Glimmer.” He said plainly. “It would look too forced from both kingdoms. Besides, Halfmoon has been clamoring for their Queen to be reinstated to the throne.” Tao added. Catra smiled at that – the people truly loved Adora.

“What a pity, that my engagement with Glimmer is ruined.” Catra intoned, not upset in the least.

“Yes, I’m sure your majesty is simply heartbroken.” Tao rolled his eyes. Catra eyed her advisor.

“That still leaves the issue of our relationship with Bright Moo—we can’t afford to have them as an enemy. Can you work with Teela on some kind of diplomatic offer to stay in their good graces?” She asked. Tao nodded dipping his pen in his inkwell.

“Yes, Teela is very intimate with the inner workings of Bright Moon, I’m sure we can find a way to salvage something, although clearly, it wouldn't be the bond that uniting the two regents would have created.” Tao continued to write up some notes as he hummed to himself. A thought occurred to Catra.

“What if we find a way for Bow to marry Glimmer? Kill two birds with one stone?” Catra suggested, eyes alight with the possibility. “Let’s see if we can give Bow the status required to wed a Bright Moon royal. I’m sure the Bright Moon council will expect something like that, why not indulge them?” Catra’s ears twitch in excitement.

“Do you think that Bright Moon would allow it? They have fought against that union for years.” Tao raised an eyebrow.

“Not all of Bright Moon opposes the union. See if it’s possible, you leave the negotiation with Bright Moon to me. I think I can convince Angella to announce the engagement before it gets approved, making the council especially pressured to accept Bow as our representative.” Tao was impressed.

“You really are devious your majesty.” He commented. Catra’s face tightened.

“Speaking of someone who is actually devious. What of Percival?” She asked.

“Still in the dungeon-like the bilge rat deserves.” Tao’s face twisted in disgust and anger.

“Have we found out if he was working with anyone?” Catra’s tail jerked at the thought. Tao shook his head.

“He seemed to be working with two of his servants, but otherwise, he wasn’t in consort with anyone else.” He reassured. Catra sat next to him.

“I can’t believe there was a traitor under my own nose this whole time. While I was worried about the Horde in the furthest reaches of Etheria, they were here inside my very castle.” An involuntary shudder ran through Catra as she wrapped her tail around herself.

“Yes, it is unsettling to think about.” Tao agreed with a sigh. “Someone from the royal family no less.”

Tao stood up, clasping his hands together. Catra rested her head in her palm as she stared out to the mountains again.

“It just makes me wonder—was I so blind to what was happening in Halfmoon because I was too focused on the Princess Alliance?” It was a troubling thought. Tao gave Catra a weak smile and a shrug of his shoulders.

“That is a definite possibility. You are only one person Catra. You have a finite amount of attention to expend on things. You can’t be everywhere at once, no matter how much you might pretend to be omniscient.” Tao gives her a knowing look. Catra hums her understanding.

“Yes, that is something to think about. I’ll need to consider my priorities, lest something like this happens again.” Catra was unsettled by the lengths Percival was willing to go to gain her throne and more importantly, how blind she was to his designs.

“How will you punish him?” Tao asked.

“I’m going to speak with him, see what he has to say for himself. Then I’ll decide.” Catra would act quickly. She wanted to put the betrayal behind her as quickly as possible.

A quick knock came at the door. Catra and Tao looked at each other questioningly then glanced at the door. Before Catra could reach the doorframe, a familiar voice sounded from behind it.

"I know you said two hours—and I'm not coming in I swear! —But at least two kingdoms have sent dignitaries to wish you well health. I thought you might want to know. I'm not sure how long we can keep them waiting." Adora's voice is muffled through the door and Catra can't help but melt a little at the lengths Adora would go to heed her orders.

"Adora, just open the door, you might be following the letter of what I asked but not the spirit." She rolled her eyes the moment that Adora came into view shyly standing at the edge of the room as if expecting to be scolded for being there.

"Escort me to our guests?" Catra offered up her arm and Adora happily took it. "Who all is there?"

"Representatives from Salineas, Dryl, and Plumeria." Catra hummed her acknowledgment.

Catra's eight shifted in a disorienting way when Adora stopped them ten paces from the throne room turning Catra to face her. She leaned down and captured Catra's lips in a searing kiss. She tried to pull away, but Catra tugged Adora down by her shirt and pressed up to her toes, maintaining the contact.

"What's all this about?" Catra asked breathlessly. Adora's eyes are full of affection but they are also blown wide with desire.

"I just missed you. Wanted to remind you that I'm not only good for worrying and hovering." Adora grins unabashedly as she draws circles on one of Catra's hips veering off to her thigh.

"Why don't you explain to me in more detail what else you are good for?" Catra pressed closer, chasing Adora's strong fingers. Adora tutted, dragging her hands up to a more respectable place —Catra's waist. The warmth of Adora's palms was equal parts comforting and distracting.

“Recall we have a meeting to get to Catra.” Adora’s voice is all fake propriety and innocence.

“You’ll pay for this later,” Catra promised in a low hiss driven by frustration. Adora grinned as she resumed the more formal hold to escort Catra to the throne room door.

“That’s what I’m hoping for your majesty.” She whispered quickly against the shell of Catra’s ear right before the doors opened, effectively getting the last word. For now.

“I’ll be at the door the whole time.” The muscles in Adora’s jaw jumped as she glared down the hall that contained Percival’s cell. Her eyes glowed blue. Catra put a hand on her arm.

“Adora, this is a bit excessive.” It had been two weeks since Catra returned to Halfmoon. Adora was much better about leaving Catra be, but she put her foot down on this.

“I almost lost you because of him. I won’t allow you anywhere near him without me.” Adora argued a finger pointed towards the hallway.

“Fine. Stay here then—do not come in unless it is actually necessary.” Catra warned. “That’s an order.”

Adora nodded, although her eyes were still glued down the hallway as if she could hurt Percival from this distance. Catra squeezed her arm and Adora’s eyes snapped to Catra.

“Yes, love.” Adora assented verbally, although her tone sounded anything but compliant. Catra placed a soft kiss on Adora’s cheek, which did nothing to relax the warrior.

“I’ll be back soon.” She could feel Adora’s eyes on her back as she walked down the long corridor. Catra stepped in front of Percival’s cell alone. He was shackled to the back wall, looking disheveled but not very different from normal.

“When I said that you would be King over my dead body, I didn’t think you would take it as a recommendation,” Catra said cooly as she took in her cousin. Percival sneered, turning his nose as if he smelled something vile.

“Yes well, seems I’ve failed, and you, great King, are victorious once again,” he mocked eyes full of hatred. Catra wasted no time and asked what she truly wanted to know.

“Why did you do this? I know there is no love lost between us, but this is excessive, even for you.” Catra searched his gaze, looking for answers there. Percival stared back aloofly, his tail occasionally jerking in the restricted space it had.

“You are leading Halfmoon into the ground Catra. I did what I had to in order to save it.” His voice was measured, not an ounce of regret in it. Catra felt her hackles rise.

“You’re wrong. You are quite ready to take Halfmoon underground, undo a quarter century’s progress in the name of what? Superiority?” Catra scoffed.

“You are arrogant, and you think you know best. That will be your downfall.” Percival warned.

“Funny, I could say the same thing about you.” She gestured to her cousin’s shackled wrists. Percival shook his head slowly.

“You and I, we are two sides of a coin. Destiny just seems to flip in your favor Catra—but remember this. Your luck will run out and someone will be there to pick up the pieces when you go from Halfmoon’s beloved King to its wretched dictator.” Percival tried to sound ominous and wise, but he missed his mark.

“You know, I’ve decided your sentence,” Catra said in a conversational tone. She saw Percival flinch away from her, trying to unite with the stone wall at his back. “I’m stripping you of all of your royal titles—you will no longer be in the line of succession for Halfmoon’s throne.” She informed him. His eyes widen.

“I suppose that’s to be expected.” He groused, attempting to be stoic as he avoided eye contact.

“Yes, can’t have a treasonous conspirator in the line of succession. I’m also erasing all references to you as heir in any of the archival documentation. When Halfmoon’s history is studied, you’ll only be known as a traitor.” Percival’s face twisted in anger. “Or maybe, you won’t be known at all. As far as coups go, this one was particularly disappointing. It’ll be a footnote if you’re lucky.”

“You can’t just erase me!” He protested loudly. Catra pretended she didn’t hear his interruption.

“As for criminal sanctions, you will have a trial. The range of punishment for kidnapping a regent spans from banishment to execution. So, best of luck with that.” Catra closed in on Percival’s face putting a sharp claw on his chest. “You might be right about me and my luck, cousin. But *you* remember *this* Percival. I might be bested by someone one day, but it will never be you.” She hissed.

She heard Percival’s piercing scream as she quickly exited his cell. Adora stood by the door, her brow up to her hairline.

“What did you say to him?” She demanded, looking over Catra to see if she was damaged in any way. Catra shrugged.

“The truth. Not my fault he didn’t like it.” Catra said curtly as she tried to still her tail. Although, she didn’t let it show, some of the things Percival said rattled her.

A few days later, Adora found Catra in her robes, hair still damp from her bath. Adora’s eyes darkened at the sight of her covered and yet so exposed. Catra turned to look at Adora, concern instead of desire on her face.

“Adora, we haven’t truly discussed what happened in that fight. Before I was kidnapped.” Catra clarified. Adora tried to cover her disappointment with a cough. Catra smirked as she took in Adora’s

demeanor for the first time. “Not what you were hoping for tonight?” Catra teased as she fluffed up her robe. Adora flushed as she caught Catra’s robe slipping off of one of her shoulders.

“Not exactly, but we should probably speak on it now, yes?” Adora said, looking away from her love for a moment to collect herself. Catra sobered.

“We can’t keep putting it off like this. I can start if you want.” Catra offered, suddenly nervous. She nodded her acceptance, training her eyes on Catra’s face. “I shouldn’t have made light of your imprisonment in the Crystal Castle or your duty as She-ra. I know it is as important, if not more important, than my duty to Halfmoon.”

She reached out and grabbed Adora’s hand, clutching it close. She suddenly felt more naked under Adora’s concerned stare now than she ever had laid bare in front of her.

“It was coming from a place of frustration. I felt so lonely—far away from you after you had just returned to me—and it seemed that you were doing just fine. You never complained about having to be far from me or having to be She-ra you were just grateful to help—always so good.” Catra could feel her eyes filled with tears, but she pushed forward. “When it looked like I would be forced to marry Glimmer, it felt like the walls were closing in on our time together and you just didn’t care.” Catra finished in a whisper.

Adora squeezed her hand back, rubbing her thumb across her palm.

“I wasn’t doing fine Catra.” Adora looked away but held on tight. “I’ve had to do unspeakable things—war crimes really—to garner the success we have. I think a lot about all the men and women I kill, the families that will always be torn asunder because of what I chose to do with my power.”

She pulled away from Catra to look down at her hands, disgusted by their force.

“Sometimes I feel like these are the hands of a monster.” She held them out in front of her, palm side up looking at every callus and scar. A deep grunt welled in the back of her throat. “I’ve killed, slaughtered with these hands.”

Catra reached out, carefully threading their fingers together. She brought Adora’s hand to her lips, letting her fingertip linger there.

“You’ve loved me with these hands.” Catra softly reminded her, lips brushing against the very hands they mentioned. Adora lets her hand trail over Catra’s face gently.

“I don’t feel worthy to touch you with them,” Adora confessed, a burden she never meant to share with Catra. “I never have.”

Catra looked as of about to protest, but Adora moved her hand to touch her lips again, stilling them.

“I clung to my duty because it was the only way I could justify what I was doing. I didn’t want to think of a way for you to bypass what I thought was your duty when I couldn’t consider the same thing for myself.” Adora admitted in a shameful whisper. “If you could be true to yourself and perform your duties, what did that mean for me? Was I taking the easy way out?” Adora asked herself.

She sighed and turned to look Catra in the eyes.

“I should have believed in you. Believed in your ability to lead regardless of who your allies are. Or at least helped you think of solutions, even if ultimately, they failed. I wasn’t a good partner to you.” Adora said looking at Catra solemnly.

“I don’t think either of us was our best at that moment.” Catra allowed as leaned her head against Adora’s shoulder. A moment of silence stretched between them as they soaked in everything they said to each other.

“So, what happens now?” Adora asks. Catra looked back up into her eyes.

“Well, what do you want Adora?” The question slipped from Catra unbidden. Adora steps closer, her answer instantaneous.

“You Catra. It’s always been you, even with everything that has happened to us.” Adora took a deep breath. “I want you to formally end your betrothal with Glimmer. I want to be at your side at Alliance meetings, not because Etheria chose me as She-ra, but because you choose me. Adora.” Her voice shook with emotion. “More than anything Catra, I want to be your choice. Always. Just as you are mine.”

Adora placed her hand on Catra’s cheek. Catra holds that hand, keeping her close.

“You are my choice, Adora. You are the only choice I always pick, no matter the odds or circumstances.” Catra leaned forward, touching her forehead to Adora’s. “You are worthy of my love, regardless of what you might think. We will figure out a way out of this war together.” Catra vowed.

For the first time, Adora felt that she could help Catra keep that promise.

The room was blazing with excitement and energy that it hadn’t seen since before Catra’s kidnapping. Everyone had stopped to chat with her before the meeting started, all exceptionally glad to see her return. Now, the meeting had begun, but it seemed the well wishes were not yet over.

“I would like to welcome King Catra back to the Alliance!” Scorpia announced. It wasn’t the first Alliance meeting to occur since Catra’s disappearance, but it was the first one she joined in person since then.

“Thank you I appreciate it. I am honored to be back in your graces. I heard that the meetings I missed were quite eventful.” Her eyes cut to Adora who smiled at her. Adora sat as the Princess of Power—not as Catra’s consort—but she did not tap into She-ra

during the meeting. “In any event, thank you all so much for rescuing me. I am grateful to be back.”

Catra smiled at the group. The Alliance waited for Catra to continue speaking.

“When I was trapped in that cell, I thought about a great many things. I’ve realized that the Alliance cannot be successful if it falls apart when one member is gone. This time it was a kidnapping, but anything could happen to any one of us: sickness, an accident, a revolt.” Catra looked around the room leaning back into her seat. “We have been successful as an Alliance but look at what I let happen in my own Kingdom. That is the price of being central to this operation.”

A concerned murmur swept amongst the representatives, as Catra confirmed what everyone suspected and Adora accused—that Percival betrayed her to the Horde.

“It was wrong of me to try to have undue influence over the Alliance, I realize that now. I owe each of you an apology. I know now that we are stronger if we work together as equals, not with one of us holding the reigns.” Catra explained. “I propose that we amend the bylaws and create an institution that will outlast us all.”

The room is silent for a long moment, as the Alliance members all look at each other, clearly not expecting this type of announcement from Catra.

“How is amending the bylaws, a document none of us have even looked at, mind you, going to fix this,” Mermista asked archly as she crossed her arms.

“If we have bylaws that we can look to, we have an outside reference to establish the decision-making process. We can act without having to look to one person for all the answers. No one person should be indispensable.” Catra ardently advocated.

“We are in the middle of a war that we are about to win. What we do now works.” Netossa noted. “Is this a good use of our time?”

Her expression seemed to indicate that she doubted that was the case.

"The best use of our time is something that makes us effective long term. I'm sure you can see the military value in that." Catra raised an eyebrow. She gestured to the group. "I know that there was a backslide when I was captured. What if the Horde assassinated me—which they likely would if they get their hands on me again."

A deep growl rumbled and shook the table, surprising Catra out of her debate with Netossa. She glanced over to Adora whose eyes are bathing the table in an ominous blue hue.

"I'd love to see them try." Adora spit out. Catra rolled her eyes.

"Not the time or the point, Adora." Catra stared meaningfully at her former Queen. Adora crossed her arms, but the glowing blue slowly petered out.

"Catra is right that we need to be bale to make decisions as a group and not rely on one or two people," Adora admitted. "I've been in the Alliance long enough to know that all of the leaders presented here are capable and have their own gifts and talents we could put to good use. I think this would only make us more resilient in the face of the Horde threat."

"Isn't she your King? Don't you have to side with her?" Mermista eyed Adora with distaste. She held the Queen's stare.

"No. I'm my own person and although I would gladly lay down my life for Catra, I am here of my own authority as the princess of Power, and I have my own opinion." Adora stated calculatingly. Mermista averted her gaze first, biting her lip in thought.

"Okay, say Catra isn't unofficially in charge anymore. Why can't someone else do it?"

"We would run into the same problem. If one person is most influential, they would become a target." Surprisingly, Perfuma

spoke out this time. Catra jumped into the fray again.

“That is exactly why we need this reform. It is easy to rely on the easy way to do things, to consolidate power as expeditiously as possible. But we need to be ready not just for the Horde. For any threat to Etheria. For peace that will outlast us. Who is with me?”

Catra stood from her chair, staring down at the leaders who she had convinced to give her power, hoping she could convince them one more time to take it back. One hand after the other, a majority of the Alliance voted in favor of amending the bylaws.

“How did the Alliance meeting go?” Glimmer’s eyes shone in excitement, hopeful that Catra could sway the council.

Glimmer was unable to go, given that they officially broke off their engagement the week before. She was due back in Bright Moon any day now.

“It went well. We are rewriting bylaws. I could really use your help figuring it out.” Catra looked at Glimmer hopefully.

“Well, I don’t think I will be available, but I’d love to. I’m going to miss going to Alliance meetings.” Catra sent Glimmer a secretive smile.

“Don’t be so sure of your unavailability, your majesty.” She singsonged. She turned and looked at Glimmer more seriously, although humor still danced behind her split eyes. “Glimmer, I have a proposal for you. I think you’ll like it more than my last one.”

“What, you don’t want me to feel like a jilted lover?” Glimmer cracked as she raised an eyebrow, hand on her hip.

“I sent Angella a letter last week formally asking for her to suspend Bow from all of his remaining Bright Moon duties and yesterday, Bow pledged his fealty to Halfmoon as my knight and citizen of Halfmoon. He gained a dukedom here in Halfmoon. It

makes him twelfth in the line of succession." Catra informed her casually, taking in Glimmer's reaction. "Eleventh once we officially scrub the stain that is Percival out of the line." She added.

"Why are you doing this for Bow. He is coming back with me to Bright Moon, he can't look after a dukedom here." Glimmer pointed out slowly, confused. Catra couldn't help the way her ear twitch as she smiled at her friend.

"If you are amenable, I think marrying my duke would be a suitable marriage that will both meet Bright Moon's laws and will cement the partnership between Bright Moon and Halfmoon. A pretty neat solution if I say so myself." Glimmer gaped at Catra's words.

Catra's gaze moved past Glimmer to something behind her. She turned around to find Bow stood there, flowers in hand looking more nervous than she had ever seen him. She walked all the way up to him, eyes shining with tears.

"My mother will allow this?" Glimmer whispers, eyes never leaving Bow. Catra smiled wide.

"I spoke to your mother about the idea, and she is willing to announce the engagement without council approval, now that the marriage would meet the letter of the law." Catra walked around the couple, her tail swishing to and fro. "It seemed this whole time she was looking for a way to allow you and Bow to be together. She is willing to face the council's wrath as long as she can follow the letter of Bright Moon law." Catra noted.

Glimmer barely looked at Catra during her explanation, a small nod the only acknowledgment she received. Her hand shook as she reached out to hold the flowers that Bow gave her. He cleared his throat, eyes only for Glimmer as he spoke.

"Glimmer, I dreamt of being allowed to do this since my father brought me to the castle to learn history lessons with the princess. My life truly started the day you told me you wanted me

the same way.” Bow reached out and held Glimmer’s cheek. “I’ve thought so many times of asking you to run away with me. But that’s not who you are, and I could never keep you from what you were born to do.”

She took in a shuddering breath, tears finally spilling over as her hands covered her mouth.

“Glimmer, the road has never been easy for us. I don’t expect that this would be either. But there is no one I would rather take this journey with than you.” The air buzzed with silent anticipation. “Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon, will you please do me the honor of marrying me?”

Bow’s arm shook as he held out his token, one of Angella’s coronation earrings, another symbol of her blessing. Glimmer ran straight into Bow’s arms, almost knocking him over in the process. She cried as she yelled “yes” over and over kissing any place of him she could reach. Catra sighed in contentment as she took in the happy couple.

“Adora is going to be upset she missed this for her military strategy meeting.” Glimmer noted once she calmed down, arms still around Bow, pressing him close. Catra shook her head.

“She will, but she will be happier that you both get to be together as you should have always been allowed. Congratulations.” Catra beamed at her friends.

“I’m so excited to plan our wedding!” Glimmer looked about to burst, bouncing on her toes.

“I’m personally looking forward to Norwyn fainting from the righteous outrage.” Catra suggested with a raised eyebrow. The three of them laughed.

Another day, another Halfmoon council war meeting it seemed, although Catra’s tail twitched in excitement from the updates she had for her advisors today.

“At the last status meeting, the Alliance confirmed that a grand majority of the Horde’s movements have been contained to the Scorpioni Kingdom with only one or two skirmishes spilling over into Plumeria. The Norther Reach officially has no known Horde presence.” Happiness rolled over Catra as she delivered the news. There was a smattering of applause from Halfmoon’s council. “Adora is currently in Plumeria at a military strategy meeting with the council of Etherian generals. She will bring back a report which should give us a better idea of what our next moves will be to hopefully stop the Horde for good.”

“Are we going to continue our discussions about reparations and military trials for when the war is over?” A magicat with vibrant green eyes asked.

“Excellent question, councilwoman Melendy. I think that would be a prudent step to take, but I worry that it will be declaring victory too soon.” Catra cautioned gently. She liked Melendy’s enthusiasm. “I will listen to what the Etherian generals have to say about their estimated timeline for the end of the war.”

Melendy nodded and continued taking notes. It seemed that now the war would be won, it was a matter of when not if.

“Next week, I propose we have a council meeting that only discusses Halfmoon’s internal affairs. Please be ready to discuss citizen grievances and project ideas. This meeting is adjourned.” Catra sounded the ceremonial bell. She caught Melendy before she left the room. Melendy bowed deeply before her regent.

“My liege.” Catra waved her off.

“Catra is fine. I wanted a quick word.” Melendy’s tail waved softly behind her.

“I know you are passionate about the rebuilding of Etheria and finding a kind of justice we can all live with after the war. I want you to continue to think of these things and come up with ideas because we will need them when this war is over.” Catra

encouraged. “I’m very proud of the way you have performed on the council in your first six months. Keep up the good work.”

“Thank you so much!” Melendy beamed, hugging her notebook close to her chest.

“Of course, you are dismissed.” Melendy happily bobbed away. Catra scanned the council room, only to find that Teela and Adam were still sitting, chatting together.

“Melendy has done a tremendous job replacing Percival on the council,” Teela called out to Catra.

“Anyone could do a better job than Percival.” Adam snorted in disgust, one of his fists clenching.

“Well, we don’t have to worry about him anymore.” The jury in Percival’s trial sentenced him to lifetime imprisonment, a rare punishment in Halfmoon. In a sense, he got exactly what he wanted—to live underground in the Halfmoon caverns.

“So, the real question Catra—” Adam smirked “—is when are you going to be my sister-in-law again?” Catra felt her fur fluffing up along her back. He had been continually pestering Catra on the topic of marriage for the last few months, always away from Adora’s eyes and ears.

“I don’t know, when will you start courting Teela?” Adam reddened but his smile grew wider. He waggled his eyebrows. Catra stared at him. “Seriously? Teela, you gave in?”

Catra spun around and looked at the woman in question. Teela rolled her eyes.

“If anything, I’m courting him, your highness. If I waited for him to approach me, I’d be an old maid before he worked up the courage.” Adam sputtered, outraged by the accusation.

“You know, Adam does ask an interesting question. When will you make Adora your Queen again?” Tao asked, smiling warmly at

Catra.

“Tao when did you even come in? And how did you even hear that?” Adam stared wide-eyed. Tao flicked his two ears very purposefully.

“You speak quite loudly Adam.” Adam blushed as Teela laughed at him.

“Adam might be an idiot, but he has a point. We all want to know, your highness.” Teela raised an eyebrow at Catra.

“You three are pests, you know?” Catra’s tail lashed behind her. Six months had passed since Catra was kidnapped by the Horde and her relationship with Adora could not be better. She had to grudgingly admit it was a fair question. She sighed.

“I don’t know, there is so much going on all the time I feel like I still barely get time to see her, let alone think about wedding her.” Adora still had duties as She-ra, although they were more tempered than when she first joined the Alliance.

“But I’m sure you have thought about it haven’t you?” Tao needled, smirking at Catra. She flushed and she could feel her tail lashing behind her even faster than before. She would never admit how much she thought of it, how her heart longed for Adora to belong to her in all ways known on Etheria.

“We haven’t talked about getting remarried since the first morning she arrived at Halfmoon. That was almost a year ago now. I’m not sure if she wants to get married again.” Catra grabbed her tail in her hand to stop it from jerking. Adam snorted.

“That’s stupid. Adora is so in love with you she would marry you at any given moment.” Teela rolled her eyes.

“Have you talked to Adora about getting remarried?” Teela asked him crossly. Catra’s palms began to sweat.

“No, but I know my sister.” Adam huffed. Teela flicked Adam’s forehead.

“I don’t want her to do it because I want to, I want her to want to get remarried.” Catra pointed out.

“All you need to do is ask, young one. Wouldn’t be the first time you have had this discussion with Adora.” Tao states evenly.

“It feels different this time. Last time, it was the only way to be together in a lot of ways. Now she is a princess in her own right, and she doesn’t need me to share my crown for her to be here with me.” Catra explained.

Maybe Adora didn’t want to get married again yet. Catra’s doubts called out maybe she didn’t want to get married at all.

“Talk to my sister and figure it out Cat.” Adam advised. Catra left her troublemaking council members to find some peace and quiet.

Adora arrived at Halfmoon absolutely spent and so happy to finally spend an uninterrupted week with Catra. She happily walked the halls of Halfmoon looking for her love.

She found Catra hunched over her desk reading. Adora tried to sneak in, but Catra’s ear immediately swiveled in her direction. Still, Catra let Adora have her fun and pretended that she hadn’t noticed her. She trailed one finger up Catra’s spine, delighting in her shiver.

“You know, if you stay hunched over like that, you’ll become even shorter than you already are.” Adora mused. Catra turned and launched herself into Adora’s arms, nuzzling and scent marking her cheeks. Adora giggled holding her love close.

“I’m so happy you are here. Two weeks is truly too long for you to be gone.” Catra griped as she tried to get closer still. Adora chuckled and crushed her to her chest, feeling a purr rumble through her.

“I agree. I can’t wait till this war is over and we won’t have to be apart even for a few days at a time.” Adora sighed longingly. Catra looked up at Adora something odd in her eyes. Adora stared back, unsure what was happening.

“Adora, do you not want to get married?” Adora laughed at how unexpected the question was.

“Dearest, what are you talking about?” Adora asked gently, truly befuddled. Catra’s gaze was uncertain as one of her fangs poked out.

“You mentioned courting me eons ago Adora, and you haven’t done or said anything about it again. It makes it seem like maybe you aren’t interested in being married again.” Catra explained, ears pinned back. Adora stared, still catching up with the sudden topic change.

“Catra. My love. You are the absolute best thing that has ever happened to me, and I would marry you every day I am alive if that is what it took to be by your side.” Adora consoled, her heart swelling at the thought of being able to marry Catra again. Catra is far from comforted, her tail swinging wildly behind her.

“That’s the point! I don’t want you to marry me because that’s how you stay by my side, like last time. I only want to remarry if we both want it.” Catra stared Adora down, a flash of anger and helplessness pulsing through her.

“Like last time?” Adora echoed, tilting her head to the side in confusion. Adora placed her hands on either side of Catra’s head and soundly kissed her. “Catra, I married you because nothing could make me prouder than to be by your side. Your partner in all things. Your wife. I did not marry you because I felt an obligation.”

Adora kissed her again, long and slow, so there would be no mistaking her next words.

“I very desperately wanted to marry you.” Adora breathed. Catra relaxed some but she still eyed Adora mistrustfully. “I still dream about being married to you one day. It is the only thing missing from my life that I long for.”

“Then why haven’t we talked about it.” Catra let out in frustration, all but whining.

“The only reason I haven’t broached the topic is that I thought it would be prudent to wait until Bow and Glimmer were married. Not steal their thunder as it were.” Adora gave Catra a wry grin as Catra blushed furiously.

“Oh.” Catra genuine surprise colored her voice. Adora pressed Catra’s forehead to hers.

“You also hadn’t mentioned anything, so I wasn’t sure where you stood on the matter my liege. Do you wish to be married to me?” Adora whispered, holding her breath as she stared into her love’s eyes.

“More than anything.” Catra breathed. Adora beamed at her.

“Then the moment Bow and Glimmer have finalized their union, be prepared to be courted and wooed as you never have before,” Adora warned placing silly kisses along Catra’s cheeks. She giggled at the sensation.

“I can’t wait.” Catra and Adora hold each other for a few moments longer.

“We are calling this meeting of the Alliance to order,” Perfuma stated, running down the agenda for the day. “Netossa and Adora will be discussing our—hopefully—final military campaign in the Scorpioni Kingdom, Catra and Glimmer are putting together a rebuilding committee, and Mermista will provide a report on the finalization of our new bylaws.”

Perfuma and the other Alliance members turned to Adora who jumped right into her report, explaining the battle plans she had been fretting over for the last month.

Catra saw Glimmer on the other side of the table with Bow at her side, finally representing Bright Moon as she always wanted. Adora reached out and squeezed Catra's hand as she continued to explain, pointing to the map in front of her.

"If we get this right, they will have nowhere to run. We have them where we want them. We just need to capitalize on it." Adora finished explaining. Catra watched her with soft eyes, proud of how far she had come as a strategist.

Recently most of the war news the Alliance received was positive, but now, Catra knew it in her bones: the Horde would meet its end before the year was out. And Catra would do it all with Adora by her side.

Chapter End Notes

> That concludes this fic! There are still some opened ended bits as you can see, so if there is demand for an epilogue I'm open to writing one! Let me know in the comments if there is anything in particular you'd like to see. I would also like to know your general thoughts on the fic-as always, comments and kudos are incredibly appreciated.
>
> P.S. Melendy is based on Melendy Britt, who voiced She-ra, the Magicat Queen, and a bunch of other characters in the 1985 She-ra.
>
> Next Week: If you liked my superhero AU (the Masks and Mistakes universe) you are in for a treat because I will be posting a one-shot for that universe! Catra and Adora, our favorite superheroes, are moving in together. The endnote on that one will have more information on my upcoming plans for the MM Universe (hint: there are a lot of plans lol).

The week after I will be posting my divorce AU, another multi-chapter fic. This fic is very close to my heart because it is the first piece of fanfiction I started writing for the She-ra fandom and is the whole reason I post on AO3 in the first place. I've spent a lot of hours writing and editing it, so if it sounds like something you might be interested in, I'd love you to take a peek at it when I post it :)

Thank you all for the support, it means a lot to be able to get feedback on my writing every week :)

End Notes

This ended up being a long chapter because I wanted to set up the background and the fact that Adora is not in fact dead lol. This fic will be very heavy on politicking (as you likely noted in this chapter) but there will be more plot happening now that everything is set up.

Note that Percival, Tao, and Cloudfoot are from the 80's version of She-ra and Adam and Teela are from He-man.

I'm pretty set on it being six chapters so I will be posting a new chapter weekly until we reach the conclusion!

Next Week: the Princess Alliance meets She-ra.

As always comments/kudos drive me to write and post content! I really enjoy hearing what you have to say :)

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!